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Government of Bharat
Committed to Nari Shakti Vandan
#NariShaktiVandan
CBC 22201/13/0005/2627
33% reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies, ensuring participation in nation-building

Permanent Commission for women in the Armed Forces
Atleast 1 Woman Director in 48% of the total recognized startups in India

PIONEER IN SHORT

CONGRESS VETERAN MOHSINA KIDWAI DIES

Veteran Congress leader and former Union minister Mohsina Kidwai passed away on Wednesday at the age of 94, marking the end of a distinguished political career spanning over six decades. She died at a hospital in Noida after age-related ailments and was laid to rest at Nizamuddin, with Rahul Gandhi among those attending her last rites. A close associate of former prime ministers Indira Gandhi and Rajiv Gandhi, Kidwai held key portfolios including health, labour, and rural development. She was also a long-serving parliamentarian, having been a member of both the Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha, and a prominent figure in the Congress Working Committee. Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge described her passing as a "profound loss," while Priyanka Gandhi Vadra praised her as a trailblazer who inspired generations of women. Shashi Tharoor called her a "titan" of the party who embodied dignity and wisdom. Beginning her political journey in Uttar Pradesh in 1960, Kidwai rose steadily through the ranks, becoming one of the few women leaders to hold top organisational roles.

West Asia: US, Israel, Iran agree to conditional, two-week, ceasefire

Easter bunny seen behind US President Donald Trump AP

IRAN'S 10-POINT PLAN: KEY DEMANDS

1 Guarantee of non-aggression by both sides and acceptance of Iran's uranium enrichment
2 Controlled passage through the Strait of Hormuz in coordination with Iran's Armed Forces
3 Ending the war on all fronts, including against Hezbollah in Lebanon
4 Withdrawal of US combat forces from bases and deployment points in the region
5 Termination of all resolutions of the UN Security Council and the Board of Governors
6 Establishment of a secure transit protocol in the Strait of Hormuz under agreed terms
7 Full payment of damages to Iran, according to estimates
8 Removal of all primary and secondary sanctions against Iran
9 Release of all blocked Iranian properties and assets abroad
10 Approval of these conditions through a binding UN Security Council resolution

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

The United States, Iran and Israel have agreed to a two-week ceasefire following a last-minute diplomatic push led by Pakistan, with both sides set to begin negotiations in Islamabad even as differences persist over the scope of the truce.

US President Donald Trump said on Tuesday, April 7 that he had agreed "to suspend the bombing and attack of Iran for a period of two weeks" after speaking with Pakistan's leadership, which has been mediating between Washington and Tehran and had sought a pause in hostilities.

Iran indicated that the agreement could enable it to formalize a policy of charging vessels transiting through the Strait of Hormuz, a vital global oil route. However, specifics remain unclear, including how such a measure would be implemented, whether shipping companies would consider the passage safe, and whether other countries have agreed to this condition.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

INDIA BACKS TRUCE

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

India on Wednesday welcomed the ceasefire in West Asia, expressing hope that the development would pave the way for lasting peace while reiterating that dialogue and diplomacy remain essential to end the conflict.

In an official statement, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said, "We welcome the ceasefire reached and hope that it will lead to a lasting peace in West Asia. As we have continuously advocated earlier, de-escalation, dialogue and diplomacy are essential to bring an early end to the ongoing conflict."

EAM chairing a meeting on at the MEA PTI

The government its consistent position of pursuing peaceful resolution through diplomatic channels and highlighted the wider global impact of the crisis.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Oil prices fall globally, LPG disruptions persist in India

RAJESH KUMAR/ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

The announcement of a conditional, two-week ceasefire between the US, Israel and Iran on Wednesday has sent a wave of relief through global energy markets with global crude oil benchmarks like Brent plummeting by nearly 16 per cent to below $93 per barrel.

In a joint inter-ministerial press conference, the Union Government said Liquefied Petroleum Gas (LPG) supply continues to be affected by the prevailing geopolitical situation while sufficient stocks of petrol and diesel are being maintained.

India is the world's third-largest energy consumer and fourth-biggest gas user. Imports account for about 88 per cent of the country's crude oil, around half of its natural gas requirements and roughly 60 per cent of its LPG needs. More than half of these crude imports, about 40 per cent of natural gas and as much as 85per cent -90 per cent of LPG shipments, sourced from Gulf countries, transit through the Strait of Hormuz — one of the world's most critical energy corridors — which was closed by Iran as violence in the region escalated.

Currently, a large number of tankers laden with crude, condensate, and refined products are stranded inside the Middle East Gulf, waiting to exit due to disruptions in the strait. For India, while crude supplies could normalise in two-three weeks, if the ceasefire continues, LNG supplies may not resume immediately as it will take two weeks to just start liquefaction facilities, depending upon the extent of damage caused by the attacks. It is learnt that 16-17 Indian vessels carrying crude oil and LPG are still in the Strait of Hormuz.

The Strait of Hormuz as seen from the International Space Station WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

With shipping expected to normalise, delayed LPG cargo can now start reaching India. At the same time, new shipments can be scheduled more predictably.

Indian consumers, however, shouldn't expect an immediate price cut at the petrol pumps. Domestic Oil Marketing Companies typically revise retail rates based on a 15-day rolling average of international prices. Currently, petrol remains steady at ₹94.77 and diesel at ₹87.67 in Delhi.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

The ByStander

CASH FOR VOTE ROW ROCKS KERALA

Political tensions escalated in Kerala on Wednesday, a day before Assembly polling, as parties traded allegations of voter inducement and Model Code of Conduct violations across multiple constituencies. The Congress accused BJP candidate Sobha Surendran of being "caught red-handed" distributing cash to voters in Palakkad. Surendran denied the charge, calling it "fabricated" and politically motivated, and said she would file a police complaint. A video cited by the Congress allegedly showed money being offered to an elderly woman, though she denied receiving cash, stating she had only sought financial help for medicines. The Election Commission's flying squad investigated the incident and submitted a preliminary report, with further inquiry underway.

RBI keeps rates steady; markets, rupee gain

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Reserve Bank of India (RBI) kept its key policy rate unchanged on Wednesday, adopting a wait-and-watch stance as policymakers assessed the fallout from the six-week Iran conflict on energy supplies, inflation and growth.

The BSE Sensex, meanwhile, jumped 2,946 points to close at 77,562.90 on Wednesday, its best single-day gain in five years after a conditional ceasefire was announced in West Asia announced a two-week ceasefire. The index hit an intra-day high of 77,635.54. As a result of the massive recovery, investors' wealth swelled by ₹16.25 lakh crore.

Simultaneously, the rupee too gained for the fourth consecutive session on Wednesday and ended at 92.58 per U.S. dollar, up 0.5 per cent from its close of 93.0075 on Tuesday. The currency opened stronger at 92.64 and briefly moved above 92.50 during the session. The currency has gained 2.4 per cent so far in April.

RBI said "excessive speculation" on the rupee prompted surprise actions on the currency front in the last fortnight, but clarified that its measures will not remain forever.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra addressing the press after the announcing the first bi-monthly monetary policy for the current fiscal in Mumbai PTI

CEC Gyanesh Kumar with Election Commissioners SS Sandhu and Vivek Joshi PTI

Tempers flare at TMC, ECI meet

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi

In a fresh political storm ahead of Assembly polls in West Bengal, a meeting between the Trinamool Congress (TMC) and the Election Commission of India (ECI) on Wednesday morning ended on an acrimonious note.

A TMC delegation of Rajya Sabha leader Derek O'Brien, deputy leader Sagarika Ghose, MPs Saket Gokhale and Menaka Guruswamy, was meeting the full bench of ECI as amid charges of disenfranchisements after the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls in West Bengal and allegations of the poll body having a "tacit understanding" with the BJP.

ECI sources accused O'Brien of shouting at the election commissioners and alleged that he asked the CEC not to speak.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

HDFC Bank's ₹54,315 crore large defaulter load

J GOPIKRISHNAN ■ New Delhi

Among the major private banks, HDFC Bank is in the third position of large defaulters list with very few big defaulters. As per the data available with TransUnion CIBIL, up to February 2026, HDFC Bank has large defaulter dues of ₹54,315 crore with 4,914 recovery cases pending.

The biggest defaulter of the bank is Delhi-based Feedback Energy Distribution and its linked firm, Feedback Infra, with total dues of ₹1,876 crore. Both the companies took 17 loans in total from the bank and now is facing insolvency cases. Second biggest defaulter is Tamil Nadu-based Sree Rengaraj Ispat Industries with a dues of ₹1,764 crore, through 10 loans.

Kolkata-based Riverbank Developers is the third biggest defaulter with ₹1,572 crore in dues, followed by Karvy Stock Broking (₹1,558 crore), Mumbai-based Tycoons Avanti Projects (₹1.085 crore), Himachal Pradesh based and Delhi registered Indian Technomac (₹1,024 crore) and Noida based Daewoo Motors Indian Limited with a dues of ₹1,023 crore to HDFC bank through 14 loans.

Other major defaulters of HDFC Bank in the range of ₹600 crore to ₹1,000 crore are : Cuttack based Gupta Power Infrastructure (₹976 crore), Mumbai based Tridhaatu Ventures (₹903 crore), Bengaluru based Camson Bio Technologies (₹854 crore) and Faridabad based CMI Limited (₹758 crore). All these companies are now under insolvency or liquidation process.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

The Pioneer Exclusive

LARGE DEFAULTERS OF HDFC BANK

- Feedback Energy Distribution
- Sree Rengaraj Ispat Industries
- Riverbank Developers
- Karvy Stock Broking
- Tycoons Avanti Projects
- Indian Technomac
- Daewoo Motors India
- Gupta Power Infrastructure
- Tridhaatu Ventures
- Camson Bio Technologies
- CMI Limited

Total- ₹ 54,315 Crores

Government doubles LPG supply for migrant workers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Delhi Government will launch a special outreach initiative to improve access to cooking fuel for migrant labourers, following a decision to double the allocation of 5 kg free trade LPG cylinders under the migrant category. As per an allocation order dated April 7, the daily availability of these cylinders has been increased from 684 to 1,368. The move follows approval by the Government of India for a 100 per cent increase in allocation under this category.

Officials said the enhanced supply is aimed at ensuring wider access and more equitable distribution of LPG among migrant workers across the Capital.

To support last-mile delivery, district magistrates have been directed to organise special camps in areas with a high concentration of migrant labourers. These camps are intended to make it easier for workers who face difficulty in accessing LPG through existing channels.

Migrant labourers can also approach district magistrate offices to request the organisation of such camps in their localities. The camps will function alongside the current distribution network operated by oil marketing companies through authorised LPG distributors.

Officials said coordination with these companies will be key to ensuring smooth and efficient supply. Eligible beneficiaries will be able to obtain 5 kg LPG cylinders at the camps upon payment and submission of Aadhaar as identity proof. The process is designed to be simple and accessible for workers who may not have easy access to formal distribution systems.

District Enforcement Teams have been tasked with supporting the initiative. Their role will include assessing demand in different areas and overseeing distribution to ensure transparency and orderly operations.

Officials said the effort is part of a broader push to strengthen last-mile delivery systems for essential services. The focus is on reaching vulnerable populations who often face barriers in accessing basic utilities such as cooking fuel.

The increase in allocation is expected to ease pressure on existing supply channels and reduce the gap between demand and availability among migrant workers. Authorities believe that improving access to LPG will also contribute to better living conditions by providing a cleaner and more reliable cooking fuel option.

The initiative comes at a time when the city continues to see a steady influx of migrant labourers working in construction, informal sectors, and small-scale industries. Many of them rely on affordable and accessible fuel options for daily cooking needs.

LPG crisis forces migrant workers to return home

MANIK GUPTA
New Delhi

Some hid their departure behind made-up family occasions, and others quietly admitted the truth, but all left with heavy bags and heavier hearts.

The LPG crisis is forcing migrants to leave the city for their villages, hoping the separation from the place they call home will be brief.

Railway stations across Delhi-NCR seem busier than usual. Hundreds of migrant labourers stream out with their belongings — mattresses, utensils, and multiple bags piled high on their heads and shoulders.

The reasons: shortage of LPG cylinders, delays in refilling, and soaring black-market prices.

Disappointment writ large on the face of Radhey Sham, 38, who worked as a gig worker by day and a security guard by night. He decided to return to his village in Bithoor, Uttar Pradesh, after multiple failed attempts to get an LPG cylinder.

Queuing to buy tickets at Anand Vihar Railway Station with his Blinkit delivery bag — this time packed with his own belongings — in tow, he worries about his family of four.

"Even after doing multiple jobs, I don't make more than ₹20,000. My wife works in nearby houses and adds another ₹5,000. I have two grown-up children to look after. Managing expenses has already been difficult. How can I afford ₹3,000 for an LPG cylinder?

"I decided it's better to leave and save on rent. In the village, we can still cook on a chulha. Hopefully, things will improve in a month, and I'll be back," Shyam said in a broken voice as his wife and children tried to console him.

The story was no different for Suman Verma. But whether out of hesitation or shame, the 29-year-old daily wager, balancing multiple gunny bags, said he was leaving for a wedding.

His class 5-going son, Anshu Verma, was quick to reveal the truth once his father stepped away to buy tickets for Bihar at the New Delhi Railway Station.

"We all know the real reason. A lockdown is about to happen. My father said all shops will shut and we won't be able to return later. We had already run out of gas, and my mother was cooking on a makeshift stove," Anshu said, with a maturity that belied his age.

The subsidised 14.2-kg LPG cylinders, currently priced at ₹913 in Delhi for regular domestic connections, were earlier accessible to migrant labourers — without proper papers and household connection — at a premium of ₹100-200. Now, the same cylinders are being sold on the black market for ₹3,000 or more.

There has also been a shortage of 5-kg LPG cylinders, which are typically available through distributors without requiring a formal connection.

The Government on Tuesday said it had doubled the daily quota of market-priced 5 kg LPG cylinders for migrant workers as part of efforts to stabilise fuel supplies amid disruptions linked to tensions around the Strait of Hormuz.

Porters, who witness the daily bustle at these railway stations, confirm the migrant exodus. (*PTI*)

CM Rekha directs MCD to tighten waste management

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday directed the MCD to tighten waste management and cleanliness systems, warning against delays and lapses in civic services.

The chief minister posted on X that at a review meeting on the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) works, a series of instructions have been issued, aimed at improving sanitation and infrastructure across the city.

"State-of-the-art waste-to-energy plants with modern technology will be set up in Ghazipur, Narela, Okhla and Tekhand," she posted on X.

The meeting also decided to redevelop around 1,000 toilets and urinal blocks operated by the civic body, while three new gobar gas plants will soon come up in Goyla Dairy, Ghogha and Ghazipur, it added.

According to the post, officials were asked to put in place a strict mechanism to ensure effective recovery of enhanced fines imposed on those found spreading filth. The MCD was also told to coordinate with the Delhi Development Authority to ensure regular and systematic cleaning of markets.

The chief minister said special drives will be carried out to remove garbage along railway tracks in a more effective and sustained manner.

On infrastructure, Gupta directed that experienced companies be assigned road construction and repair works to ensure quality and accountability and asked officials to closely monitor all projects and complete them within stipulated timelines.

Police crackdown on cyber fraud, arrest over 1,400

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
New Delhi

In one of the largest coordinated crackdowns on cybercrime in recent years, Delhi Police have rounded up 8,371 suspects and arrested over 1,400 accused as part of Operation CyHawk, a city-wide drive targeting organised cyber fraud networks.

The month-long, intelligence-driven operation resulted in the registration of 499 new FIRs and significant breakthroughs in 324 pending cyber fraud cases, police stated. Authorities also issued 2,203 legal notices to individuals linked to the financial chain of cyber fraud modules.

The Commissioner of Police, Delhi, Satish Golchha, said the operation marked a shift towards proactive policing aimed at dismantling the financial and operational backbone of cybercrime networks. "Operation CyHawk reflects Delhi Police's commitment to stay ahead of cyber criminals through intelligence-led policing. Those who exploit citizens through digital means will be identified and brought to justice," he said.

The crackdown focused on disrupting mule accounts, illegal call centres, and networks involved in siphoning defrauded money. Police said over ₹519 crore linked to cyber fraud complaints registered on the national portal has been traced to multiple bank accounts associated with organised syndicates.

The operation was carried out with support from the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre under the Ministry of Home Affairs. Investigators spent nearly a month mapping cybercrime hotspots, analysing suspicious transactions, and tracking digital trails before launching coordinated raids across multiple districts.

Senior officers stated that the operation targeted key elements of the cyber fraud ecosystem, including mule accounts used for fund transfers, field agents involved in cash withdrawals, and call centres engaged in scams such as fake job offers, tech support fraud, telemarketing deception, and customer care impersonation.

Several illegal call centres were shut down during the raids, preventing ongoing scams that targeted victims across the country. Police also linked 3,564 complaints from the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal to identified suspects and bank accounts, strengthening the investigation.

The operation was led on the ground by Special Commissioner Madhup Tewari and Special Commissioner Anil Shukla, with coordination from Joint Commissioners Rajneesh Gupta and Vijay Kumar.

Police recovered a large volume of digital and financial evidence during searches conducted at multiple locations. Seized items include mobile phones, laptops, hard drives, SIM cards, debit and credit cards, and financial records.

PUBLIC NOTICE

I Rama Rani alias Rama Wadhwa, W/o Shri Pankaj Wadhwa and D/o Late Shri Banarasi Lal, R/o K.H.-111, Kavi Nagar, District Ghaziabad, hereby sever and terminate all my relations with my brother Rajesh Sethi alias Sonu his wife Poonam Sethi and their daughters due to their inappropriate behaviour. Henceforth, they shall be solely responsible for their own actions in the future.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Known to all that my client **Bhavesh Chaturvedi and Rajshree owner of First Floor, Back Side, Area 100 Sq. Yds.,Property No. Rz-F-2/11 (Old No. 56), Khasra No. 458, Mahavir Enclave, New Delhi., and My Client Have lost original Sale deed no.13148, dated 23.11.2012 in favour of Anu Mendiratta and Kajal Talreja. And It is informed that any deal with said documents by any person except my said client and said institution regarding said property,** shall be deemed as null and void. If any person having any claim, right in said property then he may contact and handover the same and apprise his claim to undersigned within 15 days of this publication.

AD REM LEGAL SOLUTION
Ch. No. 760 - Dwarka Court Sector-10, Dwarka, New Delhi-75
Mobile :- 9899013918

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the General Public on behalf of our client i.e. Yes Bank Ltd. that Mrs. Reena wife of Mr. Amit Kumar is the owner of property No. 381/18, admeasuring 60 sq.yds, out of Khewat No.1569, khata No.1680, killa No.250//7/2/1, situated at village Gohana, Indergarhi, Gohana, Sonipat by virtue of Sale Deed dt. 28.07.2022 (Doc No. 2773), executed by Mr. Ramesh. The said Original Deed was submitted with Yes Bank Ltd, Gohna Branch however same is not traceable by the bank and it appears to be lost/ misplaced by Bank. Also in this regard Lost Property Report Number 132390352600166 has been filed by Mrs Reena. All persons are hereby informed not to deal or carry out any transaction with anyone on the basis of the above missing original document. If anyone has already carried out or being carrying out any transaction, kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 7 days of the present.
Kumar & Associates (Advocates & Consultants)
200, IInd Flr. 23, Shivaji Marg, Moti Nagar, N.Delhi-15
legal@knalegal.com Ph: 011-41112527-28

PUBLIC NOTICE

Known to all that my client **Lakshay Bains and Paras Bains owner of Commercial Shop on Ground Floor, Property municipal No. L-53, Block-L, Area 8.42 sq yds., Situated at Shastri Nagar,Delhi-52.,and My Client Have lost original Sale deed no. 4995, dated 26.09.2003 in favour of Sushila Gupta. And It is informed that any deal with said documents by any person except my said client and said institution regarding said property,** shall be deemed as null and void. If any person having any claim, right in said property then he may contact and handover the same and apprise his claim to undersigned within 15 days of this publication.

AD REM LEGAL SOLUTION
Ch. No. 760 - Dwarka Court Sector-10, Dwarka, New Delhi-75
Mobile :- 9899013918

PUBLIC NOTICE

I hereby tender my resignation from all positions held by me in **Ambience Water Solutions & Marketing Ltd,** with effect from 15 January 2022. Due to personal reasons, I am unable to continue my responsibilities and therefore request you kindly accept my resignation. I would like to express my gratitude for the opportunities and supp extended to me during my tenure with the company. I request the Board to take this on record and complete all necessary formalities in this regard.
Piyush Dwivedi

PUBLIC NOTICE

I hereby tender my resignation from all positions held by me in **Nexgen Energia Limited,** with effect from 15 January 2022. Due to personal reasons, I am unable to continue my responsibilities and therefore request you to kindly accept my resignation. I would like to express my gratitude for the opportunities and support extended to me during my tenure with the company. I request the Board to take this on record and complete all necessary formalities in this regard
Piyush Dwivedi

PUBLIC NOTICE

"Know all men by these presents that my client Sh. Parveen Kumar Grover, R/o G-11, 3rd Floor, Jungpura Extn., New Delhi-110014, has severed all his relations with his (i) son Sh. Abhishek Grover (ii) daughter-in-law Smt. Sonia Grover (wife of Sh. Abhishek Grover) (iii) granddaughter Ms. Suhana Grover (daughter of Sh. Abhishek Grover), disowned and debarred them from all his moveable and immovable properties and shall not be liable/responsible for any act and omission whatsoever done by them, if any person deals with them, he/she shall do the same at his/her own risks, costs and responsibilities and my client and his other family members shall not be liable/ responsible for the same in any manner whatsoever".
Sd/-
(MADHUKANT JHA) - ADVOCATE

LOST AND FOUND

I, Poonam Aggarwal D/o Shri Khushi Ram R/o Villa No. 158 Phase - I, Vakil Whispering Woods, Madivala Village, Anekal Taluk, Marasur, Bengaluru, Karnataka - 562106 do hereby solemnly affirm and inform that I have lost my original Property Document which includes GPA, WILL, AGREEMENT TO SELL, RECEIPT ETC on dated 13 - 11 - 1998 executed by Shri Sunil Jain and Shri Sanjeev Jain in favour of Smt. UPASANA SHARMA. I have also file a FIR against the lost document vide LR No. 207373/2026, SO No. 430/2014.
Poonam Aggarwal

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is to bring to the notice of all that the original allottee of residential flat no. 351, Sector-28, Arun Vihar, Noida, Col. Vijay Bhushan s/o Shri Hari Prakash, r/o 249, D.S. Arjun Vihar, Delhi Cantt, Delhi – 110010, had executed a General Power of Attorney (G.P.A.) on dt. 13.09.1993 in favour of Shri Manu Talwar s/o Shri P.P. Talwar, r/o C-7/117, Navin Niketan, SDA, New Delhi. which is registered in the office of Sub-Registrar Delhi-III, vide Reg no. 4916, Book No: IV , Volume no. 173 pages 79 to 80, dated. 13/9/93.
Now it is informed to all concerned that the transfer of the above said property is being made in favour of Shri Atul Gupta s/o Shri Radhey Shyam Gupta, r/o Flat No. 350, Sector-28, Noida.If anyone has any objection, he/she shall submit his/her objection to the Residential Group Housing Department of Noida Authority within 30 days of the publication of this notice.

LOST AND FOUND

I, Raju Panchal S/o Shri Jugminder Panchal R/o 327/H, 9th K Main Vijayanagar, Bangalore, Karnataka - 560040 do hereby solemnly affirm and inform that I have lost my original Property Document which includes WILL and RECEIPT on dated 15 - 05 - 1986 Executed by ISHWAR DAS AGGARWAL in favour of SURINDER KAUR and SACHDEVA of Property No. 62 - A, Timber Block, Jhilmil Tahirpur Industrial Area, GT Road, Delhi and WILL AND RECEIPT Dated 14 - 08 - 1991 of Property No. 62 - A, Timber Block, Jhilmil Tahirpur Industrial Area, GT Road, Delhi Executed by SURINDER KAUR and SANTOSH SACHDEVA in favour of RAJU PANCHAL. I have also file a FIR against the lost document vide LR No. 207666/2026, SO No. 430/2014
Raju Panchal

The Pioneer
Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Navneet Kaur Chabbra W/o Gundeep Singh Narang R/o J-3/2 Rajouri Garden New Delhi-110027 have changed my name to Navneet Kaur.
PD(814)C

I, Gupteshwar, Father of JC-473623A Nb/Sub Niaraj Kumar Singh, R/o- Vill & PO-Mustafabad, Varanasi, U.P.-221104, have changed my name from Gupteshwar to Gupteshvar, vide affidavit dated 08/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(815)C

I, No.14839673H Hav/MT Surya Kant Sharma, R/o-Vill&PO- Panchsil Nagar, Teh-Danapur, Distt- Patna, Bihar have changed my son's name from Ankur Sharma to Pranav Sharma, vide affidavit dated 08/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(816)C

I, No.14839673H Hav/MT Surya Kant Sharma, R/o-Vill&PO- Panchsil Nagar, Teh-Danapur, Distt- Patna, Bihar have changed my son's name from Aarush Sharma to Pratik Sharma, vide affidavit dated 08/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(817)C

I, Usha, W/o- No.14839081Y Hav/MT Hem Chandra, R/o-Vill- Pangrari, PO-Mukteshwar, Teh & Dist-Nainital, Uttarakhand, have changed my name from Usha Devi to Usha, vide affidavit dated 08/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(818)C

I, Thorat Pooja Bharat, W/o-No.14681794F Hav Thorat Bharat Uttam, R/o- Vill-Kapuswadgaon, PO-Veergaon, Taluk- Vaijapur, Dist- Aurangabad, Maharashtra- 423701, have changed my name from Thorat Pooja Bharat to Pooja Bharat Thorat, vide affidavit dated 08/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(819)C

I, JC-548639P Ex-Sub Maj (Hony Capt) Chandi Das Singha R/o Vill- Banskandi, P.O- Banskandi, PS- Lakhipur, Dist- Cachar, State- Assam PIN- 788101 have changed my son's name in my records from Chandrajit Singha to Th Chandrajit Singha vide affidavit dated 25/03/2026 before 1st Class Magistrate, Silchar, Cachar, Assam.
PD(820)C

I, Tushar S/o Ram Ji R/o I-1355, Block-I, Jahangir Puri, N.S. Mandi North West Delhi-33 have changed my name to Tushar Kumar.
PD(821)C

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the general public that the **original documents**, namely
• Provisional Allotment Letter • Builder Buyer Agreement dated **30.10.2012** • All Payment Receipts pertaining to **Apartment No. 1204, Tower T-9, 12th Floor (Unit ID: SO434)** in the project **"Spire Woods", Sector 103, Gurugram, Haryana,** originally developed by **A.N. Buildwell Pvt. Ltd.** and now developed by **Alpha Corp Development Limited,** allotted in the name of:
Ms. Shilpi Dahiya D/o Late Mr. Narinder Singh Dahiya R/o IV-1/75, 2 Gopinath Building Gopinath Bazar, Delhi Cantt, New Delhi – 110010 have been **lost/misplaced, as per FIR No. 201928/2026 dated 01/04/2026 lodged at Delhi Cantt Police Station.**
An application has been submitted by the above-named allottee's to the Developer/Company for issuance of Certified True Copies / Duplicates of the aforementioned documents.
The Company hereby invites any claims or objections (in writing), if any, from any person(s) having any right, title, interest, or objection with respect to the issuance of the said documents. Such claims/objections, along with supporting documents, must be submitted to the undersigned within 14 (fourteen) days from the date of publication of this notice.
Failing receipt of any objections within the stipulated period, it shall be presumed that there are no objections/claims, and the Company shall proceed with the issuance of the Certified True/Duplicate Copies of the requested documents.
Mr. Gaurav Avasthi
Dy. Manager – Commercial
Alpha Corp Development Limited
602, 6th Floor, Tower-J, World Trade Centre, Ring Road, Nauroji Nagar, New Delhi-110029

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that my client Poonam Goel is in process to avail LAP against the Plot no. 8 and 9, area measuring 150sq.yds., out of Mustatil no.18, Killa No.6, 7/1, 7/2, 14/3, Situated at village Unchagaon, now known as Bhatia Colony, Tehsil Ballabhgarh, District Faridabad, Haryana, (availing loan from Tata capital Housing Finance Ltd) by virtue Two Sale Deeds dated 27/9/2006 Doc no.6728(In respect of Plot no.8) and Sale Deed dated 12/8/2004 Doc no. 2893 (In respect of plot no.9) executed by Rajender (In respect of Plot no.8) and Angoori Devi(In respect of Plot no.9). My client informed me that below mentioned Documents are not available pertaining to the said property with her and online FIR has already been lodged vide FIR Application no. 132250032600420 in lieu of that.
1. Original Sale Deed dated 16/05/1979 executed by Tarunesh Kumar in favour of Premwati, (Doc. no.941).
2. Original Sale Deed dated 24/04/1986 executed by Premwati in favour of Surajbhan, (Doc. no.215)
All person/s having any claim against or in respect of the said Property, or any part thereof, by way of sale, exchange, mortgage (equitable/registered or otherwise), gift, trust, inheritance, family arrangement maintenance, bequest, partnership, possession, lease, sublease, tenancy, license, lien, charge, pledge, easement or otherwise howsoever, are hereby requested to notify the same in writing to us with supporting documentary evidence at the address mentioned below within 7 days from the date hereof, failing which the claim or claims, if any, of such person or persons will be considered to have been waived and/or abandoned.
KamalKant Gupta (Advocate)
Unit No. FF-2, First floor, Mahaluxmi Metro Tower Sec-4, Vaishali, Gzb., U.P., Mob. 9810063351

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of **Mrs. Deepa Sachdeva** to inform to the public at large that **Mrs. Deepa Sachdeva** is purchasing the **Second Floor without roof rights, on Property no. 31, measuring 52.25 sq. meters, Khasra no. 42/18 situated at village Khureji Khas, abadi Krishan Kunj, Part-II, Laxmi Nagar, Illaqa Shahdara, Delhi-92** from **Mrs. Bhavna Jain** who became owner through **Sale Deed dated 26.07.2024 (Doc No.2024/5/I/6247)** executed by **Mrs. Priyanka Verma & Mrs. Anita Verma and same will be financed & mortgaged by Aditya Birla Housing Finance Ltd., Noida.** That, **Ms. Priyanka Verma was the owner through Notarized Relinquishment Deed dated 26.04.2024** executed by **Ms. Riya Verma & Ms. Simran Verma**. So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/ interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within **10 days** from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc.
Lucem Legal LLP
B-93B, Second Floor, Opp. SBI Bank Sector 2,Noida,UP-201301Contact#0120-4269379

Public Notice

This is to inform the general public that Sh. Gagan Chakravarti is the Owner of the Plot no. 12, area measuring 162.2 Sq. Yds., out of Khasra no. 232, Khata/Khewat no. 137/413 & Khasra no. 233 Khata/Khewat no. 137/413, situated at Ashoka Park Extn. New Delhi through Sale Deed dated 01.11.2023 as doc. no. 2023/6/I/7633 executed by Smt. Menka Sharma & Sh. Amit Kashyap through his Gen. Att. Sh. Gaurav Sandil in favour of Sh. Gagan Chakravarti in respect of said property.
Sh. Gagan Chakravarti intend to transfer the ownership of Entire 2nd Floor without roof right "said floor", of above said property by way of Sale Deed to Smt. Yamini Bansal. Subsequently, Smt. Yamini Bansal is in the process of mortgaging the said floor with ICICI Bank Ltd./ ICICI Home Finance Co. Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 14 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 14-day period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client.
If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 14-day period by contacting Law Veritas: North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301; Landline(s): +91012-04499711, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in

CM Shri school admissions to begin from April 13

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Admissions to the CM Shri Schools in Delhi will open on April 13 for Classes 6 and 9 and on May 7 for Class 11 for the 2026-27 academic session, according to the Directorate of Education.

Admit cards were distributed on Wednesday for the entrance examinations. The tests for Classes 6 and 9 will be conducted in the last week of March, while the examination for Class 11 is scheduled for May, the DoE said in a public notice issued on Tuesday.

The results for Classes 6 and 9 will be announced on April 30, and the results for Class 11 will be released on May 25. Only residents of Delhi who studied in a recognised school in the national capital during the 2025-26 academic session are eligible to apply, a circular issued by the education department stated.

According to the department, 50 per cent of the seats are reserved for students who have passed Classes 5, 8 and 10 from Delhi government schools. The remaining seats are open to other eligible applicants who meet the residency and schooling criteria.

The entrance examination will be objective and OMR-based.

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is to inform to the public at large that Mrs. Usha Singh had acquired LIG Flat No. 187 and 188 each measuring 50 sq. mtrs., in Block-E, Sector-27, Noida Distt. G.B Nagar, U.P. vide Transfer Deed-Cum Sale Deed dated 25.07.2003 and Lease Deed dated 22.11.1998. Original Allotment Letter and Lease deed dt. 15.03.1999 w.r.t Flat no. 187 and Original Allotment Letter and Possession Certificate dt. 20.01.1990 w.r.t Flat no. 188 are Lost. Now Mrs. Usha Singh is the undisputed owner of above said properties and is willing to Mortgage the above said property with CIFCL.
OR
Any person / firm / institution / company having any claim or right in respect of the said Property by way of inheritance, share, sale, agreement, lease, license, gift, possession, legal heirs, partners or encumbrance howsoever or otherwise is hereby required to intimate in writing to the undersigned within 07 days from the date of publication of this notice of his/her/their share or claim, if any, with all supporting documents at below mentioned address. After expiration of notice period, the claims, if any, of such person shall be treated null and void and also treated as waived and not binding on our client.
Ajay Kumar Giri (Advocate) H.No. 26/161, Basement, Vikram Vihar, Lajpat Nagar 4, New Delhi 110024

PUBLIC NOTICE

KK Dhanuka Estates Pvt Ltd
Address: Office Unit No. 501,"Conscient One", Sector-109, Dwarka Expressway, Gurugram, Haryana-122017
Phone No. 88000 00751 / 88000 00751
Website: - aarambhgreens.com
REGISTRATION NO: HRERA-PKL-SNP-869-2026
PROJECT NAME: "AARAMBH GREENS"
DEVELOPED BY: M/s KK Dhanuka Estates Pvt Ltd
It is hereby informed to the general public/allottees that KK Dhanuka Estates Pvt Ltd, is the promoter of the affordable residential plotted colony under DDJAY scheme project namely "AARAMBH GREENS"located at Village Thana Kalan, Sector 7, Kharkhauda, Sonipat, Haryana has been registered with the Haryana Real Estate Regulatory Authority (HARERA) Panchkula vide RERA Registration No: HRERA-PKL-SNP-869-2026 dated 16.03.2026 valid till 31.12.2030 under the RERA Act, 2016. Accordingly vide this public notice, the general public is hereby notified/informed that the following are the bank accounts details of the project as follows:
RERA Bank Account Details (As per Section 4(2)(l)(D) of RERA Act, 2016):

Master/Collection Account, RERA and Promoter Free Account	
Account Name	M/s KK Dhanuka Estates Pvt Ltd
Bank Name	ICICI Bank
Branch Name	ICICI Bank LTD,HUDA Market, Sector - 40 Gurgaon, Haryana - 122003
IFSC Code	ICIC0005331
Master Collection Account (100%)	777705031521
RERA Account No/Escrow Account No (70%)	777705031522
Promoter Free Account (30%)	777705031523

Place: Gurugram
Date: 09/04/2026
SD/-
Authorized Signatory
M/s KK Dhanuka Estates Pvt Ltd

NORTHERN RAILWAY
OPEN-E-TENDER NOTICE

The Sr. Divisional Engineer-III, Northern Railway, Delhi Division invites E-Tender for the following work.

1	**Name of work**	Repairs and Renovation of Offices and Shed at NDLS Sick Line. Ajmeri Gate, New Delhi including Flooring Work. Repair to Leaky Roof, Replacement of Broken Doors and Windows. Provision of Toilet, Renovation of Toilet Blocks by Replacing Sanitary Fittings, white washing and other Misc. work in the section of SSE/W/NDLS under ADEN/NDLS.
2	**Approx cost of work**	Rs.1,99,17,362.47/- (Rupees One Crore Ninty Nine Lakh Seventeen Thousand Three Hundred Sixty Two and Forty Seven Paise Only)
3	**Earnest Money to be deposited**	Rs. 3,98,400.00/- (Rupees Three Lakh Ninty Eight Thousand Four Hundred Only)
4	**Cost of tender document**	Rs. 0.00/-
5	**Date & Time of submission of tender bid and opening of tender**	30.04.2026 @ 15:00 Hrs.
6	**Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen**	**www.ireps.gov.in**
7	**Allocation**	04-410-32

• The tenderer/s must be registered on the Indian Railway E-Procurement system (IREPS) site i.e. **www.ireps.gov.in** for participating in the e-tender system. • For all terms and conditions please refer tender document. • No manual offers are acceptable. • Cost of tender document and Earnest money will be acceptable through net banking or payment gateway only. **No. 128-W/280/e 1164/2026**
Tender Notice/NIT/02/2026-27/W-3 Dated :- 07.04.2026
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

AXIS BANK LTD.
Retail Lending and Payment Group (Local Office/Branch): Axis House, Tower-2, 2nd Floor, I-14, Sector-128, Noida Expressway, Jaypee Greens Wishtown, Noida-201301, U.P.
Axis Bank Ltd., 3rd Floor, Gigaplex, NPC – 1, TTC Industrial Area, Mugalsan Road, Airoli, Navi Mumbai – 400708., Registered Office: "Trishul", 3rd Floor Opp. Samartheshwar Temple Law Garden, Ellisbridge Ahmedabad – 380006.
E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY
E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE ASSETS UNDER THE SECURITISATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT 2002 READ WITH PROVISO TO RULE 8(6) OF THE SECURITY INTEREST (ENFORCEMENT) RULE, 2002.
Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described immovable property is mortgaged/charged to the secured creditor, the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of Secured Creditor will be sold on **"As is where is" , "As is what is"** and **"Whatever there -is"** on **29.04.2026** for recovery of **Rs. 6,36,47,330/- (Rupees Six Crore Thirty-Six Lakh Forty-Seven Thousand Three Hundred Thirty Only) dues as on 09-10-24** with future interest and costs due to the secured creditor from **Mr. Kawal Kalra (Applicant), Mrs. Ruchi Kalra, & Mrs. Geeta Kalra (Co-applicant).** Please refer the appended auction schedule for necessary details: -

KNOWN ENCUMBRANCES (IF ANY)	NIL
RESERVE PRICE (IN RS.)	Rs. 13,75,96,478/- (Rupees Thirteen Crore Seventy-Five Lakh Ninety-Six Thousand Four Hundred Seventy-Eight Only)
EARNEST MONEY DEPOSIT (IN RS.)	Rs 1,37,59,647/- (Rupees One Crore Thirty-Seven Lakh Fifty-Nine Thousand Six Hundred Forty-Seven Only) through DD/PO in favor of 'Axis bank ltd.' Payable.
BID INCREMENTAL AMOUNT	Rs. 50,000/- (Rupees Fifteen Thousand only)
LAST DATE, TIME AND VENUE FOR SUBMISSION OF BIDS / TENDER WITH EMD	Till 28.04.2026 latest by 05:00 P.M. Axis House, Tower-2, 2nd Floor, I-14, Sector-128, Noida Expressway, Jaypee Greens Wishtown, Noida-201301, U.P. addressed to Mr. Mukesh Singh
DATE, TIME, AND VENUE FOR PUBLIC E-AUCTION	On 29.05.2026, between 11.00 A.M and 12.00 Noon. with unlimited extensions of 5 minutes each at web portal https://www.bankeauctions.com. e-auction tender documents containing e-auction bid form, declaration etc., are available in the website of the Service Provider as mentioned above.

SCHEDULE-DESCRIPTION OF PROPERTY:- Residensial Build-Up Plot Bearing No.-B-4.17, Area Measuring 320.32 Sq. Mtrs In Block B-4, Situated In The Lauout Plan Paschim Vihar, New Delhi- 110063 And Bounded As Under: - North- As Per The Site Plan, East- As Per The Site Plan, West- As Per The Site Plan, South- As Per The Site Plan
For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to the link provided in the secured creditor's website i.e. **https://www.axisbank.com/auction-retail** and the Bank's approved service provider **M/S C1 India Private Limited** at their web portal **https://www.bankeauctions.com**
The auction will be conducted online through the Bank's approved service provider **M/s.C1 India Private Limited** at their web portal **https://www.bankeauctions.com**.
For any other assistance, the intending bidders may contact **Mr. Amandeep Singh & Mr. Mukesh Singh, Mobile. No. +91-9911356558 & +91-9873015430** Authorized officer of the Bank during office hours from **10 a.m. to 4:00 p.m.**
Date: 09-April-2026, Place:- NOIDA **Sd/-, (Authorized Officer), Axis Bank Ltd.**

LG, CM direct officials to accelerate Yamuna rejuvenation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday directed officials to accelerate Yamuna rejuvenation and riverfront development, calling the effort a non-negotiable priority that must be pursued in mission mode.

During a joint inspection of Vasudev Ghat and Yamuna Bazar Ghat, the two leaders reviewed sanitation, infrastructure, and flood preparedness and issued instructions to strengthen coordination among agencies. The visit focused on assessing ongoing work and readiness for the upcoming monsoon and summer challenges.

The Lt Governor stressed that issues such as Yamuna pollution, air pollution, water scarcity, and flooding require urgent and sustained intervention. He said the Government will adopt a time-bound approach to rejuvenate the entire floodplain stretch from Palla to Kalindi Kunj, based on concerns raised by citizens during recent public interactions.

The Chief Minister reiterated that Yamuna cleaning remains a central commitment of the Delhi Government. She said the 2026 to 2027 Green Budget of ₹22,236 crore allocates a significant share to environmental initiatives, with the largest portion directed towards Yamuna cleaning through the Delhi Jal Board.

Officials from multiple departments, including Irrigation and Flood Control, Delhi Jal Board, Delhi Pollution Control Committee, and Municipal Corporation of Delhi, have been asked to work in close coordination. They have also been directed to prepare detailed plans with clear timelines and targets.

During the inspection, the Lt Governor and the Chief Minister noted the contrast between developed and underdeveloped ghats. Sites such as Vasudev Ghat, Asita, Baansera, and Yamuna Biodiversity Park were cited as examples of eco-friendly and sustainable public spaces. However, several other ghats were found to require similar development.

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta visit the Yamuna River at Vasudev Ghat in New Delhi
PANKAJ KUMAR

The review covered greenway projects, walking and cycling tracks, plantation drives, wetland restoration, and conservation of natural water channels. Officials presented updates on floodplain restoration work being carried out in phases from Wazirabad to Okhla.

The Lt Governor said the project will draw on national and international expertise to adopt best practices and innovative solutions. He added that Yamuna rejuvenation is among the top priorities of the central leadership.

The Chief Minister directed the immediate removal of encroachments from floodplains to improve the river's water-holding capacity and strengthen flood management. She also instructed officials to implement a three-point strategy focusing on desilting, ensuring smooth water flow, and addressing waterlogging hotspots.

Both leaders emphasised the need to develop the Yamuna riverbanks as a continuous stretch instead of isolated projects. The aim is to create accessible and well-planned public spaces for citizens while maintaining ecological balance. They also called for strict monitoring of solid waste management and sewage discharge. Officials were instructed to adopt a zero-tolerance approach towards illegal dumping and pollution.

The Lt Governor said governance must remain responsive and citizen-centric. He noted that public feedback has played a key role in shaping the current approach to Yamuna rejuvenation.

The Chief Minister said the effort to restore the Yamuna is a long-term process that requires sustained commitment and public participation. She added that the goal is to build a clean, green, and resilient river system for the Capital.

At the end of the inspection, both leaders underlined that development along the Yamuna must be environmentally sustainable and contribute to enhancing biodiversity while also creating attractive public spaces.

CM crackdown on absenteeism at GST office

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday ordered strict action against absentee officials after a surprise inspection at the State GST office in ITO revealed several officers, including senior officials, missing from duty during working hours.

Taking a serious view, the Chief Minister directed the immediate issuance of show-cause notices to all absent officials and made it clear that negligence will not be tolerated at any level. "Discipline applies to everyone, from staff to commissioners. No one will be exempt from rules," she said.

The Chief Minister emphasised that the inspection was aimed at enforcing accountability within the administrative system. She expressed concern that even senior officers were not present at their desks, calling it unacceptable in a public service setup. She directed departments to ensure strict compliance with biometric attendance, which she said is

mandatory for all officials. Authorities have been asked to submit biometric attendance records for the past month to fix responsibility and identify habitual defaulters.

During the visit, the Chief Minister interacted with taxpayers and members of the public present at the office. Several complaints were raised regarding delays in services and the unavailability of officials. Responding firmly, the Chief Minister warned that officers would be held directly responsible for any delay in delivering public services.

Officials were instructed to ensure that citizens do not face inconvenience due to administrative lapses. The Chief Minister said public service delivery must remain efficient and timely. She also reviewed the condition of the office premises and flagged shortcomings in infrastructure and maintenance. She directed the immediate removal of unused materials and scrap to improve the working environment.

Raising concerns over safety, she ordered regular fire safety audits and mandated timely maintenance reports to ensure preparedness. She said basic safety standards cannot be ignored in government offices.

On grievance redressal, the Chief Minister made it clear that official meetings cannot be used as a reason for delays in handling public complaints. She directed that all pending cases be reviewed on a weekly basis and that the complaint resolution system be simplified to ensure faster outcomes. She stressed the need to fix clear accountability in cases where services are delayed. Officials were told to adopt a more responsive approach towards citizens.

Reiterating her government's position, the Chief Minister said Delhi is following a zero-tolerance policy towards negligence, irregularities, and corruption. She warned that strict action will be taken against officials who fail to perform their duties responsibly.

The Chief Minister also indicated that such surprise inspections will continue across departments. She said regular monitoring is necessary to ensure discipline and maintain public trust in government institutions.

Digital rescue: DU professor tracks stolen laptop, recovers six years of PhD work

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

What began as a routine evening near Delhi University's North Campus turned into a moment of panic for an assistant professor when thieves smashed her car window and fled with a bag containing her laptop and years of research. Hours later, aided by a tracking application and a risky search, she managed to recover it.

The incident took place on a busy stretch of Bungalow Road near North Campus, where the professor had parked her car while visiting the area with her husband. According to her account shared on social media, the laptop contained nearly six years of her PhD work.

The professor, who teaches at Maitreyi College and is pursuing her doctorate from Delhi University, said the theft occurred while they were away for a few hours. They had first gone for academic work on campus and later

headed to the Kamala Nagar market. After parking their car on the roadside, the couple went to a restaurant and later to a jewellery store.

They chose to travel by rickshaw instead of walking, which meant they did not pass by their parked vehicle during that time. When they returned, they found the driver's side window shattered.

She described the moment as shocking. Passersby gathered around the damaged car, while the couple tried to assess the loss. The professor said her bag, which contained the laptop, was missing. Her wallet and an air purifier kept inside the vehicle had also been stolen.

The loss of the laptop caused immediate distress. The device contained years of academic work related to her PhD. She later said she was worried about how she would explain the loss of such crucial data. The couple informed the police soon after discovering the theft.

What followed was an unexpected turn. After leaving the police station, they stopped at a petrol pump. It was there that the professor checked her phone and used a tracking application linked to her laptop. The device showed a fixed location where it had remained for some time.

Despite concerns over safety, the couple decided to go to the location indicated on the app. Upon reaching the area, they spoke to local residents. According to the professor, one neighbour informed them that a few young men lived nearby. Another person reportedly said that the individuals had a criminal background.

With the help of locals, they reached the terrace area of the building. The professor said her husband spotted the suspects attempting to hide the stolen bag on a different terrace. The suspects moved away after noticing his presence. The professor said she was able to recover her bag, including the laptop. She also found other items that appeared to be stolen. Police were informed again and reached the spot. The suspects were detained, according to her account.

Raghav Chadha ignites buzz over launching youth-led political party

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Fresh political speculation is gathering momentum around Raghav Chadha, with growing chatter over whether the young leader could be contemplating a new, youth-driven political platform.

The buzz intensified after Chadha reshared a video on his Instagram Story in which a supporter suggested that he should consider forming his own political party. What has drawn particular attention is his brief but intriguing response to the post: "Interesting thought". The remark, though open-ended, has sparked widespread discussion among supporters and political observers alike.

Many are debating whether the response was a casual acknowledgement or a subtle nod toward a larger political ambition.

Sharing a social media video of a user suggesting that the sidelined AAP leader

Raghav Chadha float his own political party rather than joining another, Chadha on Wednesday left a brief comment: "interesting thought", fuelling speculation.

This comes after the MP shared a picture on his Instagram account of a book chapter with the title "Never Outshine the Master", apparently taking a dig at the party's national convener Arvind Kejriwal.

In the video shared by Chadha, the content creator can be seen saying that to keep his support intact, the AAP leader should launch his own party instead of joining any other political outfit. Chadha, known for his appeal among younger voters and his articulate public presence, has often been seen as one of the prominent youthful faces in Indian politics. His social media engagement frequently draws strong reactions, particularly from first-time voters and urban audiences.

While there has been no official statement or confirmation from Chadha regarding any plans to launch a new party, the timing of the speculation has added to the intrigue. Political analysts suggest that even a hint of such a move could reshape conversations around youth participation and leadership in the country's political landscape.

The Aam Aadmi Party had last week removed him as its deputy leader in the Rajya Sabha, and the MP reacted by saying that he had been "silenced, not defeated".

Police bust fake-loan call centre in Pitampura

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Delhi Police have busted a fake call centre operating in Pitampura and arrested 19 persons, including 12 women, for allegedly duping people across the country by posing as representatives of a private banking and financial services company and offering fake loans.

The operation was carried out jointly by the Cyber Police and Anti-Narcotics Squad of the Outer District following specific intelligence inputs about an organised fraud network targeting unsuspecting victims.

Deputy Commissioner of Police, Outer Delhi, Vikram Singh, said the accused cheated victims by collecting fake processing fees and then cutting off all contact. He said the operation reflects the police's commitment to tackling cybercrime and ensuring the safety of citizens in the digital space.

Police said the raid was conducted on April 7 after credible information was

received about illegal activities at a premises in Pitampura. A police team led by the Anti-Narcotics Squad was formed.

The Cyber Police team also joined the operation. During the raid, police found 19 people engaged in making calls using mobile phones. All were apprehended on the spot. Officials said the group was actively calling people from different states and luring them with promises of loans and insurance benefits.

During interrogation, a woman acted as a team leader and revealed that the group impersonated representatives of a private banking and financial services company. They targeted victims by offering easy loans and insurance schemes. Once a person showed interest, they demanded processing fees ranging from ₹1,500 to ₹2,000.

The payments were collected through QR codes sent via WhatsApp. After receiving the money, the accused neither provided loans nor refunded the amount. Police said the group frequently changed SIM cards and avoided calls from victims after the payment was made.

Investigators said the operation was managed by a handler based in Pitampura, who supplied lists of potential victims along with their contact details. The handler is currently absconding, and efforts are underway to trace and arrest him.

Further search of the premises led to the discovery of another room functioning as a separate call centre. A second group, led by another accused, was also operating from the same location. Police said this group followed a scripted method to trap victims.

They would introduce themselves as representatives of a private financial services company and offer loan services. After gaining trust, they would ask for Aadhaar and PAN details and then demand processing fees through QR codes. Once the payment was made, the accused would either stop responding, block the victims, or switch their phone numbers.

A case has been registered at the Cyber Police Station under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

Delhi records coldest April day in 11 years

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

A blanket of clouds, gusty winds and spells of light, scattered rain through the day kept Delhi unusually cool for April, bringing down the maximum temperature to 28.2 degrees Celsius on Wednesday, the lowest for the month in 11 years, even as the city breathed easier after days with air quality settling in the 'satisfactory' category.

The maximum temperature at Safdarjung was recorded at 28.2 degrees Celsius, 6.9 degrees below normal. The last time the maximum temperature was lower in April was on April 23, 2016, when it had settled at 27.2 degrees Celsius.

The city's base weather station at Safdarjung recorded 6.4 mm of rainfall in the 24 hours ending at 8.30 am today, marking the wettest spell since April 4, 2023, when 16.3 mm of rain was recorded.

Between 8.30 am and 5.30 pm, Palam recorded 0.6 mm of rainfall, anfd Lodhi Road reported trace amounts, while Safdarjung, Ridge, and Ayanagar recorded no rainfall.

Meanwhile, Palam recorded 27.2 degrees Celsius, 8.3 degrees below normal. Lodhi Road recorded 28.0 degrees Celsius, 6.0 degrees below normal, Ridge 28.8 degrees Celsius, 6.3 degrees below normal, and Ayanagar 28.0 degrees Celsius, 6.9 degrees below normal.

The minimum temperature at Safdarjung settled at 16.8 degrees Celsius, 3.2 degrees below normal.

Son held for killing father, uncle over money, job

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
New Delhi

Delhi Police have solved a double murder case in Dwarka, arresting a man accused of killing his father and uncle, allegedly for financial gain and a government job.

The accused, identified as Ishwar, was arrested for the murder of his father, Devender Kumar, 50, and uncle Amit, 48, inside a flat in Uttam Nagar. Police said the crime was driven by greed for nearly ₹50 lakh and the prospect of securing a government job on compassionate grounds.

Deputy Commissioner of Police, Dwarka, Kushal Pal Singh, said police received a call about a disturbance on the night of April 3. "Around 11.30 pm, information was received about a quarrel. The next day, both men were found dead, and the accused was missing," he said.

According to police, the bodies were discovered inside the flat under suspicious circumstances. Initial examination did not reveal any visible external injuries. However, the postmortem report later confirmed that both victims died due to severe internal injuries caused by physical assault.

Police officials said Devender Kumar was employed with ESIC and had around ₹50 lakh in his provident fund account. During the probe, police found that the accused was aware that in the event of his father's death, he could receive the money and also be considered for a government job under compassionate

grounds. Police said Ishwar allegedly planned the killings with this motive.

On the night of the incident, neighbours reported hearing a heated argument inside the house. The landlord, Naresh Kumar, reached the flat after receiving information and found Ishwar present at the scene. The situation appeared to have been resolved at that time. However, the following day, both Devender and Amit were found dead, while Ishwar had disappeared.

A police team launched an investigation using technical surveillance and local inputs. Ishwar was later traced and apprehended. During interrogation, the accused told police that he had consumed alcohol on the night of the incident. He got into an argument with his father and uncle, which escalated into a violent assault. Police said he beat both men severely, leading to their deaths.

Officials described the crime as a result of greed and the breakdown of family relations. The absence of external injuries initially made the case complex, but forensic findings helped establish the cause of death.

Further investigation is underway to reconstruct the sequence of events and gather additional evidence.

MCD standing committee clears plan to rename civic zones

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The standing committee of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi on Wednesday approved a proposal to rename its zones to align them with the Delhi government's revenue districts in a move aimed at improving coordination and administrative clarity.

Officials said the decision is intended to reduce overlap between civic and revenue jurisdictions and streamline governance across departments. Under the approved proposal, several MCD zones will be renamed. Narela zone will be called Outer North, Civil Lines will become North, Rohini will be renamed

North West, and Keshavpuram will be known as North Central. Karol Bagh will be renamed City Sadar Paharganj, while Najafgarh will be called South West. In East Delhi, Shahdara South will be renamed East, and Shahdara North will become North East. The South and West zones will retain their current names.

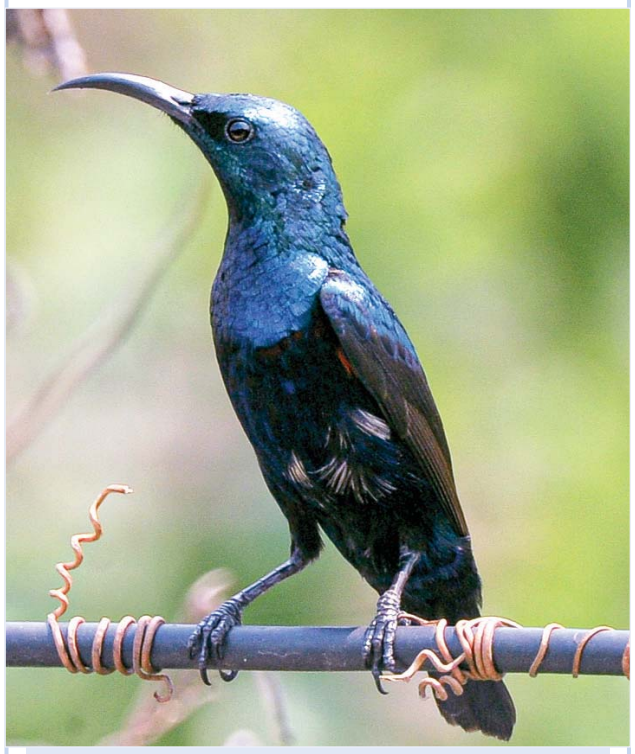
According to an official statement issued by the civic body, the proposal follows the reorganisation of Delhi's revenue districts carried out in December last year. The number of districts was increased from 11 to 13 as part of that exercise.

At present, the MCD is divided into 12 zones. New Delhi remains a separate revenue district under the New Delhi Municipal Council and is not part of the MCD structure.

Standing committee chairperson Satya Sharma said the renaming exercise is aimed at improving coordination between various government departments.

She said aligning civic zones with revenue districts will help simplify administrative processes and reduce confusion.

IN FOCUS



A Purple Sunbird sits on a wire near plants in Siliguri AP

UP saw significant agricultural growth in past nine years: CM

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Lucknow

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Wednesday said the State has significantly improved its agriculture growth rate over the past nine years as he credited sustained policy efforts and better resource utilisation.

Addressing the gathering after inaugurating the sixth Uttar Pradesh Agricultural Science Congress-2026 in Lucknow, Adityanath said the State's agriculture growth rate has increased from around eight per cent to 18 per cent during this period (in the past nine years).

Highlighting the State's importance in India's agrarian economy, he said Uttar

Pradesh accounts for 16-17 per cent of the country's population and possesses about 11 per cent of its cultivable land, contributing nearly 21 per cent to the nation's total foodgrain production. The State has some of the most fertile land and robust water resources, which, if utilised effectively, can yield significant results, he said. Attacking previous Governments in the State, he said, "Before 2017, the agriculture sector had become a symbol of disorder, unorganised systems, and deep mistrust among farmers. Effective procurement at Minimum Support Price could not be ensured, procurement centres were weak, and middlemen dominated. Farmers faced difficulty in getting fair prices for their produce. Sugarcane farmers had to wait for years for payments, which pushed them into debt."

He said that after 2017, the BJP Government prioritised agriculture and implemented transparent, technology-based, and farmer-centric policies.

Procurement at MSP at one-and-a-half times the cost of production was ensured, and payments were made directly through DBT. This increased farmers' confidence and gave agriculture a new identity as a profitable and respectable profession.

The CM further added, "Current global conditions have made it clear that self-reliance in agriculture and food security is extremely essential. Disruptions in international supply chains, uncertain availability of petroleum products, and fluctuations in fertiliser prices indicate that dependence on external sources can be risky for the country.

"In such a situation, it has become necessary for an agriculture-based country like India to strengthen its traditional agricultural system and integrate it with modern technology."

Cyber racket busted in Gujarat; 10 arrested

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Bhavnagar

Bhavnagar Police have dismantled a large-scale cyber fraud racket operating across multiple states, involving financial fraud exceeding ₹21.37 crore.

The police have arrested 10 accused, including the kingpin, and initiated legal action under stringent provisions. According to officials, the gang operated through a well-organized network led by a mastermind who appointed managers to oversee operations.

The group targeted unsuspecting individuals, luring them into opening bank accounts under their names. These accounts were then used to channel fraudulent funds. The accused collected essential banking materials such as passbooks, cheque

books, ATM cards, and SIM cards from account holders.

The fraudulently obtained money was deposited into these accounts and later withdrawn in cash using cheques and ATMs. The gang employed individuals on salary and commission to facilitate these transactions.

Further investigation revealed that the cash was routed through traditional angadia networks to various locations. Subsequently, the money was converted into cryptocurrencies, including USDT, and transferred abroad, indicating an international dimension to the scam.

Rajkot traders robbed of ₹25 crore in Patna

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Rajkot/Patna

In a shocking incident, employees of a well-known Rajkot-based jewellery firm, KV and Sons, were robbed of gold worth approximately ₹25 crore in Patna by a gang posing as customs officials.

According to reports, two employees-Mahesh Mamtora and Prince Ranpariya-had travelled from Rajkot to deliver a consignment of gold jewellery. Upon arriving at Danapur railway station in Patna, they were intercepted by around eight individuals arriving in cars and motorcycles. The accused allegedly identified themselves as officials from the customs department and demanded to verify invoices and documents related to the gold consignment. Under the pretext of inspection, the gang forcibly took the employees into a vehicle and abducted them to a secluded location.

There, the victims were threatened and relieved of approximately 17 kilograms of gold jewellery. After executing the robbery, the assailants abandoned the employees

on the roadside and fled the scene.

Following the incident, the victims informed their employer, who then lodged a complaint with the Bihar Police. Authorities in Patna have formed a special investigation team to probe the case. Preliminary findings suggest that the robbery was premeditated, possibly involving insider information about the employees' movement and the high-value consignment.

The incident has sent shockwaves through the bullion trading community in Rajkot and beyond, raising concerns over the safety of high-value transport across States.

LG Saxena launches official portals for Ladakh tourism

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Leh

To strengthen Ladakh's tourism sector and promote its rich cultural heritage, Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena on Wednesday launched the official portals for Ladakh Tourism and sacred exposition of the holy relics of Lord Buddha, an official said.

The portals — https://tourism.ladakh.gov.in/ and https://tathagata.co.in/ — were launched at the Lt Governor's Secretariat in the presence of venerable rinpoches, monks and senior government officials, a LokBhavan spokesperson said.

He said the launch marked a significant step towards enhancing Ladakh's global spiritual and cultur-

al outreach. The tourism website has been conceptualised on the directions of the Saxena as a comprehensive digital platform to serve as a central hub for promoting Ladakh as a premier travel destination, the spokesperson said.

He said the platform will provide authentic, reliable and updated information to tourists while facilitating the growth of the tourism sector. The website has been designed to be dynamic and user-friendly, featuring a tourism calendar to enable visitors to plan their travel around key festivals and events, the spokesperson said.

He said it showcases Ladakh's diverse offerings, including its spiritual and cultural heritage, tribal traditions, petroglyphs and rock art, adventure tourism, wildlife, astro-tourism, eco-tourism, wellness tourism, cuisine, sports, as well as its potential as a film destination and winter tourism hub.

It will also provide tourists with real-time advisory on health, travel and weather conditions, Saxena said, adding that the portal will also enable online registration of hotels, guest houses and homestays.

In a major ease-of-doing-business reform, inspired by Prime Minister's vision of "Minimum Government, Maximum Governance", the number of documents required for registration has been reduced from 18 to just two, while the validity period has been extended from one year to five years, thereby eliminating the need for annual renewals and reducing procedural burdens for the hotels or homestays or guest houses. "These initiatives mark a significant step towards leveraging digital technology for tourism promotion, improving service delivery and preserving Ladakh's cultural legacy, thereby reinforcing the UT Administration's commitment to sustainable and inclusive development," the Lt Governor said.

The Ladakh Tourism portal, that has been launched for the first time since the inception of Ladakh as a Union territory in 2019, would enable AI-curated travel planning, allowing tourists to customise their itineraries based on their personal interests and budget.

The primary objective is to promote tourism in Ladakh in a manner that benefits local communities while positioning Ladakh as a leading destination for adventure, spiritual and wellness tourism, the spokesperson said.

Also, the digital platform would help showcase the region's offerings globally, reaching audiences across the world, he said.

Goa nightclub fire: ED attaches assets worth over ₹17 crore

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Wednesday said it has attached immovable assets worth ₹17.45 crore as part of its money laundering investigation against the promoters of a Goa-based nightclub where 25 people were killed in a blaze in December 2025.

The federal probe agency took action against the

'Birch by Romeo Lane' club, its promoter brothers Gaurav and SaurabhLuthra and some others under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA).

A devastating fire broke out on December 6, 2025, at the nightclub in Goa's Arpora village while it was hosting a dance party. The blaze killed 25 people, and about 50 people were injured in the incident.

The ED said in a statement that a provisional order was issued to attach immovable properties valued at Rs 17.45 crore in connection with an ongoing investigation into the "illegal" operation of the establishment (Birch by Romeo). Officials said most of the attached properties belong to the Luthra brothers, apart from Surinder Kumar Khosla, a British national, stated to be an owner of the club.

A Goa court on Wednesday granted bail to the Luthra brothers in a forgery case, paving the way for their release from jail. The brothers had earlier secured bail in a case related to the blaze. The agency said its probe found that the club was being operated by an entity named 'Being GS Hospitality Goa Arpora LLP' without obtaining mandatory statutory approvals, including the requisite fire NOC. "The partners of the said entity submitted forged and fabricated documents, such as a fake health NOC and forged police clearance certificate, to various authorities to secure licences and project the establishment as lawfully compliant," the agency claimed.

TEEN DIES AFTER FALLING BUILDING IN GHAZIABAD

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Ghaziabad

An 18-year-old girl died under mysterious circumstances after falling from a high-rise residential society in Ghaziabad, triggering protests by her family and locals, before police persuaded the family to perform her last rites on Wednesday.

The deceased, a Class 12 pass-out from a nearby colony, had accompanied her father to the Jaipuria Sunrise Greens society in Indirapuram area on Tuesday, where he is engaged for washing cars and ironing clothes.

According to police, CCTV footage showed the girl walking alone inside the society, and within minutes she fell from the 16th floor of a tower, leading to her death on the spot.

Deputy CM meets Fadnavis for Baramati bypoll, gets full support assurance, say sources

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister and NCP president Sunetra Pawar met Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Wednesday to discuss the strategy and campaign for the April 23 Baramati assembly bypoll she is contesting.

Sources said Fadnavis assured Sunetra Pawar of full support from the BJP as an "elder brother".

Sunetra Pawar was accompanied by her son Parth Pawar and other NCP leaders, sources said. The meeting discussed campaigning and strategy for the bypoll, which became necessary after the then Deputy CM Ajit Pawar was

killed in a plane crash. He had represented the constituency eight times. Despite appeals made by ruling parties to ensure an unopposed election as a tribute to Ajit Pawar, the opposition Congress has fielded a candidate. A total of 53 candidates, including Sunetra Pawar and Congress's Akash More, have filed their nominations. The last date for withdrawal of nominations is April 9.

The Congress had said that it would withdraw from the contest only if an FIR is registered into Ajit Pawar's death in a plane crash in January. However, the run-up to the contest turned acrimonious after Parth Pawar criticised Congress for fielding a candidate and predicted the party's "downfall". The Congress hit back, terming Parth as an "ungrateful son". NCP (SP) chief Sharad Pawar and the party MP Supriya Sule have observed that being an independent political party, the Congress has every right to contest the bypoll.

FROM PAGE - 1

West Asia: US, Israel, Iran agree to conditional,...

In a detailed statement on social media, Trump said the decision followed conversations with Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif and Field Marshal Asim Munir, and was contingent on Iran agreeing to the "COMPLETE, IMMEDIATE, and SAFE OPENING of the Strait of Hormuz." He added that he had agreed to "hold off the destructive force being sent tonight to Iran" under these conditions. The announcement came hours after Trump warned that a "whole civilisation will die tonight" if a deal was not reached, underscoring the escalation that preceded the ceasefire. He also said the United States had received a 10-point proposal from Iran and described it as a workable basis for negotiations.

Iran confirmed it would take part in negotiations. Foreign Minister Seyed Abbas Araghchi said the move followed a "brotherly request" from Pakistan's leadership and discussions around a US proposal as well as Iran's own framework. He said that, for a period of two weeks, safe passage through the Strait of Hormuz would be ensured through coordination with Iran's armed forces, subject to technical limitations.

Mediators, including Pakistan said the ceasefire would apply "everywhere, including Lebanon and elsewhere," and invited leaders of both countries to Islamabad on April 10 for talks aimed at reaching a broader settlement.

However, there were immediate differences over the scope of the agreement. Israel said it supports the suspension of strikes against Iran for two weeks but indicated that its operations against Hezbollah in Lebanon would continue. Reports from the region indicated that strikes were recorded in parts of Lebanon after the ceasefire announcement.

The ceasefire follows weeks of military escalation that disrupted global energy supply chains and trade routes, particularly through the Strait of Hormuz, a key conduit for global oil shipments. Oil prices declined following the announcement, while equity markets in Asia moved higher, reflecting expectations of easing supply disruptions.

Officials cautioned that restoring shipping routes and stabilising supply chains could take time. There were also reports of continued incidents, including strikes and drone activity in parts of the region after the ceasefire announcement, highlighting uncertainty over implementation. Global reactions were mixed. Several countries and organisations welcomed the pause and called for negotiations to continue, while noting that the two-week arrangement remains temporary and dependent on further diplomatic progress.

Oil prices fall globally, LPG disruptions persist...

The ceasefire has begun to ease pressure on global shipping routes, with early signs of maritime traffic picking up in and around the Strait of Hormuz. Major shipping companies and tanker operators have started resuming vessel movement after weeks of disruption triggered by escalating tensions involving Iran and the United States.

Meanwhile, the Government has expanded commercial LPG supplies to a broader set of industrial sectors, allowing units to receive up to 70 per cent of their pre-West Asia crisis consumption, while maintaining a total sectoral cap of 200 tonnes per day. In a communication to State authorities, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas said eligible industries include polymer, agriculture, packaging, paints, steel, metal, glass, pharma, food, uranium, heavy water, ceramics, foundries, forging units, and aerosol manufacturers.

Analysts suggest that if the truce holds and the Strait of Hormuz remains open, a downward revision of Rs 3-₹5 per litre could be on the cards within the next 7 to 10 days. The primary headwind remains the Indian Rupee, which is currently hovering near ₹94.70 against the US Dollar, partially offsetting the gains from cheaper oil imports. For now, the "freeze" on prices is seen as a stabilising measure to prevent further inflationary shocks before the upcoming state elections. The war led to a spike in international oil prices. Rupee fell about 7 per cent over the past year, making it one of Asia's worst-performing currencies, as rising oil prices inflated the import bill and increased demand for dollars. The currency's slide has compounded imported inflation, amplifying the economic shock from the conflict.

RBI keeps rates steady; markets, rupee gain

Deputy Governor T Rabi Sankar said there was an "artificial drying up" of supply in the market during those days, which led to the measures.

RBI's six-member Monetary Policy Committee voted unanimously to keep the benchmark repurchase rate at 5.25 per cent, flagging heightened uncertainty after the West Asia conflict drove crude prices sharply higher, weakened the rupee and disrupted trade flows. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, tumbled 15 per cent to $92.88 per barrel. Rising for the fifth day in a row, the 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 2,946.32 points or 3.95 per cent to settle at 77,562.90, registering its best trading day in five years. During

the day, it surged 3,018.96 points or 4 per cent to 77,635.54. Thanks to the sharp rally in equities, the market capitalisation of BSE-listed companies surged by ₹16,25,093.09 crore to ₹4,45,51,401.85 crores (equivalent to $4.81 trillion).

Thanks to the sharp rally in equities, the market capitalisation of BSE-listed companies surged by ₹16,25,093.09 crore to ₹4,45,51,401.85 crores ($4.81 trillion). In Asian markets, South Korea's benchmark Kospi surged 6.87 per cent and Japan's Nikkei 225 index jumped 5.39 per cent. Shanghai's SSE Composite index and Hong Kong's Hang Seng index also recorded sharp rallies, while the European markets were trading significantly higher.

India backs truce

"We expect that unimpeded freedom of navigation and global flow of commerce would prevail through the Strait of Hormuz," the statement noted.

Reaffirming its long-standing stance, India said it supports all efforts aimed at ensuring peace and stability, and expressed hope that the ceasefire could also contribute to progress in other conflict zones, including Ukraine.

Meanwhile, India issued a fresh advisory urging its nationals in Iran to leave the country "expeditiously" in light of recent developments, even as a fragile two-week ceasefire between US, Israel and Iran comes into effect.

"There should be no attempt to approach any international land border without prior consultation and coordination with the Embassy," it added, while also sharing emergency contact numbers and email support. Despite the de-escalation, officials remain cautious given the volatile situation and uncertainty over the durability of the truce.

Tempers flare at TMC, ECI meet

The situation escalated after the MP said, "We are not here to listen to you," they allege.

After a short and stormy meeting that lasted seven minutes, the TMC delegation came out accusing the CEC, Gyanesh Kumar, of a "partisan attitude." According to TMC leaders, the meeting ended abruptly with the CEC telling their delegation to "get lost."

Talking to reporters after the meeting, O'Brien said they handed over nine letters written by West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee to the CEC, which the MP said have not been acknowledged. "We gave him six examples of officials who are part of the election process and have links with the BJP," O'Brien said.

Right after the meeting, the ECI published a social media post where it said it gave a "straight-talk" to the TMC delegation. The post further read, "... this time, the elections in West Bengal would surely be: fear-free, violence-free, intimidation-free, inducement-free and without any *chappa*, booth-jamming and source-jamming' (electoral malpractices)".

O'Brien questioned the post, insisting, "The CEC is a chor, a criminal. He said nothing of this in the meeting. The only thing he said was 'Get out.'" The TMC delegation accused the CEC of trying to play games with the party, saying, "Gyanesh Kumar, you don't know who you are dealing with. This is Mamata Banerjee, Abhishek Banerjee, and the TMC.".

The TMC leaders also took to social media, rejecting EC's claims. Tagging the EC's post, the TMC wrote on its X handle, "Straight-talk to ECI: Is this how a neutral constitutional body is expected to behave?" In another post, the party said, "We are also speaking straight to the Election Commission in a straightforward manner. This time, the elections must be: free from Delhi's control, free from political bias, free from targeted persecution of anyone, and certainly free from double standards."

HDFC Bank's ₹54,315 crore large defaulter load

Among the major private banks, unlike ICICI Bank with large defaulters having debt of ₹2.78 lakh crore, Axis Bank and HDFC is having less exposure to big defaults. Axis Bank is having total large defaulters with ₹66,338 crore and HDFC Bank is having total large defaulters with ₹54, 315 crroe. Large defaulter means those have dues above ₹One crore and banks conducting civil suits in various courts.

ICICI Bank is having 42 companies with more than ₹1,000 crore defaults and topper is all PSU banks plunder Lanco Group. Axis Bank is having 10 and HDFC Bank is having seven companies with more than ₹1,000 crore defaults.

Congress leader Singhvi slams rejection of motion against CEC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Senior Congress leader Abhishek Manu Singhvi on Wednesday criticised the rejection of the Opposition's notice for moving a motion in Parliament to remove Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar from his post, alleging that the decision undermines constitutional processes and weakens accountability in a democracy.

Addressing a Press conference along with other Opposition leaders, Singhvi said the move to reject the notice at a preliminary stage amounted to "strangulating" the entire impeachment mechanism envisaged in the Constitution.

He was accompanied by Trinamool Congress (TMC) leaders Derek O'Brien and Sagarika Ghose, Rashtriya Janata Dal's (RJD) Manoj Jha, Aam Aadmi Party's (AAP) Sandeep Pathak, DMK's Yogesh and NCP-SP's Rajeev Jha.

"When accountability is adjourned intelligently, then democracy itself stands impeached," Singhvi said, adding that if the Election Commission's position was strong, there should be no fear of scrutiny.

The Congress leader argued that the presiding officers of Parliament had committed a "fundamental conceptual error" by collapsing a multi-stage constitutional process into a single decision at the admission stage.

He maintained that the Constitution provides for a detailed procedure involving an initial admission, the formation of a judicial committee, framing of charges, the submission of a report, parliamentary discussion and finally, a decision.

"By rejecting the motion at the very first stage, you effectively eliminate all subsequent stages, including scrutiny by an independent committee and Parliament's collective wisdom," Singhvi said.

He also contended that the presiding officer exceeded the scope of a prima-facie assessment by delving into the merits of the allegations. "You cannot conduct a mini trial at the threshold. That defeats the very architecture of the Constitution," he said.

India, Bangladesh commit to normalise ties after 18 months

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

India and Bangladesh on Wednesday vowed to normalise their partnership following more than 18 months of unprecedented strain in relations, with External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar and his Bangladesh counterpart Khalilur Rahman agreeing to take steps to bolster ties in areas of trade, energy and people-to-people exchanges.

In his meeting with Jaishankar, Rahman reiterated Bangladesh's request to extradite former prime minister Sheikh Hasina and her ex-home minister Asaduzzaman Khan Kamal as they have been convicted by the 'International Crimes Tribunal', according to a readout issued by Dhaka.

At the same time, it was agreed that the issue relating to Hasina should not impact the overall trajectory of the India-Bangladesh relations, people familiar with the matter said.

Shortly after landing in New Delhi on Tuesday, Rahman held wide-ranging talks with National Security Advisor Ajit Doval.

It is the first high-level visit to India by a senior member of the new Bangladesh Nationalist Party Government led by Prime Minister Tarique Rahman that came to power in February following the parliamentary elections.

Nation Focus

PM Modi to address three rallies in West Bengal

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will intensify the BJP's election campaign in West Bengal on Thursday with rallies in Haldia, Asansol and Siuri. The choice of venues underlines the BJP's attempt to consolidate its support in areas where it has made major gains while also pushing into regions considered strongholds of the ruling TMC. According to the schedule shared by the BJP, Modi will address his first rally at 9.30 am in Haldia Township in Purba Medinipur district, followed by another at the Outdoor Stadium in Polo Ground in Asansol at noon. The third public meeting is scheduled to be held at Chandmari Field in Siuri town of Birbhum district at 2 pm.

S Jaishankar to embark on four-day visit to Mauritius

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar will on Thursday embark on a four-day visit to Mauritius and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) to discuss ways to bolster bilateral ties. In the first leg of his trip, Jaishankar will travel to Mauritius to attend the 9th Indian Ocean Conference and review the entire spectrum of bilateral ties. The external affairs minister will meet the leadership of Mauritius and review the entire spectrum of bilateral ties, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on Jaishankar's April 9 to 10 visit to the island nation.

Veteran Congress leader Mohsina Kidwai passes away at 94

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

Veteran Congress leader and former Union minister Mohsina Kidwai, who held key ministerial portfolios under former prime ministers Indira Gandhi and Rajiv Gandhi, passed away on Wednesday at the age of 94.

Kidwai, who was suffering from age-related ailments, breathed her last at Noida's Metro Hospital early in the morning, her son-in-law Razi Ur Rehman Kidwai said. Kidwai was laid to rest at the graveyard in Nizamuddin this evening with former party chief Rahul Gandhi attending the last rites.

Earlier, top Congress leaders paid tributes to Kidwai and AICC president Mallikarjun Kharge visited her house in Noida to express condolences to her family members. Kharge said that her passing is a profound loss to the party and to the nation.

"Deeply saddened by the passing of Mohsina Kidwai ji, a stalwart of the Congress party and a former Union minister who dedicated over six decades of her life to the service of the nation," Kharge said on X.

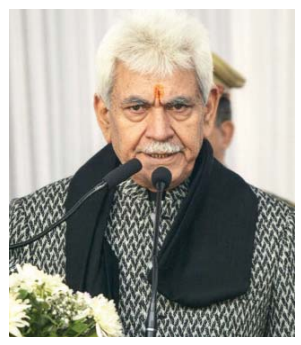
"A long-serving Member of Parliament in both the Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha, and a respected member of the Congress Working Committee for several years, she remained a guiding force within the party through its most challenging phases," the Congress chief said.

He expressed heartfelt condolences to her "family, friends and countless admirers" and wished that "her soul rest in eternal peace".

Rahul Gandhi also condoled Kidwai's demise and hailed her contribution to the party.

J&K LG terminates 2 Govt employees over terror links

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu



Jammu and Kashmir Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha on Wednesday terminated the services of two more Government employees for their alleged links with pro Pakistan terror outfits, including Lashkar-e-Taiba and Hizbul Mujahideen.

So far more than 90 Government employees with alleged terror links have been dismissed in Jammu and Kashmir.

The dismissals were carried out under Article 311(2)(c) of the Constitution as part of the administration's "zero-tolerance to terror" policy.

One of the employees whose services have been terminated have been identified as Farhat Ali Khanday, a Class-IV employee in the education department in Ramban district.

According to the dossier, Khanday was allegedly working for Hizbul Mujahideen and using his Government position as a cover to revive militant activities and build networks in the region.

According to sources, Khanday first came under the radar of security agencies in 2011 during investigations into a hawala network involved in distributing funds to families of militants.

He was arrested the same year but later secured bail and allegedly continued his activities.

Investigations revealed that he remained in contact with militant networks and acted as a facilitator. A chargesheet was filed against him in a special court in 2022, they said.

"We didn't know that Farhat was working for Hizbul Mujahideen until April 2011. His name came out during the interrogation of a Hizbul Mujahideen terrorist, who was nabbed by Jammu and Kashmir Police for distributing terror money to seven terrorist families. Police picked up Farhat and put him behind bars, but in October 2011, he managed to get bail and continued his terror activities," official sources revealed.

The second employee, Mohammad Shafi Dar from Bandipora, was working in the rural development department and had been appointed on compassionate grounds, officials said.

He was allegedly acting as a terror associate of Lashkar-e-Taiba, providing logistical and operational support, including arranging safe houses, facilitating movement of militants, and sharing sensitive information about security forces, they added.

Dar was apprehended in April 2025 during a joint naka check. Arms and ammunition, including an AK-56 rifle and a grenade, were recovered from his possession, sources said.

Further investigation suggested that he had become an active operational associate and was allegedly involved in planning attacks on security forces.

Union Cabinet clears draft bill for amendments to Women Reservation Act

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

The Union Cabinet is learnt to have cleared on Wednesday the draft bill for amendments to the Women's Reservation Act that will ensure an increase in the number of Lok Sabha seats to 816 with 273 reserved for women, and its implementation in the 2029 general elections.

Sources privy to the development said that a meeting of the Cabinet, chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, approved the draft bill for the amendments to the law, Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, more commonly known as the Women's Reservation Act.

The Government has extended the budget session of Parliament and a special three-day sitting will be held from April 16 to 18, where the amendment bill is expected to be passed.

The provision to provide 33 per cent reservation to women in the Lok Sabha and State assemblies was brought by amending the Constitution in 2023, but it would have come into effect after the completion of the delimitation exercise on the basis of the 2027 Census. Therefore, it was expected to come into force only in 2034 if the present law remains as it is.

According to the broad contours available, the number of Lok Sabha seats would be increased from the present 543 to 816, with 273 seats reserved for women. The reservation will also be done on a "vertical basis" with seats allocated for SCs and STs.

The redrawing of the constituencies will be done on the basis of the 2011 census rather than the proposed 2027 census.

Assam CM using police to intimidate rather than replying to charges on wife: Khera

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Guwahati

Congress leader Pawan Khera on Wednesday accused Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma of "unleashing" the State police on him instead of addressing the Opposition party's questions on multiple passports and foreign investments linked to the CM's wife.

He also criticised the chief minister for using "derogatory" words against Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, maintaining it was not reflective of the age-old rich culture of the State.

Khera, who has moved the Telangana High Court seeking anticipatory bail in a case filed against him by the Assam Government over his allegations against Sarma's wife, showed his residential address in Hyderabad and requested release on bail in the event of arrest. The petition, filed on April 7, will be taken up by the court on April 9.

In a recorded video addressed to the CM from an undisclosed location, Khera said, "Our party had only asked you some questions. Why do you want to silence us? We have asked questions; give us the replies."

He added, "Instead of replying, you are hurling abuses at everyone, you have put police behind me. I am not afraid of them. But I am avoiding them as I have more questions to ask."

Khera reiterated questions regarding a purported company registered in the US State of Wyoming in the name of Sarma's wife, Riniki Bhuyan Sarma, claiming that the official company website lists a London address as primary and two other addresses in Dubai and Dhaka.

The company, Bhuyan Properties LLC, has Bhuyan Sarma as the 'Manager, authorised member', with nationality of Antigua and Barbuda, along with mentioning of "multiple" other nationalities.

Khera alleged that the London address of this company is also linked with one 'Bhuyan Properties Ltd', as available in UK Government records.

Rahul urges Assam voters to fight corruption, hatred

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

A day before polling for the Assam Assembly election, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi appealed to the people of the State on Wednesday to vote for change, asserting that the polls are not just about changing the Government but for eradicating violence, corruption and hatred.

In a video message posted on X, Gandhi attacked Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, calling him the "most corrupt chief minister", and said he has crossed all boundaries while indulging in graft.

"This election is not just about changing the Government but about eradicating violence, corruption and hatred. The chief minister of Assam is the most corrupt chief minister in India and has crossed all boundaries in corruption. The whole of Assam knows this and understands this," the leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha said.

"The Congress has given you guarantees that within 100 days, we will ensure justice for Zubeen Garg's family. The second guarantee is of a new health insurance system for Assam under which every family would have a cover of ₹25 lakh. We will create a new ministry for our senior citizens and every month, they will get ₹1,250 as pension," he said in his video appeal to the people of Assam.

Women will get an unconditional bank account transfer and ₹50,000 for starting a new business, the former Congress president said.

Union Cabinet clears ₹13,038 crore Jaipur Metro Phase-2 project

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
New Delhi/Jaipur

> Jaipur is set for a major infrastructural upgrade! Cabinet approval for Jaipur Metro Phase-2 is a significant step towards sustainable urban growth. It will expand connectivity, reduce congestion and enhance 'Ease of Living'
>
> — PM NARENDRA MODI

In a noticeable push for urban mobility, the Union Cabinet chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday approved the second phase of the Jaipur Metro Rail Project. Estimated to cost ₹13,038 crores. This project will have a 41-km North-South corridor from Prahladpura to Todi Mod with 36 stations.

Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw announced the decisions taken by the union cabinet for developing infrastructure in Rajasthan. "The approval is part of a larger set of Cabinet decisions clearing projects worth approximately ₹1.74 lakh crore, which also include nutrient subsidies for farmers, expansion of the HPCL Rajasthan Refinery and major hydropower initiatives".

The decision to grant approval for the Jaipur Metro Phase-2, is being hailed as a game-changer for Rajasthan's urban transport landscape, positioning Jaipur as one of the faster-growing metro cities in India.

It will provide seamless connectivity between southern industrial and residential zones; Sitapura, Prahladpura, Sanganer and northern areas including Todi Mod, Ambabari, Vidhyadhar Nagar), passing through key landmarks like Gandhi Nagar, Tonk Phatak, Sawai Man Singh Hospital vicinity and potential interchanges with the existing Pink Line in Phase-1.

Once fully operational, the phase-2 will serve lakhs of daily commuters, including workers in industrial areas, airport-bound passengers, and residents in rapidly growing suburbs. It will boost economic activity by improving last-mile connectivity to commercial hubs, educational institutions and healthcare facilities. Once fully operational, this project is expected to generate substantial direct and indirect employment during construction and operations. The project aligns with the broader vision of expanding Jaipur's metro network, which currently operates the 9 km long Pink Line from Mansarovar to Chandpole under Phase-1.

Phase-2 will integrate with existing infrastructure, including a possible interchange at Chandpole and foot-over-bridge links at Jaipur Junction Railway Station. Officials said the work to construct phase-2 metro is anticipated to begin following the Cabinet nod as some advanced civil works have already been completed. The project will be completed within the stipulated period.

Interestingly, Rajasthan Chief Minister Bhajan Lal Sharma had earlier approved the Detailed Project Report (DPR) and put the proposal to the Centre on fast track. The chief minister laid emphasis on the project's importance for the State's capital.

Second phase of Jagannath temple's Ratna Bhandar inventory begins

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Puri

The second phase of the inventory of the Puri Jagannath temple's Ratna Bhandar (treasury) commenced on Wednesday and is scheduled to continue till April 11, officials said. The first day of the second phase of inventory continued for seven hours, an official said.

A select team of servitors, gemologists and goldsmiths entered the sacred treasury at 11.30 am, along with Ratna Bhandar Committee chairman Justice Biswanath Rath, and Shree Jagannath Temple Administration's (SJTA) Chief Administrator, Arabinda Padhee.

The inventory work will be held on April 9, 10, and 11, while subsequent sessions are scheduled on April 13, and then again from April 16 to 18, Padhee said.

The exercise, the first in 48 years, began on March 25, and the daily-use ornaments of the deities were inventorised on the first phase.

Gajapati Maharaja Dibyasingha Deb, the titular king of Puri, inspected the inventory work inside the Ratna Bhandar.

He is also the chairman of the Shree Jagannath Temple Managing Committee (SJTMC), the highest decision-making body of the 12th-century shrine.

"The inventory work is going on smoothly in presence of SJTA chief administrator Arabinda Padhee and Justice Rath. Only selected persons were present in Ratna Bhandar during the inventory," Deb said.

Expressing satisfaction over the inventory works, the Gajapati Maharaja said that the SOP approved by the State Government is strictly followed and scientific inventory is done through videography, photography, and 3D mapping to ensure transparency.

Deb said there should not be any time frame for completion of the exercise, but the stress should be given on accuracy and perfection.

Replying to a question, he said that efforts are on to complete inventory work by the '*Snan Purnima*' bathing ritual on June 29, before the annual Rath Yatra.

Meanwhile, Law Minister Harichandan said that during the ongoing inventory, the articles and valuables are aligned with those conducted last time in 1978. Now, digital photography is also being arranged to create a detailed visual record of the valuables, the minister said.

The temple functions under the law department of the Odisha Government.

States Focus

PALANISWAMI SLAMS STALIN, CALLS TN GOVT A FAILURE MODEL

AIADMK chief Edappadi K Palaniswami on Wednesday flayed the Stalin-led Government, labelling it as a "failure model" that could not deliver its promises on filling up Government posts, giving jobs to youth, or even preventing massive inundation in Chennai during monsoons. Terming DMK as "evil", he asked people to oust their Government from Tamil Nadu. He said that during the last five years of the DMK rule, people suffered hardship in many ways, including deterioration of law and order, no safety for women, girls and people. "People are living in fear under the present DMK regime. During the AIADMK regime, the rule of law was upheld and people lived without fear in a safe atmosphere. AIADMK Government took stern and prompt action on the wrongdoers then," Palaniswami said in Velacherry rally.

NITIN NABIN HOLDS ROADSHOW IN JALPAIGURI DISTRICT'S MAINAGURI

BJP national president Nitin Nabin on Wednesday led a roadshow in Mainaguri town of Jalpaiguri district in support of the party's candidates for the West Bengal Assembly elections. The streets reverberated with slogans of 'Bharat Mata ki Jai' and other chants backing the saffron party as Nabin rode an open jeep flanked by BJP candidates. Supporters carrying party flags and balloons lined the nearly two-km route from Hogla Factory to Natun Bazar bus terminus. "The huge presence of people in this rally is an indicator of the BJP's victory in the Assembly elections," Nabin said.

Will move court again on voter deletions: Mamata

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Wednesday hit out at the BJP and the Election Commission of India (ECI) over voter deletions during the SIR exercise and said her party will move a court again to resist the removal of electors from the rolls.

Her comments came after nearly 91 lakh voters' names were deleted from the electoral rolls following the completion of the Special Intensive Revision in the State.

"You will not be able to defeat the TMC by deleting names. We will move a court again to resist the exclusion of names," Banerjee said while attacking her principal challenger BJP over the roll revision exercise.

Banerjee had in February argued in the Supreme Court as she sought an intervention in the SIR process.

The ECI figures showed the total deletion of over 90.83 lakh names from the original voter base of 7.66 crore in October 2025.

Criticising the poll panel over the SIR process, the TMC supremo said, "We will fight legally to get the names included on the list as per the Constitution. If people cannot cast their votes, what is the need to frame the tribunal? And then you are saying that the list has been frozen. What is this? We will challenge it and try to understand it."

Addressing a poll rally at Arambagh in Hooghly district, the TMC supremo accused the saffron party of trying to manipulate the electoral rolls and offering money to woo voters.

Banerjee also charged the Election Commission with intimidating people over the phone. "It (ECI) is working at the behest of the BJP. It is calling people over the telephone to threaten and intimidate them," she claimed.

Later, while speaking at a rally in Balagarh in the same district, Banerjee warned that voting for the BJP would effectively mean "giving up fish, meat, and speaking in Bengali".

"People are not allowed to eat eggs, fish, or meat in the BJP-ruled States like Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, and Maharashtra. The same will happen here if the BJP comes to power," Banerjee claimed.

Addressing another rally in Sreerampore, the TMC supremo alleged that the BJP was planning to divide Bengal in the garb of delimitation.

West Bengal CM and TMC candidate from Bhabanipur constituency, Mamata Banerjee, filing her nomination in the State Assembly elections in Kolkata PTI

MAMATA BANERJEE FILES NOMINATION FOR BHABANIPUR SEAT

Kolkata: Turning her nomination filing for the Bhabanipur seat into a political counteroffensive to the BJP's call for "*paribartan* ", West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Wednesday marched from her Kalighat residence to submit her papers, projecting the constituency as a "mini India" under siege of polarisation.

Amid slogans of '*Mamata Banerjee zindabad* ', '*Joy Bangla*' and '*TMC zindabad* ', Banerjee led a colourful procession to the Alipore Survey Building, where she filed her nomination papers for the constituency that revived her electoral career in 2021. With folded hands and her trademark smile, Banerjee walked nearly 600 metres with women supporters blowing conch shells and raising ululations and party workers waving Trinamool Congress flags. If BJP leader Suvendu Adhikari's nomination filing last week, accompanied by Union Home Minister Amit Shah, was designed as a show of saffron strength and a call for "paribartan", Banerjee's roadshow on Wednesday was carefully choreographed as its ideological opposite.

"I was born and brought up here in Bhabanipur only. I stay here 365 days a year. My life, my work, my movements everything revolves around Bhabanipur. Everything in my life began from here. I thank and salute the people of Bhabanipur," Banerjee said after filing her nomination papers. Seeking to widen the contest beyond Bhabanipur, Banerjee appealed to electors across Bengal to vote for the TMC. "I appeal to the people not only in Bhabanipur but in all the 294 seats to ensure the victory of our candidates. We will win with a bigger mandate," she said. The TMC had won 213 of the 294 seats in the 2021 assembly polls. But the sharpest political message of the day came through the issue of voter roll revision. Banerjee alleged that large-scale deletions under the SIR had hit Muslims and women disproportionately and said the TMC would again move a court against the freezing of electoral rolls.

Stalin slams PM Modi over women's free bus travel remark, mocks AIADMK

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Cuddalore (Tamil Nadu)

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister MK Stalin on Tuesday took strong exception to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's remark that free bus travel scheme for women could undermine financial viability of projects like metro rail, and claimed that Modi doesn't seem to care for women.

The remark came as he was addressing a poll campaign in support of the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance candidates here on Tuesday night.

Stalin said, according to the prime minister, the free bus travel (Vidiyal Payanam) for women launched by the DMK, would affect the profit of metro rail.

"This shows that the prime minister doesn't seem to care about the advancement of women. If the NDA comes to power in Tamil Nadu, it will halt this scheme," Stalin, who is the president of DMK, claimed. He was referring to a recent remark by Modi in an interview claiming permanent free bus travel schemes for women could undermine the financial viability of metro rail.

The chief minister, however, countered, saying the initiative was "economic revolution" that empowered women.

Stalin also mocked AIADMK chief Edappadi K Palaniswami for "surrendering" Tamil Nadu's rights to the BJP and alleged that Palaniswami has turned the party, named after former Chief Minister CN Annadurai, into "Amit Shah DMK".

"If Tamil Nadu should move forward in top gear, then the 'Dravidian Model 2.0' Government must be formed again," Stalin said, adding that the DMK's return would ensure more development for the State.

Tamil Nadu CM and DMK candidate from Kolathur constituency, MK Stalin, interacting with women workers during a voter outreach ahead of the State Assembly elections in Tiruvannamalai on Wednesday PTI

Congress levels vote-for-cash allegation in Palakkad; BJP denies

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Palakkad (Kerala)

Congress alleged that Sobha Surendran, the BJP candidate of the Palakkad constituency in Kerala, was "caught red-handed distributing" cash to voters ahead of April 9 elections to the State Assembly. Surendran denied the allegations, calling them "fabricated" to defeat her.

He alleged that a local Congress leader and a journalist of a TV channel were behind the allegations, and she would be filing a police case against them.

The BJP leader claimed that a video aired on TV channels, showing some women "offering something" to an elderly woman in her constituency, was wrongly projected by the Congress and the journalist to allege that she offered money for votes.

Visuals aired on TV channels show a woman offering something to the elderly woman, and thereafter, another group goes to her and opens her hand to reveal a small roll of ₹500 currency notes.

Based on the video, it was alleged that the elderly woman was given money by someone in the BJP candidate's campaign team.

However, the elderly woman denied having received any money, but admitted to having asked for ₹5,000 for buying medicines.

The visuals also showed Surendran getting out of her car and arguing with a few men who had shot the video, questioning how they could take her visuals without her permission. Surendran claimed that she got out of the car as one of the men made "sexually harassing gestures" at her.

Following the incident, Congress general secretary KC Venugopal, in a post on X, alleged, "The BJP candidate in Palakkad is caught red-handed distributing cash on the eve of elections. All this, while the Election Commission is asleep and blissfully unaware of the electoral malpractice. It is in the BJP's DNA to manipulate elections, no matter what, no matter where".

"This is a crime, and the candidate must be punished for this blatant violation of election norms. She does not have the legal and moral standing to continue on the ballot," Venutgopal said in the post.

He said giving money to influence voters was a very serious violation of the election rules, and the BJP has been doing this in several places to sabotage elections, he said in a statement.

While the UDF was adhering to EC norms to not show political advertisements on TV channels and online platforms, the LDF and BJP were violating them, Venugopal, the Alappuzha MP, said.

The ECI, meanwhile, noted that political advertisements are appearing on channels and online platforms in violation of poll norms during the silent campaign period and sought that they be withdrawn immediately.

"It has been observed that many channels are violating these instructions. Cases will be registered against those who violate the instructions," it warned.

Besides this, the CPI(M) alleged that in one well-known constituency, over 300 bottles of liquor were found in a booth-level office of a prominent political party, but the seizure of only a small number was recorded. It has sought ECI's intervention in the matter.

BJP candidate in Kerala, Sobha Surendran

Congress general secretary KC Venugopal

9.50 lakh voters to decide fate of 294 candidates in Pondy: CEO

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Puducherry

Around 9.50 lakh voters will decide the electoral fate of 294 candidates in the Assembly elections in Puducherry on April 9 and all arrangements have been made for smooth conduct of polls, Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) P Jawahar said here on Wednesday.

The polling will begin at 7 am in Puducherry and its enclaves of Karaikal, Mahe and Yanam which together have 30 Assembly seats.

The union territory has 1,099 polling stations and of them 209 have been identified as vulnerable, Jawahar told media here.

Thirty polling stations would be managed exclusively by women staff and 15 booths would be operated by young officers. Two polling stations would be operated by persons with disabilities, he added.

The union territory has as many as 24,919 new voters, he said.

The CEO said senior citizens and differently-abled voters would be assisted by volunteers at the booths to reach the polling stations to cast their votes and also for their safe return to their homes. Wheelchairs will be available. The election authorities have engaged 2,200 young voters to take care of them, he said.

Jawahar said that deployment of drones for monitoring purposes had been of help to track persons indulging in activities that tarnished fair poll. He said cash and liquor were seized after drone surveillance was conducted. A total of Rs 77.25 lakh was seized at various points and liquor worth Rs 68.50 lakh was also seized.

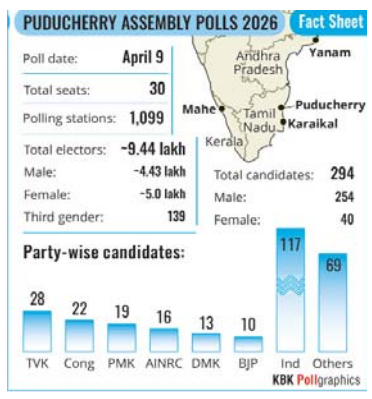
Seventeen cases were booked for alleged violation of the Model Code of Conduct during the past few weeks. As many as 24 persons were booked for allegedly distributing cash to lure the voters, he said.

Besides major political parties, newly floated parties are also in the fray.

The NDA comprising AINRC, BJP, AIADMK and LJK faces a challenge from the INDIA bloc comprising the Congress, DMK and the VCK.

While the NDA is fighting to retain its 'double engine' governance, the Opposition bloc is making a push to regain power in the union territory, focusing on issues of local autonomy and administrative friction.

Actor Vijay's newly formed TVK has emerged as a significant third force fielding candidates across the union territory.



Udalguri Congress candidate Daimari quits day before Assam poll

TONY DAS Guwahati

A day before polling in Assam, Congress candidate for the Udalguri seat, Suren Daimari, on Wednesday announced he has quit the party and "surrendered" his candidature. The Congress, however, said that he was yet to submit his resignation letter to the party. A senior election commission official, when contacted, said Daimari's name will remain in the EVM, and people can still vote for him since the deadline for withdrawing nomination has long passed.

Congress Spokesperson Bedabrata Bora told media that Daimari has announced his decision in front of the media and has not yet submitted his resignation letter to the party. Earlier in the day, Daimari told reporters that he has resigned from the Congress and "surrendered" his candidature. "There is no benefit of being in the Congress. It has betrayed me," he said.

"The Congress only works for the Miyas, but they do nothing for the Scheduled Tribes like me," Daimari alleged. He claimed that after nominating him from the Udalguri seat, the Congress offered no support in campaigning.

"I called up the party leadership repeatedly, but they did not even receive my call. I am hurt because they did not help me at all. The district Congress committee did not help me," Daimari said. After waiting for a long time for a response, and when it did not come, the decision was taken to leave the party, he added.

When asked why he resigned just a day before the polling, Daimari said: "I have not betrayed the party, the party has betrayed me." In the situation arising from Daimari's announcement, the senior poll panel official clarified that the deadline for withdrawing nominations had long passed and candidates' names had already been loaded onto the EVMs.

"In fact, the polling parties have left for their polling stations. So, there is no question of withdrawing one's name now from the contest," he added.

Polling for the 126-member Assam Assembly will be held on April 9, while the results will be declared on May 4. Four candidates are in the fray for the Udalguri Assembly seat.

Suren Daimari

Kerala LoP urges ECI to ensure smooth postal voting for Govt staff

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Thiruvananthapuram

Leader of the Opposition in the State Assembly, VD Satheesan, on Wednesday sought the EC's intervention to ensure that Government employees can exercise their franchise without any hindrance through the postal voting process.

In a letter to Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar, Satheesan said the issue has already been brought to the attention of the Kerala Chief Electoral Officer by postal voters from all 14 districts, but "no effective remedial measures have been implemented". Assembly polls for 140 constituencies in Kerala will be held on April 9. He said many such employees have also approached him, seeking assistance in resolving these difficulties.

Satheesan said that under the earlier system, eligible Government servants could receive their postal ballots at their residences upon application, which significantly enhanced accessibility and voter participation.

International delegation arrives in Assam to observe Assembly polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Guwahati

A 15-member international delegation has arrived in Guwahati to observe the ongoing electoral process for the Assam Legislative Assembly elections as part of the International Election Visitors Programme (IEVP).

The delegation includes representatives from election management bodies of seven countries Angola, Egypt, Portugal, Sri Lanka, Mexico, Benin, and Croatia along with three officials from the Election Commission of India (ECI).

Their two-day visit is aimed at gaining firsthand insight into India's electoral system and practices. The IEVP initiative is designed to showcase the strengths and scale of India's election management while encouraging the exchange of best practices among participating countries. The programme offers visiting delegates a comprehensive understanding of India's electoral framework, institutional mechanisms, and innovations in election administration.

Upon their arrival at Lokpriya Gopinath Bordoloi International Airport, the delegates were divided into three groups and taken to various distribution centres and control rooms across Kamrup Metropolitan and Kamrup districts.

These visits allowed them to assess on-ground preparations for the elections. The delegation later visited the Webcasting Monitoring Centre at the office of the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) in Assam.

During a meeting at the CEO's office, Chief Electoral Officer Anurag Goel, State Police Nodal Officer Akhilesh Singh, and other senior officials briefed the visitors on key aspects of the electoral process, including logistics, security, and technology deployment.

On April 9, which is polling day, the delegates are scheduled to visit polling stations in both districts. They will observe various stages of the voting process, including mock polls, security arrangements, and the use of election technology.

TVK chief Vijay hits out at Tamil Nadu CM over campaigning issue

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Tirunelveli (Tamil Nadu)

Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) chief Vijay launched a scathing attack on the ruling DMK during a campaign rally in Tirunelveli, alleging that if Chief Minister MK Stalin had "full powers", the event would not have happened.

"The CM would have put some kind of obstacle and prevented us from coming. But now, this is a "caretaker Government," as it is called, and he's a CM without authority," Vijay said. Dubbing the DMK-led bloc a "cash-box alliance", the actor-turned-politician alleged it was formed using "looted" money. He claimed the constituent parties lack internal unity, stating that "people in the alliance won't even cast vote for each other".

Taking a swipe at the grand old party, Vijay alleged that the DMK had "pocketed" the Tamil Nadu Congress by "giving crores". However, he asserted that the "real Congress" stands on the TVK's side.

TVK chief and candidate from the Tiruchirappalli East constituency, Vijay, during a public meeting ahead of the TN Assembly elections in Tirunelveli PTI

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Can non-devotees challenge customs: SC to Centre

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday asked the Centre how persons who are not devotees of Lord Ayyappa could challenge the customs of the Sabarimala temple in Kerala.

The remark was made by a nine-judge Constitution bench hearing petitions related to discrimination against women at religious places, including the Sabarimala temple in Kerala, and on the ambit and scope of religious freedom practised by multiple faiths.

The bench comprises Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, Justices BV Nagarathna, MM Sundresh, Ahsanuddin Amanullah, Aravind Kumar, Augustine George Masih, Prasanna B Varale, R Mahadevan and Joymalya Bagchi.

The top court has framed seven questions on the scope of religious freedom. One of the questions was whether a person not belonging to a religious denomination or religious group can question a practice of that "religious denomination or religious group" by filing a public interest litigation (PIL).

As the bench was about to rise for the day, Justice Nagarathna sought to know from Solicitor General Tushar Mehta as to who were the petitioners in the Sabarimala case.

"What follows from what you have just submitted is that the original petitioners are not devotees. No devotee has approached this court challenging this. Then, who are the writ petitioners who are assailing this?" she asked.

Mehta replied that the original petitioner is a lawyers' body called Indian Young Lawyers Association.

Justice Nagarathna said, "They are not devotees. But let us be clear. Can any devotee of Lord Ayyappa file a writ petition challenging this? If a non-devotee, a person who is not concerned with that temple, challenges it, can this court entertain such a writ petition?

"We have all been trained. We have all practised in trial courts. If a suit is filed by an association, the first question would be under Order VII Rule 11(a) of the Code of Civil Procedure. No cause of action, no causal connection, the plaint would be rejected." The CJI said he has often used the term invisible victims of the judicial system for such petitioners.

Mehta termed it as a fight between the silent majority and the vocal minority.

"Your Lordships rarely sit in a Bench of nine. PIL jurisdiction was initiated in Bandhua Mukti Morcha v Union of India at a time when people had no means to approach the court. I have pointed out in my written submissions that today the judicial system has become far more transparent. By e-filing, even a letter can reach the court.

"Now, nobody needs representation through another for an unrepresented class. If someone has no means, they can approach the District Legal Services Authority and say: my fundamental rights are violated, advise me, or file a petition on my behalf before the Supreme Court or the High Court.

"Then why, my Lords, should such PILs be entertained? And we know that many PILs today are motivated PILs. Somebody else is behind them," Mehta said.

Order Order

HC quashes ECI notification for April 9 Ponda Assembly by-election in Goa

The Bombay High Court on Wednesday declared as "null and void" the Election Commission of India's notification for the Ponda Assembly byelection, effectively cancelling the April 9 poll.

Justices Valmiki Menezes and Amit Jamsandekar of the Goa bench of the HC passed the order on petitions filed by two voters who had challenged the validity of the notification on the ground that less than one year of the current assembly's term is left.

The byelection was necessitated by the death of former Goa minister Ravi Naik in October last year. The ECI had notified polling for April 9 and counting on May 4. The petitioners argued that under the Representation of the People Act, holding a byelection is not mandatory if the remainder of the Assembly's term is less than one year. The new MLA would serve only for a few months, they pointed out.

Judgements on adultery, same-sex relationship 'not a good law': Centre in SC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

The Centre on Wednesday told the Supreme Court that the two landmark judgements on decriminalising adultery and same-sex consensual relationships were based on the subjective application of "constitutional morality" and should be declared as "not a good law".

The submission was made during the hearing by a nine-judge Constitution bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on the petitions related to discrimination against women at religious places, including the Sabarimala temple in Kerala, and on the ambit and scope of religious freedom practised by multiple faiths.

The top court has framed seven questions on the scope of religious freedom. One of the questions was as to what is the scope and extent of the word 'morality' under Articles 25 and 26 of the Constitution, and whether it is meant to include Constitutional morality?" Advancing arguments on the second day, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Centre, submitted that the concept of constitutional morality is a sentiment and it is not a doctrine upon which a legislation can be tested.

"In a country governed by democratic principles, it is always the majoritarian view which prevails, particularly when it comes to testing a law, because it is the majority which enacts the law.

"How do you then define morality on that basis? Thereafter, subsequently, there may be an evolution or change in understanding," Mehta said.

Dealing with the issue of the scope of judicial review, Mehta referred to top court judgements decriminalising adultery (Joseph Shine) and same-sex consensual relationships (Navtej Singh Johar).

The top court, on a plea filed by NRI Joseph Shine, had in 2018 struck down Section 497 of the Indian Penal Code dealing with the offence of adultery, holding it unconstitutional.

A five-judge Constitution bench in 2018 had decriminalised homosexuality by partially striking down the colonial-era provisions of Section 377 of the Indian Penal Code on a plea filed by dancer Navtej Singh Johar.

SG Mehta said, "One of the questions is what is the extent of judicial review and what is constitutional morality. Whether social or constitutional morality, there is a judgment in the Joseph Shine case. This is a judgment, I am little concerned as a citizen, as a student of law and therefore — this was an adultery provision under challenge.

"Some "Feminist Legal Methods" by Katharine T. Bartlett, Harvard Law Review, is quoted which is a law under Article 141 of the Constitution and binds 140 crore Indians," Mehta said.

The CJI said that the Joseph Shine judgment cites Jeffrey A Segal as a well-known American legal scholar. "Who is this Segal? He has almost been referred here as if he is the second Ambedkar?" the CJI said.

Thane court acquits 8 in attempted murder of policeman in 2016

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Thane

A court in Maharashtra's Thane has acquitted eight men charged with the attempted murder of a police constable, citing the victim's inability to identify his attackers and the fact that key prosecution witnesses turned hostile.

In her judgment delivered on April 6, Additional Sessions Judge VL Bhosale gave the benefit of doubt to the accused, observing that the prosecution had failed to prove its case beyond reasonable doubt.

A copy of the order was made available on Wednesday.

According to the prosecution, constable Bhaskar Sonavane was assaulted with sticks and beer bottles outside a bar in the city's Upvan area on April 21, 2016.

The attack was a fallout of a dispute between the hotel management and a customer named Kamlesh, whose brother Arun led 10-15 persons to the site, it said. Sonavane, who was at the spot to meet an informant, suffered a skull fracture and brain injuries in the attack, the court was informed during the trial.

The eight accused persons had been facing charges for attempted murder under the Indian Penal Code.

The court noted that the constable himself could not identify "any of the accused as the assailants, since the incident occurred at nighttime and he lost consciousness after being struck on the head".

Additionally, the hotel partner Rajesh Shetty and manager Naveen Gouda, who was the original complainant, both turned hostile, the judge noted.

"Having regard to all the evidence on record, I find that the prosecution has failed to prove beyond reasonable doubt that the accused persons charged in this case committed the offences," said the court, acquitting all the accused.

Delhi HC rejects AgustaWestland middleman James' plea seeking release from jail

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Wednesday dismissed a petition by alleged middleman Christian Michel James in the ₹3,600-crore AgustaWestland VVIP chopper scam case seeking his release from jail.

A bench of Justices Navin Chawla and Ravinder Dudeja said there was no merit in the petition by the British national, who was extradited from Dubai in December 2018.

A detailed copy of the verdict is awaited.

In his petition, James assailed a provision of the India-UAE extradition treaty. He also challenged a trial court order of August 7, 2025 by which his application under Section 436A of the Code of Criminal Procedure (CrPC) for his release from jail was rejected.

James challenged Article 17 of the treaty, signed in 1999, which allows the requesting state (in this case India) to prosecute extradited persons not only for the specific offence for which extradition was done, but also for connected offences.

It was contended that an extradited person can be prosecuted only for the offences for which extradition took place, and not for connected offences.

After his extradition, James was arrested by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) and the Enforcement Directorate (ED).

James also submitted that he completed seven years in jail on December 4, 2025 and has, therefore, already undergone the maximum sentence possible for the offences for which he was extradited, rendering his continued detention in India illegal.

James is among the three alleged middlemen being probed in the case, and the other two are Guido Haschke and Carlo Gerosa.

He was granted bail by the Supreme Court in the CBI case in February 2025. The high court granted him bail in the ED case in March that year. James, however, continues to be in jail as he was unable to fulfil the bail conditions.

Tweets by journalist Rana Ayyub derogatory, communal: Delhi HC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Wednesday termed certain tweets by journalist Rana Ayyub "highly derogatory, inflammatory and communal" as it sought her stand on a petition seeking removal of the allegedly objectionable content from social media.

Justice Purushaindra Kumar Kaurav, who was hearing a lawyer's petition alleging that Ayyub's tweets insulted Hindu Deities and "revered historical figures", observed that even an FIR was also directed to be registered against her in relation to the tweets and called upon the Centre, Delhi Police and X to "work in tandem" and "do the needful in 24 hours".

"Let the matter be called day after. Action is necessary in view of the highly derogatory, inflammatory and communal tweets by respondent no. 4 (Ayyub), pursuant to which FIR has also been directed against respondent no. 4 by a court of competent jurisdiction," the court ordered.

Observing that the "matter requires consideration", the court issued notice to the Centre, Ayyub as well as X on the petition seeking the immediate removal of the "highly derogatory, inflammatory, and communal tweets" by Ayyub.

The court also made Delhi Police a party to the case.

Rana Ayyub

Petitioner Amita Sachdeva said she is a devout follower of the Sanatan Dharm, and on her complaint, a magisterial court had already directed the registration of an FIR while holding that the journalist's tweets prima facie disclose cognisable offences under the Indian Penal Code.

The plea said the petitioner approached X's resident grievance officer as well as the Grievance Appellate Committee for the removal of the content. However, the committee declined to grant relief, stating the matter was sub-judice, it added.

The petitioner said the continued public availability of the tweets has caused continuing and direct injury to her religious sentiments and violated her fundamental rights guaranteed under Articles 21 (Right to life and liberty) and 25 (Freedom of religion) of the Constitution.

Delhi HC seeks Centre's stand on petitions challenging amended transgender law

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Wednesday sought the Centre's stand on two petitions challenging provisions of the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Act, 2026 for taking away one's right to a self-perceived gender identity.

A bench of Chief Justice DK Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia issued notice on petitions by Chandresh Jain and Lakshay Jain and asked the central government to file its reply within six weeks. The Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Bill, 2026, was passed by Parliament on March 25 and received President Droupadi Murmu's assent on March 30. Petitioner Chandresh Jain said the Act "removes and dilutes" self-perceived gender identity and instead introduces a regime of State-controlled verification, certification and screening of gender identity, which violates rights to dignity, privacy and decisional autonomy under Article 21 of the Constitution.

His petition further said that the amendment Act is manifestly arbitrary and disproportionate, and it infringes Article 19(1)(a) by restricting the expression of gender identity.

Lakshya Jain's petition said that the amendment altered the existing statutory framework by replacing self-perceived gender identity with a regime of medical and administrative verification, including scrutiny by a district magistrate (DM).

NCDRC stays bailable warrants against Salman Khan in pan masala advertisement case

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

The National Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission has stayed the execution of bailable warrants issued against actor Salman Khan in a case related to the alleged misleading advertisement linked to a pan masala brand, and directed that the original records of the proceedings be produced before it.

A bench comprising NCDRC President Justice AP Sahi and member Bharatkumar Pandey ordered the Rajasthan State Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission to summon the complete records from the Jaipur District Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission and forward them to the registrar of the national commission.

"In order to appreciate the arguments and the assumptions raised, it would be appropriate to examine the records of the district commission as well as the state commission," the bench said in its order.

The commission directed that the records, including proceedings initiated under Section 72 of the Consumer Protection Act, 2019, be sent through a special messenger after being summoned from the district commission.

Pending the consideration of this matter, the NCDRC stated that the execution of any warrants issued by the district commission would remain in abeyance.

"We also direct that the execution of any warrants issued by the district commission shall remain in abeyance till the disposal of this matter before us," the order stated.

A notice has been issued to the complainant, advocate Yogendra Singh Badiyal, directing that it be served through both the state and district consumer commissions. Additionally, the notice will be sent via registered speed post.

"We therefore direct that the state commission, Rajasthan, shall send for the entire records of the district commission pertaining to the subject matter," it said.

Furthermore, the bench directed that since the original records of the district commission had been summoned, all further proceedings pursuant to the impugned orders would remain stayed until the matter is considered by it.

Authorities who had previously received directions from the district commission were also instructed to be informed about the ongoing proceedings before the national commission.

The matter is scheduled for admission on April 14, 2026.

Earlier on Tuesday, Senior advocate Ravi Prakash, appearing for Khan, had argued that the district commission adopted coercive and disproportionate measures, including issuing bailable warrants without proper service of orders on the actor.

He contended that applications for certified copies of the orders were pending, despite the orders having been reported in the media.

According to the plea, the district commission had also directed the constitution of a Special Task Force to secure Khan's presence, which the counsel described as unusual in consumer proceedings.

The dispute originates from a complaint filed in December 2025 with the Jaipur District Consumer Commission against Rajshree Pan Masala and Khan, claiming that their advertisement constituted a surrogate promotion of pan masala and was a misleading advertisement under the Consumer Protection Act.

Khan was named as Opposite Party no 2 in his capacity as the brand ambassador for "Rajshree Elaichi."

On January 6, 2026, the district commission passed an interim order directing the respondents to refrain from issuing misleading advertisements. According to Khan's plea, the order was passed ex parte without notice to him. Subsequently, a contempt application under Section 72 of the Act was filed alleging violation of the order based on a hoarding featuring the actor.

On January 15, 2026, the district commission issued bailable warrants against Khan in the contempt proceedings. Khan challenged the order before the Rajasthan State Consumer Commission under Section 73 of the Act.

However, by a judgment dated March 16, 2026, the state commission dismissed the appeal and upheld the issuance of the bailable warrants.

Editor's TAKE

A fragile ceasefire and the limits of power

Trump's warning of civilisational destruction if Iran failed to meet his deadline borders on a threat of genocide, and has triggered widespread outrage

As the deadline set by Donald Trump expired, the United States and Iran have agreed to a two-week ceasefire, halting a rapidly escalating conflict that had pushed the region to the brink of a nuclear war. It comes after Trump categorically threatened to 'annihilate the entire civilisation.' Trump even declared that "whole civilizations" could be wiped out if Tehran did not comply. While Iran's leadership, led by Mojtaba Khamenei, agreed to the ceasefire amid sustained military pressure, it was quick to stress that this is "not the end of the war." Tehran has tied any lasting peace to stringent conditions, including sanctions relief, compensation, and security guarantees. The US President Donald Trump has been outlandish well before he declared war against Iran on February 28. He sent his fighter jets to Iran unprovoked, and when reportedly the negotiations were reaching a logical conclusion. Even before that, he unilaterally declared tariffs, disrupting world trade and alienating even his close allies. The war against Iran, which he thought would be over in a couple of days, has dragged on for over a month with no signs of Iran caving in. Frustrated as he may be, he gave a deadline to Iran to open the Strait of Hormuz, which was summarily rejected by Iran. Hours before the deadline was to expire, he stated something which shocked even his close allies – a threat to annihilate the civilisation. In other words, a guised threat to drop a nuclear bomb, something no country has done for the last 80 years since the US dropped two nuclear bombs at Hiroshima and Nagasaki in Japan, killing thousands of people at the height of World War II. Donald Trump's threat to "wipe out" Iranian civilisation if Tehran failed to meet deadline oversteps the limits of leadership in a nuclear age. At one level, the statement can be read as brinkmanship. Yet there is a difference between signalling resolve and invoking the destruction of an entire people. It is a language no leader ever used, even at the height of the Cold War. The statement goes beyond coercive diplomacy explicitly prohibited under the Geneva Conventions. When the head of a nuclear state uses this as a threat, it is criminal.

The outrage from Democratic Party lawmakers is therefore justified. Patty Murray and Chris Coons have described the remarks as tantamount to threatening a war crime. Others, including Bonnie Watson Coleman, have gone further, calling for the invocation of the Twenty-fifth Amendment to the United States Constitution – a mechanism designed precisely for moments when a president is deemed unable to discharge the duties of office. But can it be invoked when the President becomes a threat to humanity? The president may have discretionary power in times of war, but that is subject to legal and moral limitations. Even if one grants that the threat was a bluff, the implications remain troubling. A nuclear bluff risks miscalculation and narrows the space for de-escalation. The United States has long claimed a leadership role grounded in the legitimacy of its conduct. It raises uncomfortable questions about whether the world can rely on the steadiness of American decision-making.

Together, let us empower our Nari Shakti!

India has always shown that when it comes to matters of national importance, it can rise above differences and act with unity. Let us move forward together and strengthen Constitutional values and empower our Nari Shakti for national progress

NARENDRA MODI

In the coming days, India will be immersed in a festive season, with celebrations taking place across the length and breadth of the nation. The people of Assam will mark Rongali Bihu while Odisha will celebrate Maha Bishuba Pana Sankranti. In West Bengal, Poila Boishakh will usher in the Bengali New Year and in Kerala, Vishu will be observed with immense enthusiasm. In Tamil Nadu, Puthandu will be celebrated while in Punjab and other parts of Northern India, it will be Baisakhi, which will usher in a spirit of hope as well as positivity. I convey my best wishes to all those across India and the world who are marking these festivals. May these auspicious occasions bring happiness and prosperity to everyone's lives.

Furthermore, on the 11th of April, we will commence the 200th birth anniversary celebrations of Mahatma Phule and on the 14th, India will pay homage to Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar on Ambedkar Jayanti.

In addition to these special occasions, when the spirit of renewal fills our hearts and minds, our nation stands at the threshold of another historic occasion. It is an opportunity to deepen the foundations of our democracy and to reaffirm our collective commitment to equality and inclusion.

On the 16th of April, Parliament will be convened to discuss and pass an important bill that advances women's reservation. To describe this merely as a legislative exercise would be an understatement. It is a reflection of the aspirations of crores of women across India. It is an affirmation of a principle that has long guided our civilisational ethos, that society progresses when women progress.

Women constitute nearly half of India's population. Their contributions to our nation are vast and invaluable. Today, India is witnessing remarkable achievements by women across every field. From science and technology to entrepreneurship, from sports to the armed forces and from music to the arts, women are at the forefront of India's progress. Over the years, sustained efforts have been made to create an enabling environment for women's empowerment. Greater access to education, improved healthcare, enhanced financial inclusion and better access to basic amenities have strengthened the foundations of women's participation in economic and social life.

Yet, their representation in the world of politics and legislative bodies has not always been commensurate with their role in society.

> WOMEN CONSTITUTE NEARLY HALF OF INDIA'S POPULATION. THEIR CONTRIBUTIONS TO OUR NATION ARE VAST AND INVALUABLE. TODAY, INDIA IS WITNESSING REMARKABLE ACHIEVEMENTS BY WOMEN ACROSS EVERY FIELD

This is particularly unfortunate because when women participate in administration and decision-making, they bring with them experiences and insights that enrich public discourse and improve the quality of governance.

It is imperative that the 2029 Lok Sabha elections and the Assembly elections to the various states in the coming times are conducted with women's reservation in place. Over the decades, there have been repeated efforts to provide women with their rightful place in democratic institutions by the previous governments. Committees were made, bill drafts were introduced but they never saw the light of day. But the broad consensus has remained that women's representation in legislative bodies has to increase. In September 2023, Parliament passed the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam with the same spirit of consensus. I consider it to be among the most special occasions of my life.

This opportunity to ensure women's reservation also resonates deeply with the spirit of our Constitution. The makers of our Constitution envisioned a society where equality is both enshrined and realised in practice. Strengthening women's participation in legislative institutions is an important step towards fulfilling that vision. It reflects our commitment to building a society where every citizen has an equal stake in shaping the nation's destiny.

This is a moment that cannot be deferred any longer. Every delay in advancing women's representation is, in effect, a delay in strengthening the quality and inclusiveness of our democracy. For decades, the need for greater participation of women in legislative institutions has been acknowledged, discussed and reaffirmed. To postpone action now would mean extending an imbalance that we already recognise and have the capacity to correct. At a time when India is moving forward with confidence and purpose, it is essential that our institutions reflect the aspirations of all citizens, especially those who form half our population. Timely action will not only honour long-standing commitments but also ensure that the momentum of progress is sustained. This is truly a historic opportunity to make our democracy more representative, responsive and future-ready.

This moment calls for collective action. It is not about any one government, party or individual. It is about the nation as a whole recognising the importance of this step and coming together to realise it. It is what we owe to our Nari Shakti. That is why the passage of a bill for women's reservation should reflect the broadest possible consensus and be guided by the larger national interest. Such opportunities call upon us to act not for ourselves, but for future generations. They remind us that the true strength of a democracy lies in its ability to evolve and to become more inclusive over time.

As we approach this historic Parliament sitting, I appeal to all Members of Parliament, across party lines, to come together in support of this important step for the women of India. Let us seize this opportunity with a sense of responsibility and purpose. Let us act in a manner that reflects the highest traditions of our democracy.

India has always shown that when it comes to matters of national importance, it can rise above differences and act with unity. This is one such moment. Let us move forward together and strengthen Constitutional values and empower our Nari Shakti for national progress.

The writer is the Prime Minister of India
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PIC TALK

A worker unloads coconuts from a truck at a wholesale market in Prayagraj. PHOTO: PTI

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Understanding ego through the Bhagavad Gita

AJIT KUMAR BISHNOI

2ND OPINION

Let us first understand what ego is. Who will know about it? God, of course, who has created it. In the Bhagavad Gita, Lord Krishna states that a soul is part of Him (15.7). Surely, a part must serve the whole, who is God. There are several verses in the Gita where Lord Krishna has asked us, souls, to work for Him, as in verse 11.55. As God is complete in all respects, He does not need anything from us (3.22). What the Lord means is to serve His other parts - souls. Lord Krishna has praised such souls, as in verse 3.20, when He stated, "Such souls achieved perfection by working selflessly only." These parts must have an identity, a feeling of being somebody. In a Sanskrit dictionary, it is defined as 'apni satta ka bodha'. Translated into English, it means being aware of one's existence. A soul is unique and very different from all others and, surely, has life. Analysing the word 'ahankar', it means "I do" or "I exist". No matter how we see it, ahankar never means that one is superior in any way. False ego is what describes the wrong kind of pride or superiority.

A soul is not a doer, really. Only God or material nature are the actual doers; a soul can only desire or decide using his free will. There is nothing more a soul can do. So let us conclude that a soul is a part of God, subservient to God eternally, and meant to serve other souls as a duty. One can claim that one is good in a certain field and useful in some ways.

Any other emotion is false and harmful. Lord Krishna warned Arjuna of perishing if he continued to harbour the feeling of being the doer (18.58). In another verse, Lord Krishna clarifies the other doer: "All acts are carried out in totality by the modes of material nature. The feeling of being a doer is false" (3.27).

Such false ego causes a lot of harm. The biggest harm lies in ignoring God by assuming the world to be self-centric, whereas it is God-centric. The free will of an egoist supports this false notion. Ahankar comes in the way of 'bhakti' (devotion) (18.58). A soul does not have any independent power; taking credit is a result of great ignorance. There can be only one 'Purushottama' (Supreme Person), while others can be just persons.

One deprives oneself of all the help God can provide; the fault lies in bodily consciousness. This false sense of superiority can be got rid of by taking help from God — yes, by 'kripa' (grace of God). Devotees offer whatever they do, eat, the offerings they make, the charity they give, and the austerities they perform to God (9.27). Satsang helps in removing this false notion; Hanumanji is a classical example of being free from this fault. He always gave credit to Lord Ram for all His achievements.

The writer is a spiritual teacher and a popular columnist

DARING U.S. RESCUE OPERATION REFLECTS PRECISION AND POWER

The rescue operation by the United States in Iran recalls the elimination of Osama bin Laden in Abbottabad, Pakistan, during a covert Special Forces operation conducted in the dead of night. Such missions reflect not only military capability but also strategic planning and coordination at the highest level. In the present instance, the US military rescued an officer after an F-15E fighter jet was reportedly shot down by Iranian forces. President Donald Trump confirmed that the mission involved dozens of aircraft and a CIA deception strategy, suggesting that the airman had already been located.

In a bold and highly complex operation deep inside hostile territory, US forces located the distressed airman who had bailed out and successfully evacuated him. The mission reportedly involved hundreds of personnel, multiple aircraft, and advanced intelligence assets, with Navy SEAL Team 6 leading the extraction. The officer was later flown safely to a military hospital in Kuwait.

However, it is deeply regrettable that ongoing conflicts continue to witness violations of the rules of war, including attacks on civilian infrastructure such as hospitals, schools, and essential services. The sooner such hostilities cease, the better it will be for global peace and stability, particularly in sensitive regions like the Strait of Hormuz, which holds immense strategic and economic importance for the world.

YASH PAL RALHAN | JALANDHAR

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In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Trump tests limits of leadership

Trump proves a postulate in the quality of leadership: the enduring thread in history is not ideology or institution, but temperament, wherein impulse rivals intention. From Alcibiades of Greece, who shifted loyalties with the tides of the Peloponnesian War, to Muhammad bin Tughluq, whose restless experiments disoriented a realm, power has often leaned on brilliance unmoored from consistency. Nero turned rule into spectacle, while Napoleon Bonaparte, Emperor of France, revealed how immense will, unchecked, could both forge and fracture order.

In the modern age, this has been refined. Richard Nixon of the United States harnessed unpredictability as a deliberate stratagem; Silvio Berlusconi of Italy recast politics as personal theatre; Juan Perón of Argentina blurred ideology to sustain mass appeal. Each, in different measure, bent institutions without entirely discarding their necessity.

In this cavalcade, Donald Trump must be seen not as an aberration, but as rawness acquiring even greater abrasion. His unpredictability no longer merely serves power; it begins to define it. History shows that while power may thrive on surprise, order depends on trust

R NARAYANAN | NAVI MUMBAI

Voter roll purge concerns

The voter verification drive in West Bengal has sparked fresh controversy after the Election Commission of India's (ECI) judicial adjudication process led to the deletion of an estimated over 90 lakh names from the electoral rolls, raising serious concerns over transparency and potential disenfranchisement ahead of the Assembly elections.

Such a massive purge, carried out under the Special Intensive Revision (SIR), risks excluding legitimate voters on a large scale.

The scale of the exercise has drawn criticism, especially when viewed against earlier revisions. Before the SIR began in November, West Bengal had over 7.66 crore registered voters.

The draft rolls published in December saw 58.2 lakh deletions, which rose to 63.66 lakh in the final list released on 28 February.

The latest adjudication has now pushed the figure close to the one-crore mark, intensifying fears of voter suppression. Particularly alarming is the regional pattern of deletions. Minority-dominated districts appear to be disproportionately affected. With elections imminent, concerns over fairness and inclusiveness are growing.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Social media's dangerous new reality

Gone are the days when social media platforms were merely spaces for sharing memories and chatting with each other, extending likes and comments. Today, these platforms, especially Meta services, are being used to ignite social sentiments and wage emotional wars through provocative videos, viral hashtags, and disturbing images. Situations of social unrest have become common, with Instagram emerging as a major platform for sloganeering, both for and against causes.

From dialogues to AI-generated videos of renowned personalities used to defame them, everything on the internet is carefully crafted depending on the agenda. Ironically, 418 million Instagram users are exposed to such fabricated content daily, misleading innocent minds. Unfortunately, there is little control over such content, which is affecting society, particularly the youth. Reports suggest that 50 per cent and 37 per cent of people rely on YouTube and Instagram respectively for news. The need of the hour is to develop social media literacy. Before trusting content, we must verify whether the stated facts are genuine. Personal awareness alone can protect us from this information crisis.

KIRTI WADHAWAN | KANPUR

Ceasefire: A tactical pause in an ongoing war?

The Iran-US war exemplifies this complexity. It is not merely about nuclear capabilities, maritime routes, or regional alliances. It is also about competing visions of order — each shaped by distinct historical experiences and ideological commitments

FIRST Column

BALBIR PUNJ

The announcement of a two-week ceasefire between Iran and the United States has pulled the world away from what appeared to be the brink of an apocalypse. Both sides claim to be the winners in this 40-day-long war that kept the world on edge. The sad fact is that neither has won; at best, it is a Pyrrhic victory for both.

Undoubtedly, the USA and Trump have lost face. The US has presented the ceasefire as evidence of strategic success, asserting that Iran has been compelled to ensure the safe opening of the Strait of Hormuz.

The Strait, despite occasional rhetorical escalations, had never been definitively closed to global navigation, neither before February 2026 nor after previous crises, including the October 2023 Hamas attack on Israel and the June 2025 joint US-Israeli airstrikes on Iranian nuclear facilities. This war closed it, and calling its limited 15-day opening a victory is, at best, absurd.

In truth, Washington's objectives extended far beyond maritime assurances. The military campaign, executed through operations such as "Epic Fury" (2026) and "Midnight Hammer" (2025), was designed to dismantle Iran's nuclear programme and catalyse regime change. Yet, despite this overwhelming display of force, the principal objectives remain unrealised.

Iran's nuclear infrastructure, though significantly disrupted, has not been eliminated. Its scientific knowledge and latent capabilities persist. More importantly, the anticipated internal collapse of the Iranian regime has not materialised. And Trump calls it a victory!

Undoubtedly, the war has severely damaged Iran's critical infrastructure; rebuilding destroyed facilities, energy grids, and transport networks will require years of sustained effort. Despite these significant losses, Iran's determination to pursue its theological goals remains unshaken - something a transactional man like Trump cannot appreciate.

It is obvious that the USA completely miscalculated Iran's capacity and resolve to fight back — a fact perhaps most starkly illustrated in the dramatic oscillation of American rhetoric and action. Mere hours before announcing the ceasefire, President Trump issued an apocalyptic warning that captured the gravity — and volatility — of the moment: "A whole civilisation will die tonight." Such language, invoking the spectre of irreversible destruction, underscored the extent to which the conflict had approached a catastrophic threshold.

> THE US HAS PRESENTED THE CEASEFIRE AS EVIDENCE OF STRATEGIC SUCCESS, ASSERTING THAT IRAN HAS BEEN COMPELLED TO ENSURE THE SAFE OPENING OF THE STRAIT OF HORMUZ

Iran, for its part, has moved swiftly to frame the ceasefire as a strategic victory. Official statements have characterised the outcome as a "crushing defeat" for the United States, asserting that Washington has, in principle, conceded to key elements of Iran's position. These reportedly include the easing of sanctions, recognition of Iran's nuclear enrichment rights, and acceptance of its role in regulating passage through the Strait of Hormuz.

Whether these claims fully reflect the agreed terms remains uncertain. However, in asymmetric conflicts, perception often outweighs material outcomes. By withstanding a sustained military onslaught and compelling a pause, Iran reinforces its narrative of resistance - an image that carries significant weight both domestically and regionally.

Under the 47-year rule of the Ayatollah, millions of Iranians have become hardened jihadists, willing to die rather than surrender to what they see as a satanic civilisation. For them, the comforts of life here hold little value compared to the promised rewards in the next world. This ideological dimension, often overlooked in purely strategic calculations, has proven central to Iran's capacity for endurance.

Many have questioned why, in mediating tensions between Iran and the United States, engagement seemed to favour Pakistan over democratic India. It is the wrong question. The right question is whether India should have done everything Pakistan did to please Trump, to become his sidekick.

Pakistan engaged in targeted political and economic efforts, recommending Donald Trump for the Nobel Peace Prize (June 2025) and forming a crypto-related partnership with an affiliate of the Trump family-linked World Liberty Financial (January 2026), under the broader strategic influence of General Asim Munir. India, however, could not and rightly did not. India is too large and enduring to resort to such cheap tricks merely to seek favour with someone as an uncouth loudmouth as Trump.

Modern warfare has undoubtedly evolved. Where once battles were fought with swords and cavalry, today they are waged through precision-guided missiles, cyber operations, economic sanctions, and proxy networks. Increasingly, conflicts unfold in domains that are diffuse and often deniable.

Yet, despite these transformations in method, the underlying impulses remain strikingly consistent. Wars are preceded by ideas — beliefs about superiority, destiny, and exclusive truth. Before armies clash, worldviews collide. The history of the past millennium reveals a recurring pattern in which the interplay of faith and power shapes the trajectory of conflict. The Abrahamic traditions — Judaism, Christianity, and Islam — have, at various points in history, witnessed phases where theological exclusivity translated into political assertion. The long and turbulent history of Jerusalem illustrates this dynamic with particular clarity. From the Jewish-Roman wars of antiquity to the Crusades, from the expansion of Islamic empires to the modern Arab-Israeli conflicts, the region has been a crucible of civilisational contestation.

At the core of many such conflicts lies a potent idea: that truth is singular and exclusive. When this belief acquires political expression, it often legitimises coercion. The Crusades, the expansionist campaigns of early Islamic polities, and the excesses of the Inquisition were not aberrations; they were manifestations of a worldview that fused divine sanction with temporal power.

Even in the contemporary era, stripped of overt theological language, similar patterns persist in more subtle forms. The concept of neo-colonialism is instructive in this regard. Unlike classical colonialism, which relied on direct occupation, its modern variant operates through influence, intervention, and fragmentation. It employs non-state actors, ideological platforms, and economic instruments to achieve strategic objectives.

The vocabulary may have evolved - from "civilising missions" to "democracy promotion" — but the underlying impulse of control remains remarkably consistent. In such a context, conflicts are rarely confined to their immediate triggers.

The Iran-US war exemplifies this complexity. It is not merely about nuclear capabilities, maritime routes, or regional alliances. It is also about competing visions of order — each shaped by distinct historical experiences and ideological commitments.

Yet, significantly, Tehran has shown no indication of altering its strategic intent. The ceasefire has paused the conflict, but it has not softened Iran's ideological posture or long-term objectives. Iran's support for terror groups such as Hamas, Hezbollah, and the Houthis reflects a strategic doctrine that extends beyond conventional state rivalry.

Similarly, Israel's security posture is informed by its historical vulnerabilities, while the US seeks to maintain its role as a guarantor of regional balance.

The persistence of such conflicts raises troubling questions about the efficacy of global institutions. The twentieth century witnessed the creation of mechanisms such as the League of Nations and the United Nations, designed to prevent large-scale wars. Yet, despite these efforts, the cycle of conflict continues unabated.

The two-week ceasefire must, therefore, be understood as a tactical pause rather than a substantive resolution. It may temporarily prevent escalation, but it does not address the underlying tensions. Indeed, history suggests that such pauses often precede renewed confrontation, particularly when the root causes remain unresolved.

The writer is an eminent columnist, former Chairman of the Indian Institute of Mass Communication (IIMC), and the author of 'Tryst with Ayodhya: Decolonisation of India' and 'Narrative ka Mayajaal'

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Balancing growth and green goals: India charts next climate milestone

POOJA SEHBAG

The Union Cabinet approved the new edition of NDCs on March 25, 2026. These updated targets for 2031-35 demonstrate consistent, action-driven climate leadership, raising ambition on emissions intensity, non-fossil capacity, and carbon sinks while effectively balancing development goals, equity, and geopolitical uncertainty globally.

Amid global geopolitical turbulence, India stands out for its action-driven climate leadership. On March 25, 2026, the Union Cabinet approved the next round of India's Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs) for 2031-2035. Maintaining its track record of carefully balancing developmental imperatives with environmental responsibility, India is set to put forward three key quantifiable targets: reducing the emissions intensity of GDP by 47 per cent from 2005 levels; achieving 60 per cent of cumulative installed electricity capacity from non-fossil fuel sources; and creating an additional carbon sink of 3.5-4 billion tonnes of CO? equivalent through forest and tree cover.

These targets are not being set in isolation; they reflect continuity in India's climate action trajectory. For 2030, India had committed to reducing the emissions intensity of GDP by 45 per cent, achieving 50 per cent of installed electricity capacity from non-fossil sources — a target that has already been met - and creating an additional carbon sink of 2.5-3 billion tonnes of CO? equivalent. The new set of NDC targets reflects India's pragmatic, forward-looking approach, being framed with due regard to the implementation timeline as well as its twin goals of becoming a developed nation — Viksit Bharat by 2047 — and achieving net-zero emissions by 2070.

A defining feature of India's climate stewardship is its consistency in articulating targets and delivering on them without disruption. This is evident in its track record since becoming a party to the UNFCCC in 1993. India has not only met but often exceeded its commitments - the initial target of reducing emissions intensity of GDP by 33-35 per cent by 2030, set in 2015, was achieved years ahead of schedule. This was scaled up with a more ambitious target of 45 per cent in its 2022 NDC. Crucially, India has never stepped back from its climate commitments, nor questioned established climate science, maintaining uninterrupted engagement with the UNFCCC and its successive instruments. This pattern of credible delivery, coupled with calibrated ambition, underscores India's strong commitment as a climate actor.

Furthermore, India's climate commitments are not merely declaratory; they are anchored in a comprehensive policy framework integrating mitigation with a strong emphasis on adaptation. Non-fossil capacity expansion is driven by initiatives such as the National Solar Mission, PM-KUSUM, and Green Energy Corridors, supported by battery storage systems. Emissions intensity reduction is led by energy efficiency measures like the Perform, Achieve and Trade (PAT) mechanism, alongside sectoral transitions through the National Electric Mobility Mission Plan (NEMMP). Production-Linked Incentive (PLI) schemes further enable cleaner manufacturing. Concurrently, programmes like the Green India Mission advance carbon sinks while supporting rural livelihoods, reinforcing a clear adaptation-development linkage. Notably, the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC) has played a pivotal role in steering India's consistent and credible climate action through clear policy direction and institutional leadership.

The unequal burden of climate responsibility

Per capita energy consumption and emissions in India remain well below the global average. As India continues to "pull more than its weight" amid shifting geopolitical headwinds, the newly approved targets remain aligned with its development and climate action goals.

Contemporary discourse on emissions is often foregrounded by current emission trajectories. There remains a persistent tendency to underplay the weight of historical emissions in shaping present climate realities. However, these emissions represent only the tip of the iceberg. Historical accumulation reveals the true distribution of responsibility. The United States has been the largest historical emitter, having released over 509 GtCO? since 1850 — about one-fifth of the global total. Among European nations, the United Kingdom and Germany account for approximately 3 per cent and 4 per cent respectively, while China contributes around 12 per cent.

Notably, India — despite its population size — remains far down this list, underscoring the asymmetry between its contribution to the problem and its responsible approach to addressing it. When emissions generated overseas under colonial rule are accounted for, the historical burden of European powers rises sharply. For instance, the United Kingdom's share nearly doubles — from around 3 per cent to approximately 5.1 per cent - elevating it to the fourth-largest contributor to global warming. Despite this, historical emissions continue to be underplayed in international climate discourse.

A steady beacon amid geopolitical uncertainty

The United States' decision to withdraw from the Paris Agreement as well as the mother convention, combined with the contemporary energy crisis triggered by the ongoing conflict in West Asia, has placed the climate regime at a crossroads. Despite these challenges, India has shown conviction and quietly steered the climate discourse in the appropriate direction. The United States' withdrawal from the Paris Agreement under the UNFCCC framework — and its broader disengagement from multilateral climate processes — reflects a pendulum-like policy behaviour, where shifts in political leadership translate into abrupt changes in climate stance. Such oscillations disrupt momentum, weaken trust, and dilute the credibility of global climate cooperation at a time when consistency is most critical.

India's climate trajectory reflects consistency, credibility, and clear strategic direction. Rather than episodic shifts, it has pursued a stable pathway — retaining core parameters of its NDC commitments and proposing pragmatically progressive targets. This is not incrementalism, but calibrated progression.

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India-Dominican strategic link

ASHOKE RAJ

As the global economic order undergoes profound realignments, emerging partnerships between dynamic economies are reshaping trade corridors, supply chains, and geopolitical priorities. In this evolving landscape, the relationship between India and the Dominican Republic presents a compelling opportunity to build a strategic bridge between the Caribbean and the Indo-Pacific.

The Dominican Republic, which celebrated the 182nd anniversary of its independence on February 27, has consolidated itself as one of the fastest-growing economies in Latin America and the Caribbean. With a GDP exceeding USD 130 billion and a GDP per capita of approximately USD 12,000, the country has transitioned into an upper middle-income economy with sustained macroeconomic stability and democratic continuity.

Over the past decade, the Dominican Republic has recorded one of the highest average growth rates in the region. Even amid global uncertainty, economic growth has remained resilient, averaging around 4-5 per cent in recent years and projected at approximately 2.1 per cent for 2025, still outperforming many regional peers. Foreign direct investment has also remained strong, consistently surpassing USD 4 billion annually. In 2025, the country reached a historic high of USD 5,032.3 million in foreign direct investment, representing an 11.3 per cent increase compared to 2024, reflecting sustained investor confidence and the country's macroeconomic stability. For Indian policymakers and business leaders, these figures are not merely statistical milestones. They reflect a stable and expanding market strategically located at the crossroads of North America, Central America, South America, and the Caribbean.

Bilateral trade between India and the Dominican Republic reached approximately USD 2.1 billion in 2025, marking a record level. The trade relationship demonstrates strong complementarity: Dominican exports such as gold, medical devices, and agricultural products find demand in India, while India's globally competitive pharmaceutical, automotive, engineering, and technology sectors offer significant value to the Dominican market.

Beyond trade, institutional engagement has entered a more structured phase. The signing of a bilateral economic and commercial cooperation protocol established a formal platform for advancing dialogue in investment promotion, trade facilitation, and sectoral collaboration. This framework provides predictability and momentum to the relationship.

From an investment perspective, the Dominican Republic offers distinctive advantages. The country operates more than 80 free trade zones, hosting over 700 companies, generating hundreds of thousands of direct jobs, and producing exports valued at billions of dollars annually. These zones provide fiscal incentives, logistical efficiency, and integration into global value chains.

Infrastructure is a central pillar of the country's competitiveness. With 13 maritime ports and eight international airports, including major cargo hubs, the Dominican Republic has become one of the most connected logistics platforms in the Caribbean basin. This connectivity enables efficient access to markets covering over one billion consumers across the Western Hemisphere under preferential trade arrangements.

For Indian companies seeking diversification of supply chains and nearshoring options closer to the Americas, the Dominican Republic represents a strategic foothold with political stability, legal certainty, and a business-friendly regulatory framework.

Diplomatic engagement has also intensified. The Ambassador of the Dominican Republic to India, Francisco Comprés, a career diplomat, has advanced an active agenda focused on trade promotion, multilateral cooperation, and institutional partnerships. Engagement in areas such as renewable energy, climate resilience, business facilitation, and academic exchange reflects a broader ambition to elevate bilateral ties beyond traditional trade flows.

In multilateral arenas, both India and the Dominican Republic share common priorities as democratic developing nations committed to sustainable development, energy transition, and resilience-building. Cooperation within international frameworks provides additional depth to a partnership that is steadily expanding. As India continues to consolidate its role as a leading global economy and strategic actor, deeper engagement with stable and outward-looking partners in the Caribbean strengthens its global outreach. For the Dominican Republic, expanding ties with India aligns with its objective of attracting high-quality investment, technological collaboration, and greater integration into Asia's growth dynamism.

Geography may separate the Caribbean and the Indo-Pacific, but economic logic and strategic vision increasingly connect them. By building a structured and forward-looking partnership, India and the Dominican Republic can transform geographical distance into strategic opportunity.

The foundations are in place. The next phase depends on ambition.

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RBI confident about GDP growth

Lower estimates amidst a feeling that economy will bounce back

OUR TAKE

Yes, the central bank scaled down the growth figure by 0.7 per cent to 6.9 per cent this year (2026-27) due to the ongoing Iran war, and related implications. Yet, there is a feeling among experts that this exudes a certain confidence in the economy's ability to bounce back soon. This is evident in the statement by the Reserve Bank of India's governor. "Further escalation and wider spread of the conflict, heightened volatility in global financial markets, and weather-related events, however, weigh on the domestic growth outlook. Risks to the baseline projections are tilted to the downside, with uncertainty remaining elevated due to the ongoing West Asia conflict," he said.

Let us look at the issues that indicate that the central bank thinks that India has the inherent macro strengths to combat the repercussions. The RBI's estimates are more optimistic than those by global institutions. In its Monetary Policy Report (April 2026), which collates predictions from several sources, India will grow at 6.4 per cent in 2026, and similarly in 2027. Of course, these are the numbers for the calendar year (January-December) unlike the RBI's ones for the financial year (April-March). But even an apple-to-apple comparison shows that the latter's estimates for 2026 (calendar year) remain higher at seven per cent.

One needs to consider the quarterly estimates in 2026-27. The lowest number is 6.7 per cent in Q2-27 (July-September 2026), which is the same as in Q1-26 (April-June 2025), which was substantially lowered as per the new data series. Despite the war clouds, and disruptions, the RBI feels that the drop in growth will be akin to what happened a year ago. More importantly, the growth is likely to bounce back substantially by 0.5 per cent by Q4-27 (January-March 2027). Hence, the impact of the war will not last beyond three quarters, since the figure for Q4-26 (January-March 2026) was a robust 7.5 per cent.

In addition, as the RBI Governor said, there are major downside risks to growth. Although the baseline assumptions, or the most expected ones, point at 6.9 per cent annual growth in 2026-27, the "risks (are) tilted towards the downside around this baseline path." The Monetary Policy states, "Assuming a normal monsoon, and no major exogenous or policy shocks, structural model forecasts for 2027-28 indicate real GDP growth at 6.6 per cent," or lower than the previous year's 6.9 per cent, and substantially lower after a Q4-27 expectation of 7.2 per cent. However, things can turn out to be worse if the downsides persist.

"Under the scenario of higher crude oil prices than the baseline, real growth is projected at 6.7 per cent (not 6.9 per cent) and 6.4 per cent (not 6.6 per cent) for 2026-27 and 2027-28, respectively," states the Monetary Policy. The downside spillovers emanate from "prolonged geopolitical conflict, volatility in global financial markets, shifting trade patterns, and climate-related shocks." Indeed, there are some upsides, although their chances are lower than the baseline, or downsides. "At the current juncture, the situation is highly uncertain, and would require continuous assessment of the developments," states the report.

On the inflation front, manufacturing firms expect a rise in the costs of raw materials in the first quarter of this financial year, which may be compensated by a simultaneous increase in the selling prices of finished products. "Services and infrastructure firms anticipate rising input cost pressures but lower growth in selling prices," which will put more burden on them. Thus, there will be a sector-specific mismatch as manufacturing may be able to handle the issues more efficiently. Consumer Confidence Surveys point at higher prices.

The most-expected consumer inflation is expected to be 4.6 per cent in 2026-27, with the highest level of 5.2 per cent in Q3-27 (October-December 2026). The annual figure will be the same in 2027-28, if there is a normal monsoon, minus "further exogenous or policy shocks." But there are upsides, as in higher inflation, with a potential for it to be five per cent in 2026-27, and 5.1 per cent in 2027-28. These are based on the assumptions of higher global crude prices compared to the baseline, or most-expected predictions, and will stem from a longer conflict.

"The baseline forecasts (4.6 per cent) are subject to several upside (higher) and downside risks. The upside risks emanate from supply disruptions caused by weather-related shocks, and elevated energy prices due to prolonged geopolitical conflicts. The downward (lower) risk could emanate from an early resolution of geopolitical conflict," states the Monetary Policy Report. If the consumers and business community sense a higher-than-expected rise, there may be sentiment-driven momentum that can inflate the prices further. Since price rise has emotional links, the upside risks are more qualitative and subjective.

Some experts contend that high inflation, if retained under the five per cent mark, or nearer to four per cent, may be beneficial. It will boost nominal growth (real growth plus inflation), which was under pressure due to extremely low inflation. High nominal growth, in the range of 10-11 per cent, provides more fiscal space for the policy-makers to keep the fiscal deficit, as a percentage of nominal GDP, under check, even as they loosen the purses for higher expenditure. In 2025-26, low nominal growth forced the finance ministry to squeeze the budgets of several ministries, and on account of several welfare measures.

According to the RBI, there are several unrelated factors, i.e., not directly related to the ongoing war, that can disrupt the growth figures. One of these includes the "possibility of a sharp correction in AI-related asset valuations if corporate earnings fail to justify elevated technology stock valuations. Such a correction could trigger a tightening of financial conditions, concentrated in tech-heavy regions but with potential broader contagion effects," warns the monetary policy report. Valuations are currently under pressure due to the fast-changing AI-related tech, and emergence of new tools. There are fears that AI-linked productivity and other gains may not materialise easily.

In conclusion, the RBI is gung-ho. "Domestic economic activity remains resilient, supported by robust private consumption, and continued expansion in fixed investment, even as the external environment remains uncertain. Favourable agricultural prospects, steady services activity, elevated capacity utilisation, and healthy balance sheets of corporates and banks are likely to underpin growth going forward. Continued public investment in infrastructure, and recently concluded trade agreements are also expected to be conducive for medium-term growth prospects," states the monetary report. Yet, the risks to the outlook persist, and the growth-inflation dynamics can change.

BLASÉ CAPITAL

RBI POLICY REACTIONS

Sanjay Malhotra, RBI Governor

The RBI delivered a neutral-to-dovish policy as it chose to look through supply shock emanating from the ongoing energy crisis. The overall guidance is tilted towards "vigilance" given the elevated concerns around growth, and comfort on inflation. We believe the policy rates will remain on hold in 2026.

-Kaustubh Gupta, CIO (Fixed Income), Aditya Birla Sun Life

RBI continues to lay emphasis on keeping ample banking system liquidity to support economic activity. We expect that it will continue to conduct liquidity operations in a way that will keep overnight rates at the lower end of the policy corridor. While the positive development of temporary ceasefire in the West Asia war provides much needed relief across asset classes and currency, geopolitical risk will continue to drive the markets.

-Amit Somani, Deputy Head (Fixed Income), Tata Asset Management

The RBI meeting outcome was largely along expected lines. The overall tone was cautious, with the committee on a wait-and-watch mode, while remaining vigil on global developments. The governor indicated comfort around the external front, and reiterated to be proactive and pre-emptive in terms of liquidity management. We continue to remain constructive on the near end of the curve given the RBI's assurance of maintaining adequate system liquidity.

-Naval Kagalwala, COO, Shriram Wealth

It was not even mildly hawkish in any sense. RBI expressed that the risk of Iran war will become systemic when it stated that 'initial supply shock may potentially become a demand shock.' It will be a wrong conclusion that a long Iran war means higher rates. It can mean lower growth, and lower rates. El Nino found its space in the speech, which may drive the conversations for the next few months.

-Sandeep Yadav, Head (Fixed Income), DSP Mutual Fund

On inflation, the RBI highlighted a range of factors, from energy shocks feeding into inflation and growth to second-order effects on manufacturing, from trade disruptions due to blocked routes to the looming threat of El Niño. The expectations remain for a prolonged pause in policy rates with the curve expected to continue its steepening bias.

-Basant Bafna, Head (Fixed Income), Mirae Asset Investment

We think financial stability will no longer play second fiddle to the inflation-centric policy reaction function, and may emerge as the primary focus, if the crisis persists. Policy responses are needed to broaden beyond inflation, with a stronger emphasis on macro-financial stability and a more assertive stance on forex management. This shift is visible. We believe that the bar for any conventional rate hike remains high.

-Madhavi Arora, Chief Economist, Emkay Global Financial

Governor Sanjay Malhotra emphasised that while India's economic fundamentals remain on a stronger footing compared to previous crises, the central bank is adopting a 'wait and watch' approach. RBI sees risks to inflation from the likely emergence of El Niño but believes that core inflation pressures remain muted.

-Churchil Bhatt, Ex VP (Investment), Kotak Mahindra Life Insurance

In the face of pressures such as geopolitical tensions, volatile energy prices, and currency movements, maintaining the status quo provides much-needed predictability to the broader economy. For the real estate sector, this continuity in interest rates plays a crucial role in sustaining momentum. In an environment where sentiment can be easily influenced by macroeconomic signals, the absence of rate volatility acts as a reassuring factor.

-Shishir Baijal, CMD, Knight Frank India

We do not see RBI hiking policy rates until CPI inflation durably surpasses 6 per cent, and expectations get unhinged. We believe the 6.9 per cent growth estimate may need a reassessment as full pre-war energy export volumes might take 3-6 months due to backlog, diverted tankers, and partial infrastructure damage.

-Garima Kapoor, Economist, Elara Capital

The decision to hold rates is the right call, not a pause, but a pivot to patience. For us, the signal is clear that the next phase of growth will not be liquidity-constrained but execution-driven. MSMEs are entering a phase where working capital cycles are becoming volatile. This requires banks to move beyond collateral-led lending to dynamic, cash flow-based models anchored in GST trails, account aggregator frameworks, and transaction data.

-Salee S Nair, MD & CEO, Tamilnad Mercantile Bank

Is it beginning of World War III?

Several seemingly-unconnected wars can easily converge, and soon

Let us begin with a huge caution. What we present here is the most-frightening scenario. It may or may not happen, but more voices are articulating it openly. Billionaire-investor Ray Dalio recently wrote, "We are now in a world war that is not going to end anytime soon." More importantly, this is not merely a military situation that involves geopolitics. It has engulfed large parts of domestic politics, global economics, large businesses, financial markets, global trade, currencies, and other assets. Like it or not, what we see now, from a perspective from the top, as opposed to the ground realities, is possibly the initial and cautionary beginnings of World War III.

At present, one thinks of the mini-wars across the various regions and continents as disconnected and unrelated ones. But look at them from a different angle. The Russia-Ukraine war involves the US and Europe. The Iran war has firmly put its stamp not just on America and Israel but most of the Middle East. West Asia is enveloped in several wars, which include those that involve Israel, Lebanon, and Syria, along with the one whose protagonists include Saudi Arabia, UAE, Yemen, and Sudan. In effect, North America, Europe, Asia, and the Middle East are already in the grips. Add South America (Venezuela and Cuba), and Arctic (Greenland), which are, or may be, subsumed.

"Together, these conflicts make up a very classical world war that is analogous to past world wars," wrote Dalio. Other experts feel that at some stage, if China escalates territorial ambitions, and other nations take these mini-wars as opportunities to pursue their agendas, the disparate conflicts can converge, and ignite a true World War III. As mentioned before, it will consume businesses, and markets, as the "monetary order, some domestic political orders, and geopolitical world order are breaking down" like never before. Dalio feels that the conditions that "typically precede" wider world wars are in place.

The billionaire lays out the grand geopolitical chess board, and tracks the moves over the past few years by the various participants, or chess pieces. First, dominant powers weaken relative to rising powers. This may imply the decline of the US and Europe, relative to Russia and China, in a world that is truly multi-polar. Economic wars follow the political ones in the form of trade sanctions, tariffs, bilateral deals, and aims to support local businesses. "Critical industries and supply chains come under tighter government control. Trade checkpoints become weaponised. Military operations take over, and spread across continents as "multi-theatre conflicts increasingly happen simultaneously."

From a so-called multi-polar world, the world slowly but steadily transforms into a bipolar one, as was the case during the first two world wars. At present, two distinct sides are visible. America has its allies, although it keeps prodding and nudging them, and tries to undermine NATO, and European friends. In response, "China is aligned with Russia, and Russia is aligned with Iran, North Korea, and Cuba," even as Russia tries to muscle its way into Europe, and China does it in Asia, Africa, and Europe. At some stage, South America will take a stand, especially after Venezuela, and if the US seeks Cuba.

But most of these alliances, even if firm, will be fluid, and change fast. In this scenario, the enemy's enemy is a friend, or a smaller or less-crucial enemy is a friend when a more powerful enemy looms large. This explains the alliances between India and China, India and Russia, China and Russia, and the stance taken by Brazil and Japan. Thus, this world war may not even look like a world war. It will continue to mirror the present scenario of several mini-wars, which link up in bizarre ways, and pitch one side against the other, even as the composition of the sides keep changing rapidly, and without warnings. According to Dalio, the alliances will matter as much, if not more than, the battlefields. "It is quite easy to see objectively how the sides are lining up via indicators such as their treaties and formal alliances, their votes at the United Nations, their leaders' statements, and their actions," he wrote. But since the scenarios are flexible, this is not about the formation of blocs, like during the earlier world wars or Cold War, but an erosion of the order that was built over the past 70 years. Today, one sees the "might-is-right order with no single dominant power."

Now, look at the future. Let us assume that the Iran war ends with America's victory. After Venezuela, and if the US eyes Cuba, it will prompt Russia to occupy and demand more territory in Ukraine, and China to step up its intentions in the South China Sea, and Taiwan. If America withdraws, Iran will emerge stronger in the Middle East, and impose its conditions, which will give more encouragement to other nations like North Korea, Russia, and China.

This is why Dalio believes that the way the Iran war ends will not mark an end to the crisis.

Whichever way the Iran war ends, it will be another input into the so-called 'Big Cycle' of global events, which will advance in different ways, depending on the outcome, and influence the future. The world war will take new shapes, escalate, and the next phase will lead to more conflicts, rather than less. Either way, more nations will enter the fray, or some nations may intensify their war efforts. As more nations link with each other, or distance themselves, a concrete line will differentiate the two sides. Nations will cross the line quite frequently, and the line may shift, but the marker will remain.

Statements like the Iran war will mean the end of a nation, or civilisation, will add to the chaos and confusion. Suddenly, the political and economic nuances will be lost, or get blurred, and ideological mindset, even if unclear and opaque, will be at the forefront. The mini-wars will acquire a larger-than-life image, and will involve either a fight for survival, tussle for revival, or a conflict for imperial. The balance of power, whatever remains of it, will break down. As Dalio explains, the world has transited from a pre-fighting stage to a fighting one, which is broadly comparable to the situations in 1913-14 (World War I) and 1938-39 (World War II). Even if the timing is not precise, as Dalio admits, a minor trigger may ignite the world. We are sitting on a huge heap of tinderboxes. All it needs is adequate light.

RBI gives bank's board time to promote ease of doing business

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Mumbai

In a bid to promote ease of doing business, Reserve Bank Governor Sanjay Malhotra on Wednesday proposed to revise and rationalise guidelines to facilitate better utilisation of bank board's time and draft directions in this regard would be released shortly.

The matters to be placed before the Boards of banks, along with their periodicity, are determined by the Boards themselves, guided by the seven broad themes prescribed by the Reserve Bank of India.

Meanwhile, the Reserve Bank has also mandated certain policies and matters to be placed before the Board for approval, review, or information.

"In an endeavour to enable Boards to utilise its time effectively, and to facilitate a more focused and qualitative engagement on strategy and risk governance, the Reserve Bank has undertaken comprehensive review and rationalisation of all such instructions. Draft directions in this regard will be issued shortly for public consultation," RBI said in its statement on Developmental and Regulatory Policies.

The announcement comes weeks after HDFC Bank Chairman Atanu Chakraborty's abrupt resignation, citing ethical concerns.

"Certain happenings and practices within the bank, that I have observed over the last two years, are not in congruence with my personal values and ethics. This is the basis of my aforementioned decision," Chakraborty had said in his resignation letter dated March 17.

This is the first time that the part-time chairman of HDFC Bank left mid-way raising concerns over its functioning.

Announcing the Monetary Policy Committee meeting outcome, Reserve Bank

Governor Sanjay Malhotra said, "We had recently undertaken a detailed exercise, to consolidate over 9,000 regulatory instructions into 238 Master Directions. A similar consolidation exercise has now been completed for all our supervisory instructions."

The Reserve Bank has constantly endeavored to refine and strengthen its regulatory and supervisory framework while minimising compliance costs, through periodic evaluation of instructions for their continued relevance.

In furtherance of this objective, the Reserve Bank had undertaken a comprehensive consolidation exercise of the regulatory instructions, on an 'as is' basis, in 2025.

The exercise involved consolidation of more than 9,000 existing regulatory circular/guidelines into 238 function-wise Master Directions (MDs), specific to each category of regulated entity, the Statement on Developmental and Regulatory Policies said.

A similar exercise has now been carried out for the supervisory instructions, it said.

Accordingly, the drafts of 64 Master Directions consolidating extant supervisory instructions on up to nine functional areas are being published on Wednesday on RBI website for public comments, it added.

To facilitate ease of doing business by MSMEs, Malhotra said, RBI proposed to dispense with the requirement of due diligence while onboarding them on TReDS platforms. With a view to facilitating timely access to working capital for MSMEs, guidelines for Trade Receivables Discounting System (TReDS) were issued in 2014 and subsequently updated in 2018. The scope of TReDS was further expanded in 2023 with the inclusion of insurance companies as the fourth participant. In order to promote ease of doing business for MSMEs and to encourage their greater participation on TReDS, it is proposed to dispense with the requirement of due diligence of MSMEs while onboarding on TReDS platforms.

A comprehensive review of other extant instructions has also been undertaken, and draft directions will be issued shortly for public consultation, he added.

For further development of the term money market, Malhotra said, "we have decided to permit certain additional categories of non-bank entities in this market segment. At present, only banks and standalone primary dealers (SPDs) are eligible to participate in this market. We are also enhancing the borrowing limit of SPDs in the term money market."

An active-term money market, apart from providing an alternative funding avenue to the market participants, also helps in enhancing monetary policy transmission by creating a link between the overnight money market and longer-term interest rates.

At present, only banks and standalone primary dealers are eligible to participate in the term money market, with certain prudential limits.

"With a view to further enhance the depth of participation and liquidity in the term money market segment, it has been decided to expand the participant base in the term money market segment to include non-bank participants viz., AIFIs, NBFCs, including housing finance companies, companies, etc. and enhance the borrowing limit in the term money market for standalone primary dealers," it said.

The revised directions are being issued separately, it added.

Iran ceasefire taken into account for policy decision: RBI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Mumbai

Reserve Bank Governor Sanjay Malhotra on Wednesday termed the ceasefire between the US and Iran as "pleasant news", which was taken into account while taking the policy decision hours later.

"At 5:30 am, we got some pleasant news, maybe not a complete surprise," Malhotra told reporters at the customary post-policy-review interaction.

"The ceasefire, to some extent, has been taken into account. The whole implications (will come later), but

the ceasefire has been taken into account in the monetary policy decision," he added.

Although it was a scheduled review, the maiden policy review for FY27 by the Reserve Bank is the first such call taken by any central bank in the world after the ceasefire announcement.

Concerns have persisted over the last 39 days of the conflict in West Asia, triggered by the US and Israel's joint attacks on Iran, and the Gulf country's response to the crisis.

Malhotra said the six-member rate-setting panel, headed by him, meets before the announcement of the decision to the wider public at 10 am.

The central bank's six-member Monetary Policy Committee voted unanimously to keep the benchmark repurchase rate unchanged at 5.25 per cent, flagging heightened uncertainty after the West Asia conflict drove crude prices sharply higher, weakened the rupee and disrupted trade flows.

During the course of the press conference, Malhotra also mentioned the upheaval in the financial markets, supply chain disruptions and the dent to economic activity as something that was "almost a crisis".

Borrowing the old adage of never letting a crisis go waste, Malhotra recommended a slew of structural aspects beyond the short-lived turbulence, which we need to focus on going forward.

This includes accelerating the pace of adopting electric vehicles and upping self-sufficiency in oil to reduce import burdens, he said.

RBI ups crude oil, exchange rate baseline assumptions for FY27

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Mumbai

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Wednesday said it expects crude oil prices to average $85 per barrel and the rupee to be at 94 against the dollar in FY27.

The central bank has made the projections in the bi-annual Monetary Policy report released on Wednesday.

The crude oil price assumption has been upped to $85 per barrel during FY27, from $70 per barrel during H2FY26. It also increased exchange rate projections to 94 against the US dollar during FY27, from 88 against the greenback during H2FY26, report showed.

"The baseline assumption for crude oil price has been taken at $85 per barrel for FY27 and $75 per barrel for FY28, in line with average Brent future prices," RBI said in a report.

The report added that the International crude oil prices exhibited a declining trend during October 2025-December 2025, easing to around $63 per barrel, owing to OPEC+ announcements which increased supply in the global oil market. This trend reversed sharply in

March 2026, with prices surging past $100 per barrel for the first time since November 2022, driven by escalating geopolitical tensions.

The nominal exchange rate of the Indian rupee was in the range of 87-92 per US dollar during October 2025 to January 2026. Since October 2025 and up to the first half of November, the rupee remained stable, trading around 88 per US dollar.

Towards the end of November, the INR exhibited depreciating bias and reached an all-time low, almost touching 92 per US dollar in the second fortnight of January 2026, driven by portfolio outflows, steady dollar demand and tight global financial conditions.

In March, however, depreciation pressures accentuated with the INR breaching 95 per US dollar intraday, surpassing its previous record lows amid concerns over West Asia conflict.

Indian rupee has posted its biggest annual decline in 14 years in FY26, depreciating by 9.88 per cent against the US dollar, marking the sharpest fall since FY12 when the currency had weakened by 12.4 per cent.

The steep depreciation was driven by persistent foreign fund outflows, elevated crude oil prices, and a strengthening dollar globally, which put sustained pressure on the domestic currency. Volatility in global financial markets and tightening liquidity conditions further weighed on the rupee during the fiscal year.

Aviation stocks fly high

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

Aviation stocks zoomed on Wednesday morning trade following a sharp decline in crude oil prices after the US and Iran announced a two-week ceasefire.

Easing of geopolitical stress led to a sharp fall in Brent crude oil prices, which tumbled 13 per cent to $94.94 per barrel.

InterGlobe Aviation, the parent firm of IndiGo,

zoomed 10.98 per cent to ₹4,737.40 on the BSE.

The stock of SpiceJet also jumped 4.99 per cent to reach its upper circuit limit of ₹11.14.

Stock markets also turned buoyant following the ceasefire announcement. The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 2,839.53 points or 3.80 per cent to 77,456.11 in morning trade. The 50-share NSE Nifty surged 837.6 points or 3.62 per cent to 23,961.25.

RBI to come out with new NBFC framework amid lack of clarity on Tata Sons' listing

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Mumbai

Reserve Bank of India (RBI) Governor Sanjay Malhotra on Wednesday announced that the monetary authority will be coming out with a new framework for non-bank lenders amid a lack of clarity over Tata Sons' listing issue.

"We are coming up with a new framework for the NBFCs. Very soon, we should," Malhotra told reporters at the customary post-policy review press conference. On a specific question on Tata Sons, Malhotra said the new framework will categorise non-

banking finance companies. He, however, did not elaborate further on the matter, which has been tracked intensely because the RBI is likely to decide if Tata Sons, the holding company of the salts-to-software conglomerate, continues to be privately held or is forced to list.

As per the existing rules from the RBI, Tata Sons, a core investment company, should have been listed by September 30 last year because it is included in a set of 15 entities in the upper layer bracket. Barring Tata Sons, all other entities have complied with the provision.

Previously, Malhotra had said that an entity can continue doing business till its license is cancelled and declined any further comment, even though the timeline for mandatory listing has passed.

Gold climbs ₹3,007 to ₹1.53 lakh/10g in futures trade

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

Gold prices jumped ₹3,007 to ₹1.53 lakh per 10 grams in futures trade on Wednesday due to increased buying on the back of a weak US dollar and relief sentiment after Washington and Tehran agreed to a two-week ceasefire.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange, the yellow metal for June delivery appreciated by ₹3,007, or 2 per cent, to ₹1,53,296 per 10 grams.

Gold prices were supported by a weaker US dollar after President Trump announced a two-week ceasefire with Iran, averting imminent military escalation, Manav Modi, Commodities Analyst at Motilal Oswal Financial Services Ltd, said.

The decision to suspend strikes on Iran's civilian infrastructure came just hours before a key deadline, easing geopolitical tensions and improving overall market sentiment, he added.

Echoing similar sentiments, Jateen Trivedi, VP Research Analyst — Commodity and Currency, LKP Securities, said the rally

in gold is largely driven by relief sentiment after the US-Iran ceasefire, which led to a sharp 15 per cent correction in crude prices, supporting broader risk assets.

"However, this move is more of a relief rally and short covering, as uncertainty still persists regarding the durability of the ceasefire and reopening of key supply routes," Trivedi added.

Despite the rebound, gold futures remain below the levels seen before the escalation in West Asia. During the conflict, prices declined ₹12,363, or 7.5 per cent, from ₹1,65,659 per 10 grams recorded on February 27, 2026.

Globally, gold futures for the June contract appreciated $129.12, or nearly 3 per cent, to $4,813.82 per ounce.

12% hike approved in subsidy for P&K fertilisers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA), chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, on Wednesday approved a 12 per cent hike in subsidy for Phosphatic and Potassic (P&K) fertilisers for the Kharif 2026 season to ₹41,534 crore in order to insulate farmers from rising global prices amid the West Asia conflict.

The subsidy for P&K fertilisers for the Kharif 2025 season was ₹37,216 crore.

The decision, taken at a Cabinet meeting chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, fixed subsidy rates effective April 1 to September 30, 2026.

For Kharif 2026, the government has set a subsidy for nitrogen at ₹47.32 per kg (up from ₹43.02 per kg in Rabi 2025-26), phosphate at ₹52.76 per kg against ₹47.96 per kg, and sulphur at ₹3.16 per kg against ₹2.87 per kg. The potash subsidy has been held steady at ₹2.38 per kg.

Subsidy is extended across 28 grades of P&K fertilisers under the Nutrient Based Subsidy (NBS) scheme, in force since April 2010.

"The subsidy has been increased by ₹4,317 crore over the Kharif 2025 season," Information and Broadcasting Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw told reporters. Despite a sharp increase in Di-ammonium Phosphate (DAP) prices in international markets since the Covid years, the minister said the retail price for

farmers has been held at ₹1,350 for a 50-kg bag.

Be it the Covid years or the West Asia crisis, the Prime Minister has remained as a safety shield for farmers, insulating farmers from global price volatility, he added.

The Cabinet also approved a set of additional measures: provisions to manage global price volatility, extension of similar safeguards to imported Triple Super Phosphate (TSP) to ensure supply stability, continuation of freight subsidy for Single Super Phosphate (SSP), and inclusion of both imported and domestically manufactured Ammonium Sulphate under the NBS scheme for Kharif 2026.

Kharif sowing typically begins with the onset of the southwest monsoon in June.

The total budgetary allocation for the NBS and urea subsidy scheme for FY 2026-27 - covering both Kharif 2026 and Rabi 2026-27 — stands at ₹1,70,799 crore.

Retail prices of non-urea fertilisers such as Di-ammonium Phosphate (DAP), Muriate of Potash (MoP) and Nitrogen, Phosphate, Potash (NPK) are decontrolled and determined by manufacturers, while the Centre gives those fixed subsidies each year.

BMW India records best-ever first quarter

Manufacturer claims 70 per cent share of luxury EV market in India

KUSHAN MITRA
Gurugram

BMW Group India which sells BMW and Mini passenger vehicles in India said that it recorded the highest sales ever for the first quarter of a calendar year with 4,567 units sold between January and March, 2026. This was a recorded 17 per cent growth over the same period last year.

Thanks to the success of the long-wheelbase iX1 BMW India, BMW India claimed a 70 per cent market share in the luxury market with over 1,185 units sold. BMW Motorrad, the company's two-wheeler division recorded sales of 1,216 in the first quarter.

Speaking with the media, Hardeep Brar, President,

BMW India, said that he expected growth to continue, "We expect to have strong double-digit growth in 2026. However, the current global volatility could definitely impact us, although for the time being we have enough kits and supplies for the next couple of months as they have long lead times. That said, the luxury buyer is the first to be impacted by volatility and might hold off from purchases although it is also the first to bounce back. News of the ceasefire should be welcomed."

To enable growth in 2026, BMW will be embarking on their most ambitious product launch strategy in the coming months with 27 launches, four of which have already occurred in the first quarter and eight more planned for the second quarter, including the much expected F450 GS motorcycle and the long-wheelbase i5 electric sedan. "Of the 27 launches, six will be all-new vehicles and four will have major changes", Brar highlighted.

Speaking of BMW India's lead on electric vehicles, Brar also pointed out that the current situation could lead to even more buyers choosing electrics.

"The fact is that elections are ongoing and the government has not allowed petrol or diesel prices to increase, but they are bound to go up and that will only increase the 'delta' of running cost between internal combustion and electric vehicles." In fact to aid in the electric transition, BMW India has also installed over a 100 of their own chargers at all their retail points, including 12 chargers on the 'Kashmir to Kanyakumari' route with speeds of between 120-720 kilowatt hours.

Speaking to The Pioneer, Brar added that BMW Financial Services, BMW India's own Non-Banking Financial Company (NBFC) subsidiary has been playing a major role in financing vehicles for the company. "Having our in-house NBFC allows us to come up with innovative financing schemes and also control the residual value of our vehicles by offering buyback packages and comprehensive maintenance", he added.

FROM THE WORLD

PAKISTAN

6 militants killed in Balochistan

Pakistani security forces have killed six militants during an intelligence-based operation in the troubled Balochistan province, an official said on Wednesday.

Counter Terrorism Department official Mehtab Rehmani said the militants belonging to a banned outfit were killed in the Kirdgab area of Mastung town on Tuesday.

Rehmani said the operation was carried out after intelligence reports that militants were hiding in the area and preparing an attack. The security forces cordoned off the area and launched the operation, killing six militants. However, some militants managed to escape into the mountains, he said. Rehmani said a large quantity of arms and ammunition was seized from their possession.

NEPAL

Arrest warrants issued for ex-PM

A Nepalese court has issued arrest warrants against former prime minister Sher Bahadur Deuba and his wife Arzu Deuba Rana, the former foreign minister, in money laundering cases, media reports said on Wednesday. The Kathmandu District Court issued warrants against the couple on Tuesday following a request by the Department of Money Laundering, which is investigating the couple's assets, according to The Kathmandu Post newspaper. Citing investigative sources, the paper said that the couple is believed to be in Singapore. The department started investigating the assets of the couple after burnt pieces of banknotes were recovered from their residence at Budhanilkantha on the outskirts of Kathmandu in September. Deuba, who served as prime minister five times, has remained a key figure in Nepali politics.

Israel strikes Beirut without warning amid ceasefire

ABBY SEWELL ■ BEIRUT

Israeli strikes hit several dense commercial and residential areas in central Beirut Wednesday afternoon without warning, hours after a ceasefire was announced in the US-Israeli war with Iran.

Israel has said the agreement does not extend to its war with the Iran-backed militant group Hezbollah in Lebanon, although mediator Pakistan said it does.

Israel's military called it the largest coordinated strike in the current war, striking more than 100 Hezbollah targets within 10 minutes in Beirut, southern Lebanon and the eastern Bekaa valley.

Black smoke towered over several parts of the seaside capital. Booms interrupted the honking of traffic on what had been a blue-sky afternoon. Ambulances raced toward open flames. At least one apartment building was struck. Emergency responders searched charred vehicles. It was not immediately clear how many people were killed or wounded, but several strikes were in busy commercial locations, causing panic in the streets.

First responders working at the site of an Israeli airstrike that struck an apartment building in Beirut, Lebanon,

Israel's military said it had targeted missile launchers, command centres and intelligence infrastructure and accused Hezbollah of using civilians as human shields.

"The State of Lebanon and its civilians must refuse Hezbollah's entrenchment in civilian areas and its weapons build-up capabilities," the military said in a statement.

Israel has rarely struck central Beirut since the outbreak of the latest Israel-Hezbollah war on March 2 but has regularly struck southern and eastern Lebanon and Beirut's southern suburbs.

Before the wave of new strikes, a Hezbollah official told The Associated Press that the group was giving a chance for mediators to secure a ceasefire in Lebanon, but "we have not announced our adherence to the ceasefire since the Israelis are not adhering to it." He spoke on condition of anonymity because he was not authorised to comment publicly.

The Hezbollah official said the group will not accept a return to the pre-March 2 status quo, when Israel carried out near-daily strikes in Lebanon despite a ceasefire being nominally in place since the last full-blown Israel-Hezbollah war ended in November 2024.

"We will not accept for the Israelis to continue behaving as they did before this war with regards to attacks," he said. "We do not want this phase to continue."

Hezbollah had fired missiles across the border days after the US and Israel attacked Iran, sparking a regional war. Israel responded with widespread bombardment of Lebanon and a ground invasion.

Israeli airstrikes have killed more than 1,530 people in Lebanon, including more than 100 women and 130 children. The Israeli military has said it has killed hundreds of Hezbollah fighters. More than one million people have been displaced in Lebanon.

Early Wednesday, after the ceasefire was announced, many displaced people sleeping in tents on the streets of Beirut and the coastal city of Sidon began packing their belongings in preparation to return to their homes. (*AP*)

UK PM hail US-Iran ceasefire, travels to Gulf

ADITI KHANNA
■ London

British Prime Minister Keir Starmer begins a visit to the Gulf region on Wednesday to discuss diplomatic efforts to support and uphold the ceasefire agreed between the US and Iran overnight.

Downing Street said his visit to the Gulf region is aimed at bringing about a lasting resolution to the conflict and protect the UK and global economy from further threats. Starmer is set to reiterate the UK's commitment to de-escalation and hold further discussions on practical efforts to restore freedom of navigation in the Strait of Hormuz, following what his office referred to as

"promising progress" as a result of the ceasefire.

"I welcome the ceasefire agreement reached overnight, which will bring a moment of relief to the region and the world," said Starmer.

"Together with our partners we must do all we can to support and sustain this ceasefire, turn it into a lasting agreement and reopen the Strait of Hormuz," he said. The US and Iran agreed to a two-week ceasefire after nearly six weeks of military hostilities.

US President Donald Trump made the dramatic announcement on Truth Social on Tuesday evening (US time) 90 minutes before his deadline to wipe out the civilisation was to end.

Starmer's three-day tour follows the UK-convened meeting last week of more than 40 countries, including India, to begin work on a viable plan to reopen the Strait of Hormuz when the fighting subsides.

A follow-up military planning meeting was hosted by the UK's Permanent Joint Headquarters on Tuesday to further advance that work.

Work will now continue at pace in light of the ceasefire and the Prime Minister is expected to discuss this further in meetings with leaders in the region, 10 Downing Street said.

During his visit to the Gulf, Starmer is set to review the defensive support the UK has provided in the collective self-defence of UK allies and express gratitude to British personnel for "brave service".

"The Prime Minister's first stop will be to thank the UK and local personnel who have bravely put their lives at risk in the defence of our people, our interests and those of our allies," the UK PM's office stated. (*PTI*)

Hormuz opening to depend on results of talks with US: Iranian envoy

KJM VARMA ■ Beijing

Iran will allow ships to pass through the Strait of Hormuz during the two-week ceasefire, but any decision to open the Strait entirely in future will depend on the results of the peace talks with the US, a senior Iranian diplomat said on Wednesday.

So far, 3,000 ships are waiting to pass through the Strait of Hormuz, Iranian Ambassador to China Abdolreza Rahmani Fazli told the media.

"Iran will take measures to reduce the pressure and let ships pass through, but whether the Strait of Hormuz can be opened entirely will have to wait for the results of the negotiations," he said. Iran is considering transit fees for the Strait of Hormuz, he added.

He said Tehran would reference the fees for other maritime passages in the world, but had not decided on a detailed plan

Iranian Ambassador to China Abdolreza Rahmani Fazli

yet."For hundreds of years, Iran has been the guarantor of the Strait (of Hormuz), and we have never charged, but no country has ever recognised Iran's contribution and value," the Hong Kong-based South China Morning Post quoted him as saying.

Iran would work with neighbouring countries to ensure safe passage through the Strait, but the "main safety guarantee would come from Iran", he said. (*PTI*)

Pete Hegseth warns of strikes if Iran keeps enriched Uranium

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth said the US could strike again if Iran does not hand over enriched uranium.

The Pentagon chief did not offer any details about whether Iran had agreed to Trump's statement that the US would work with them to "dig up" the buried material. However, Hegseth said Iran will "give it to us voluntarily," or the US might do "something like" its strikes last summer with Israel hitting Iran's nuclear sites. "We reserve that opportunity," Hegseth said.

Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth speaking to members of the media during a press briefing at the Pentagon in Washington AP

Gor, Trump discuss future of India-US strategic ties

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Washington

US Ambassador to New Delhi, Sergio Gor, has said that he has discussed with President Donald Trump ways to build a "strong future" for India and the US.

Gor met Trump over dinner on Tuesday. His meeting with President Trump coincided with the US and Iran agreeing to a two-week ceasefire following nearly six weeks of military hostilities.

Gor also mentioned Trump's unwavering determination to bring global stability. "Just had an outstanding dinner with President Trump. We discussed his unwavering determination to bring global stability, the

historic achievements of his presidency, the strong future of India-US ties, and so much more! A very memorable evening as history unfolded in real time," Gor posted on X on Wednesday.

The dinner comes as Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri reached Washington DC on Wednesday to review bilateral trade and defence ties, and discuss the escalating crisis in West Asia.

The visit comes as both sides work to stabilise the ties after a spell of uncertainty and strain. The relations witnessed a major downturn after Washington imposed punitive tariffs on India, and President Donald Trump made controversial assertions regarding his role in de-escalating the India-Pakistan military clashes last May.

Meanwhile, US envoy Gor earlier met US Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick here and discussed the commercial roadmap for the two countries and the opening up of a market of 1.4 billion people for American products. Gor said he discussed with Lutnick a new Memorandum of Understanding that seeks to connect India's AI scale with the American AI ecosystem, and also strong participation from New Delhi in the upcoming Select USA Summit near .

Gautam Adani petitions to US court against SEC charges

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New York

A US judge granted a request from billionaire Gautam Adani to schedule a hearing in his effort to dismiss a US Securities and Exchange Commission fraud case, which he says lacks necessary jurisdiction as well as fails on multiple reasons.

This followed lawyers of Adani and his nephew, Sagar filing a plea seeking dismissal of the case.

"The court has received Defendants' letter requesting a pre-motion conference on their anticipated motion to dismiss the Complaint.

The court GRANTS that request and DIRECTS the parties" to schedule the pre-motion conference, the Eastern District court of New York said in its order.

In the filing, the Adanis' lawyers said there was no credible evidence supporting the alleged bribery scheme. The SEC, they said, lacked necessary jurisdiction over the two men and that the alleged misstatements underpinning the case weren't actionable.

JINDAL LEASEFIN LIMITED
CIN: L74899DL1994PLC059252
Regd. Office: 110, Babar Road, New Delhi - 110 001

EXTRACT OF STATEMENT OF STANDALONE AUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND YEAR ENDED 31.03.2026 (Rs. in Lacs)

Sl. No.	Particulars	Three Months Quarter Ended			Year Ended	
		31.03.2026	31.12.2025	31.03.2025	31.03.2026	31.03.2025
		Audited	Un-Audited	Audited	Audited	Audited
1	Total Income from Operations	247.68	-21.23	-167.05	239.00	-293.10
2	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or extraordinary Items#)	237.81	-25.88	-175.87	213.32	-312.69
3	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/or extraordinary Items#)	237.81	-25.88	-175.87	213.32	-312.69
4	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or extraordinary Items#)	117.6	-20.30	-124.42	91.89	-237.66
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period (Comprising Profit/(Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax))	-115.03	-9.34	-103.83	-99.56	-189.71
6	Equity Share capital	300.89	300.89	300.89	300.89	300.89
7	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance Sheet of the previous year	236.59	351.62	340.40	236.59	336.15
8	Earning per Share (face Value of Rs. 10/- each) (not annualised)					
	1. Basic	3.91	-3.58	-4.14	3.05	-7.90
	2. Diluted	3.91	-3.58	-4.14	3.05	-7.90

NOTES :
1. The above is an extract of the detailed format of Annual Financial Results for the quarter and year ended March 31, 2026, filed with the Stock Exchange under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Annual Financial Results are available on the Stock Exchange website www.bseindia.com. The same is also available on the Company's website www.jindalleasefin.com
2. The above results duly reviewed by the Audit Committee, were approved by the Board of Directors in their meeting held on 08.04.2026.

Date : 08.04.2026
Place : New Delhi

For Jindal Leasefin Limited
Sd/-
(SURENDER KUMAR JINDAL)
Managing Director

China-mediated Pak-Afghan talks end without a deal

KJM VARMA ■ Beijing

The week-long China-mediated talks between Pakistan and Afghanistan to end fighting concluded without an agreement, with Beijing maintaining that Islamabad and Kabul have agreed to explore a "comprehensive solution" to resolve their differences.

Representatives from China, Afghanistan and Pakistan held informal talks from April 1 to 7 in Urumqi, the provincial Capital of China's Xinjiang Uygur Autonomous Region, Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Mao Ning said on Wednesday.

The China-facilitated talks were the first major diplomatic engagement between the two neighbours since Pakistan launched Operation Ghazab lil-

Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Mao Ning

Haq in late February to target alleged terrorist hideouts in Afghanistan. Pakistan accuses the Taliban-led Afghan government of sheltering the members of the banned Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) and Baloch Liberation Army (BLA) militant groups, which are carrying out insurgency in Pakistan with recurring attacks in several provinces.

Mao said officials from the three sides had candid and pragmatic discussions in a good atmosphere, following a problem-focused, result-oriented, and action-driven approach.

The three sides stressed that dialogue and consultation are the viable and effective way to resolve complex international disputes, including that of Pakistan and Afghanistan, she said. They agreed to explore a comprehensive solution to address issues in Afghanistan-Pakistan relations, identifying both core and priority concerns, Mao said. Asked whether Pakistan and Afghanistan have agreed to meet again, Mao said, "I think it is important consensus to stay in touch, and the Urumqi process is quite meaningful. We can expect more communication at all levels in future." China emphasised that terrorism is a core issue affecting Afghanistan-Pakistan relations, Mao said, without explicitly backing Islamabad's allegations of Kabul sheltering militant groups.

Last month, UN experts urged the two nations to commit to a permanent ceasefire, while adding that Pakistan had not published credible evidence that the Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) attacks within its territory were directed or controlled by the de facto Afghan authorities.

The report, released by the UN human rights office of the high commissioner, said that attack on Afghanistan violates the prohibition on the use of force under Article 2 of the United Nations Charter and international law. (*PTI*)

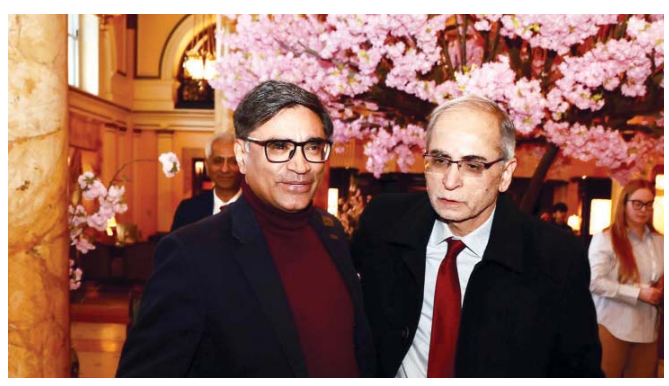
Foreign Secretary Misri launches India-US trade facilitation portal

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri on Wednesday launched the India-US Trade Facilitation Portal here as the two countries eye the $500 billion bilateral trade target.

Misri, who is on a three-day visit to the US, launched the portal at a virtual event that was attended by India's Ambassador to the US Vinay Mohan Kwatra, and officials and trade representatives from the two countries.

"It will serve as a bridge ensuring continuity and ensuring that existing supply chains are reinforced, and at the same time will enable new commercial linkages to emerge and



Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri with Ambassador of India to the United States, Vinay Mohan Kwatra, during his three-day visit to Washington DC AP

grow," Misri said. Misri on Wednesday began his three-day visit to the US to meet with senior officials to review bilateral trade and defence relations and discuss global developments, including the crisis in the Middle East.

Misri's visit comes as both the US and India work to stabilise the ties after a spell of uncertainty and strain. The relations witnessed a major downturn after Washington imposed punitive tariffs on New Delhi and President Donald Trump made controversial assertions regarding his role in de-escalating the India-Pakistan military clashes last May.

In February, the US and India reached a framework for an Interim Agreement regarding reciprocal and mutually beneficial trade (Interim Agreement). The visit comes hours after the US and Iran agreed to a conditional two-week ceasefire that included the opening of the Strait of Hormuz for shipping.

Misri's visit "offers an opportunity to review with our US partners the full breadth of the India–US partnership, and to advance discussions across key pillars of our bilateral agenda - including trade, defence, technology, and exchange perspectives on regional and global developments," Kwatra said in a post on X. Misri's visit comes as both sides work to stabilise the ties after a spell of uncertainty and strain.

The relations witnessed a major downturn after Washington imposed punitive tariffs on India and President Donald Trump made controversial assertions regarding his role in de-escalating the India-Pak military clashes last May. (*PTI*)

Did Trump's Iran war optics collapse after Pakistan's move?

SURJIT SINGH FLORA

Donald Trump built much of his public image on a single promise: he could issue hard threats, move fast, and still control how a crisis ended. The Iran episode weakened that claim. Five weeks into the campaign, he no longer looked like the figure setting the pace.

What made the moment more damaging was Pakistan's place in it. During Operation Sindoor, Trump cast himself as the steady hand who stepped in and helped Pakistan avoid disaster. Now the picture looked reversed. Pakistan appeared to help create an exit from a clash that Trump could not shape on his own.

At its core, this was less about battlefield lines and more about who seemed forced to give way.

The argument turns on optics and bargaining power, not on any formal ruling over victory or defeat. Still, politics runs on what people can see, and by that measure Trump's Iran war no longer looked like a clear show of force.

His opening stance was blunt. Iran was expected to retreat, reopen the Strait of Hormuz on demand, and absorb pressure without setting conditions. That did not happen. Iran's nuclear program was not broken in a way Trump could present as final. The Strait stayed under Tehran's effective control. Then the White House shifted from threats of destruction to a pause and talks.

That shift mattered because Trump had sold escalation as proof of command. A leader can change course and still come out ahead, but only when the new terms look chosen, not imposed. Here, they did not. Iran kept speaking as if it still had options, while Trump seemed more eager for a halt than he had at the start.

At first, Trump's message was simple: open the Strait at once or face massive force. The point was to project dominance. It also left little room for doubt.

Iran did not accept that demand. Instead, Tehran tied safe passage to its own armed forces and to technical and security terms that it said it would manage. In plain terms, Iran did not act like a state surrendering under pressure. It acted like a state that still controlled the chokepoint.

That mattered because the Strait of Hormuz was not a side issue. It was the pressure point. If Iran could still shape movement there, then Trump's threats had not produced the clear compliance he wanted.

The next problem was both visual and political. Trump's language began with destruction. Later, it gave way to a two-week pause in strikes and talks linked to an Iranian framework.

Iran presented that pause as a sign of confidence, not weakness. Its message stayed firm: attacks had to stop, Iran's red lines would remain, and any talks would happen on terms it could accept. That framing helped Tehran look steady, while Trump looked as though he was stepping back from his own toughest line.

Even if the pause helped prevent a wider war, it still weakened the strongman image Trump likes to sell. He had promised pressure that would break resistance. What emerged instead looked like pressure that ended in bargaining.

A retreat is one thing. A retreat that runs through a country once treated as dependent is far worse. That is why Pakistan's role made the episode so uncomfortable for Trump.

During Operation Sindoor, Trump presented himself as the one adult in the room. He praised Pakistan's leaders, spoke as though disaster had been avoided because they turned to him, and wrapped the moment in his favorite message: only he could make the right calls at the right time. In that story, Pakistan looked like the side that needed help. Now that image had flipped. Reports and public statements pointed to Pakistan as part of the channel that carried messages, bought time, and helped reduce the chance of a wider war. Trump publicly thanked Pakistan's Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif and Field Marshal Asim Munir. Iran, for its part, also suggested that Pakistan helped open space for de-escalation. That reversal hit Trump where he's always been most exposed, his brand. He had cast himself as the man who stepped in during the India-Pakistan crisis around Operation Sindoor, praised Pakistan's leaders, and claimed his involvement stopped a disaster. Yet the story flipped fast, and he no longer looked like the saviour of Islamabad. Instead, he looked like a president who needed Islamabad's help to retreat.

The fine details mattered less than the image. Pakistan looked relieved to have Washington engage. Trump looked calm, decisive, and bigger than the crisis itself. He sounded like the only leader who could talk tough, make a few calls, and come out looking stronger than when he began.That story worked because it placed Pakistan beneath him in the chain of power. Trump was the fixer. Pakistan was the uneasy state that benefited from his reach. This time, Pakistan did not look like a client waiting for rescue. It looked like a broker. That is a very different image. Trump's public thanks made that clear because they suggested dependence, not command.

At the same time, Iran's side said Pakistan helped pass messages and reduce the risk of a broader war. The United States also seemed to make formal outreach. Islamabad then gained room to act as a go-between and, by some accounts, to host or support talks.

That is what made the reversal so awkward. Trump once used Pakistan to enlarge his own image. Now Pakistan enlarged its own relevance by helping manage Trump's problem.

The Strait of Hormuz shaped the entire episode because oil markets and shipping react quickly to any threat there. A state that can still affect that chokepoint does not look cornered. It looks dangerous, controlled, and hard to force.

That gave Iran political space. Tehran could say it did not want a wider war while still warning that attacks would bring a response. In that frame, restraint looked like a choice, not surrender. Trump, by contrast, no longer looked like the side controlling the pace.

Pakistan's role also revealed something familiar about its statecraft. Islamabad did not come out looking principled or consistent. It looked transactional, skilled at brokering in tense moments and quick to turn danger into diplomatic value. Iran's public line was sharp but measured. It said it would defend its sovereignty, answer attacks, and keep the door open to talks if attacks stopped. That helped The Tehran project balance. In political terms, that was smart. Iran looked neither reckless nor submissive. It looked like a state willing to negotiate without first accepting humiliation. That cut into Trump's core image as the leader who could escalate and still emerge stronger.

The biggest loss was not only military or diplomatic. It was personal and symbolic. Trump no longer looked like the leader who could threaten, escalate, and walk away taller.

Meanwhile, Pakistan looked like what it often looks like in regional crises, a state that survives by brokering between rivals. That may give it relevance, but it does not make it principled. In this case, it made Trump's loss of face even harder to hide. Trump didn't just fail to break Iran's resistance on the terms he set. In the end, he also had to edge toward a way out shaped by pressure from allies, rivals, and events he couldn't control. That mattered because his public image rested on force, command, and personal dealmaking. Instead, he looked boxed in, with fewer choices than he claimed. That's why the embarrassment hit so hard, it wasn't only a failed threat but a very public loss of control.

The same Pakistan he once used to boost his image became part of the path out. That reversal damaged Trump's central political story, the claim that every crisis bends to his will.

Pakistan, for its part, turned regional danger into fresh relevance once again. Trump lost the image battle, and Islamabad helped make that loss visible.

Surjit Singh Flora is a freelance writer and journalist who lives in Brampton, Canada. He is the author of the book "The Challenge and The Opportunity."

Bali extradites Scottish crime boss to Spain

NINIEK KARMINI
■ Jakarta

Indonesian authorities on Wednesday extradited an alleged Scottish crime boss to Spain, after his removal was delayed multiple times as police pursued an ongoing investigation, officials said.

Steven Lyons, 45, described by law enforcement as a senior figure in an international crime syndicate, was flown from Indonesia to Amsterdam early Wednesday morning, said Husnan Handano, a spokesperson for the island of Bali's immigration office.

From there, he was to be transferred onward to Spain to face charges related to drug trafficking and money laundering, Handano said.

Lyons was arrested on March 28 upon arrival at Bali's Ngurah Rai International Airport from Singapore after Indonesia's immigration system flagged him through an Interpol Red Notice issued at Spain's request. A Red Notice is an international alert seeking the arrest of a suspect for extradition.

Alleged to be the leader of the Lyons crime family, Lyons has been wanted by authorities in Spain and Britain. He has been on Spain's wanted list for about two years, following a killing there in 2024.

Bali Police Chief Daniel Adityajaya said Lyons' arrest was part of a joint investigation involving Indonesian, Spanish and Scottish authorities. Police in Indonesia allege Lyons led a transnational criminal network, operating out of Scotland, that controlled narcotics trafficking routes between Spain and the UK. Authorities also suspect the group laundered money through shell companies across Europe and the Middle East, including in Spain, Scotland, England, Dubai, Qatar, Bahrain and Turkey.

Prior to his arrest in Bali, police in Scotland and Spain carried out raids linked to the investigation that resulted in multiple arrests. Additional suspects were detained in Turkey, the Netherlands and the United Arab Emirates.

Lyons arrived in Bali with two companions who are believed to be still on the island, although Lyons told authorities he traveled alone, said Bugie Kurniawan, head of the Bali immigration office. He said Spain's Interpol has identified them as members of the same criminal cartel but they are not the targets of any arrest warrants or Interpol Red Notices.

Bali Police spokesperson Ari Sandy refused to comment on the investigation.

Scottish media have reported that Lyons survived a shooting in Glasgow in 2006 that killed his cousin, later moved to Spain and eventually settled in Dubai. Last year, his brother and an associate were shot and killed in what authorities described as a suspected gangland attack at a beachfront bar in Fuengirola, southern Spain. (*AP*)

North Korea fires several ballistic missiles toward sea

HYUNG-JIN KIM/ KIM TONG-HYUNG
■ Seoul

North Korea fired several short-range ballistic missiles toward the sea Wednesday in its second launch event in two days, South Korea's military said, hours after a senior North Korean official released crude insults against Seoul's hopes for warmer relations.

South Korea's Joint Chiefs of Staff said the missiles lifted off from North Korea's eastern coastal Wonsan area and flew about 240 kilometers (150 miles) each in a direction toward the North's eastern waters. It said South Korea maintains a readiness to repel any provocations by North Korea under a solid military alliance with the United States. Seoul later said North Korea fired an additional ballistic missile toward its eastern waters without giving further details.

The South Korean military said it had also detected the launch of an unidentified projectile around North Korea's capital region Tuesday. It said South Korean and US intelligence authorities were analyzing details of Tuesday's launch.

South Korean media reported the previous projectile, also likely a ballistic missile, disappeared from South Korean military radars after displaying an abnormal development in the initial launch stage. This indicated the launch ended in a failure, according to the reports. The back-to-back launches came after North Korea made it clear that it has no intentions of improving ties with South Korea, whose liberal government has steadfastly expressed its hopes to restore long-dormant dialogue.

On Tuesday night, Jang Kum Chol, first vice minister at Pyongyang's Foreign Ministry, said South Korea would always remain the North's "most hostile enemy state." He derided South Korea as "world-startling fools" engaged in wishful thinking over a recent statement by Kim Yo Jong, the influential sister of North Korean leader Kim Jong Un.

After South Korean President Lee Jae Myung expressed regret over alleged civilian drone flights into North Korea, Kim Yo Jong late Monday praised him for what she called honesty and courage, but reiterated a threat to retaliate if such flights recur.

South Korean officials responded by describing Kim Yo Jong's statement as meaningful progress in relations.

Jang said her Statement was intended as a warning. He cited Kim Yo Jong as calling South Korea "the dogs affected by mange that blindly bark to the tune of neighboring dogs" as she criticized it for recently co-sponsoring of a UN human rights resolution on the North's purported human rights violations. (*AP*)

US: Principal shot while protecting students from gunman

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Pauls Valley (US)

A high school principal in Oklahoma was shot in the leg Tuesday after confronting a man who entered the school with a gun, authorities said.

Pauls Valley High School Principal Kirk Moore is in stable condition, and no students were injured in the shooting, according to authorities. The suspect, a 20-year-old former student, was taken into custody, Oklahoma State Bureau of Investigation spokesman Hunter McKee told reporters outside the school.

Moore and other staff members quickly confronted the former student after they noticed he entered the school with a gun, McKee said.

"The subject was able to fire multiple rounds, where the principal was hurt, but no one else was," McKee said. "The actions of the staff and the principal stepping in as soon as they saw a subject with a firearm saved lives today." Oklahoma Gov Kevin Stitt said Moore "acted bravely to protect students' lives" and that he and his wife were praying for his quick recovery.

"I'm thankful for the swift response from law enforcement and school staff, and I'm grateful no students were harmed," he said in a post on the social platform X. Pauls Valley is a community of about 6,000 people 60 miles (96 km) south of Oklahoma City.

Turkiye Police detains 9 over attack outside Israeli Consulate in Istanbul

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Istanbul

Turkish authorities have detained nine people as part of an investigation into an attack on police outside a building housing the Israeli Consulate in Istanbul that left one assailant dead, Turkiye's state-run news agency reported Wednesday.

Two other assailants were wounded and captured during Tuesday's shootout in the city's financial and business district, while two police officers sustained slight injuries, officials said.

Israel had withdrawn its diplomats from Turkiye over security concerns and deteriorating relations with Ankara shortly after the start of the war in Gaza, and officials said the consulate was closed at the time of the attack.

Interior Minister Mustafa Ciftci said one of the assailants had links to a group that he said "exploits religion," without naming the organisation.

The Islamic State group has carried out deadly attacks in Turkiye in the past. Anadolu Agency reported that security forces detained nine suspects in operations conducted in Istanbul as well as in the provinces of Konya and Kocaeli. They were being questioned along with the two injured assailants, the agency reported, without providing further details.

Cifti said the attackers had travelled from the city of Izmit, in Kocaeli province, in a rented car. The two wounded assailants are brothers, identified as Onur C. and Enes C. The first has a criminal record related to drugs.

Israel's Foreign Ministry on Tuesday condemned the attack and praised the Turkish authorities for preventing further violence.

Indian health worker called auntie, wins harassment claim in UK

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ London

An Indian-origin healthcare assistant employed with the UK's National Health Service (NHS) has won a harassment claim over being called "auntie" by a nurse colleague of Ghanaian heritage.

Watford Employment Tribunal Judge George Alliott upheld that Ilda Esteves was harassed on the grounds of age and sex and directed the West London NHS Trust to pay her a total of 1,425.15 pounds in damages for "injury to feelings".A three-judge panel, which heard the case last year and issued detailed reasons behind the judgment last month, accepted that "auntie" is a term of respect for older people in Ghanaian culture. However, staff nurse Charles Oppong was responsible for leading the teams on the ward and should not have made such comments. "We find that Charles Oppong's purpose was probably an offensive attempt at humour," notes the judgment. "We find that the claimant did perceive it as creating an offensive environment.

We find that the circumstances of the comments being made in the office and in the corridor and at handover were such that it had the effect of creating an offensive environment. We find that it was reasonable for the comments to have that effect.

Consequently, the claimant's claim of harassment on this ground succeeds," it reads.

China surpasses US in global approval ratings in 2025: Gallup survey

KJM VARMA ■ Beijing

China has overtaken the US in global approval ratings in 2025 as the disapproval of American leadership under President Donald Trump rose to a record 48 per cent, according to a worldwide survey by Washington-based analytics and advisory firm Gallup.

While neither China nor the US command broad support, the survey found a median of 36 per cent approval rating of China's leadership, compared with 31 per cent for the American leadership.

China's five-percentage-point advantage over the US is the widest Gallup has recorded in China's favour in nearly 20 years, the survey results published on its website said. The recent shift reflects a decline in US ratings alongside an increase for China. Median approval of US leadership fell from 39 per cent in 2024 to 31 per cent in 2025, returning to earlier lows, while China's approval rose from 32 per cent to 36 per cent. At the same time, disapproval of US leadership rose to a record-high 48 per cent while China's disapproval rating remained flat at 37 per cent, according to the survey.

For the past two decades, Gallup has asked residents of every country polled as part of its annual World Poll to rate the leadership of the four leading economic or military powers - the US, China, Russia and Germany.

The latest results are based on Gallup surveys conducted in 2025 in more than 130 countries, it said. The survey, however, predates several major developments in early 2026, including the US decision to withdraw from 66 international organisations in January and the outbreak of war with Iran in late February.

Germany, which was ranked as the most positively viewed major power for nine consecutive years in Gallup's trend, spanning the chancellorships of Merkel, Olaf Scholz and Friedrich Merz, received the highest approval in 2025, at 48 per cent. It is followed by China at 36 per cent, the US at 31 per cent and Russia at 26 per cent. Approval of US leadership declined by 10 points or more in 44 countries between 2024 and 2025, while it increased by a similar amount in only seven. The declines were concentrated among US allies, including many NATO partners.

The US disapproval rating was high in Germany with 39 points, followed closely by Portugal (down 38 points). Several other long-standing US partners - including Canada, the UK and Italy - also showed substantial decreases, the survey said.

At the same time, the US standing improved by more than 10 points among Israelis, marking an exception among the American allies.

Approval of US leadership in Israel, which surged after the October 2023 Hamas attack and then fell sharply in 2024, rebounded to 76 per cent in 2025 after Trump's return to the White House, a 13-point increase, among the highest levels globally.

Overall, China's move ahead of the US more broadly reflects a decline in America's ratings rather than an increase in ratings of China, it said. Approval of China's leadership increased by double digits over the past year in 23 countries. However, many of China's increases occurred in countries where US approval fell, including allies such as the UK, Spain, Italy and Ireland, it said.

The countries and territories most aligned with the US, those that have strong net approval of the US that roughly mirrors their net disapproval of China, span several regions, and include Kosovo, Israel, Poland, Albania and the Philippines, it said. (*PTI*)

PROSPECT

Mega medical, dental camp held in Arunachal Pradesh

Marking the occasion of World Health Day, a Mega Medical and Dental Health Camp was organised on 05–06 April 2026 at Baririjo, Arunachal Pradesh, by Subansiri Healers under the aegis of Spear Corps. The initiative coincided with the vibrant Mopin Festival, further enhancing community participation.The camp witnessed an encouraging response from the local population, with a total of 179 civilians availing healthcare services.

This included 133 beneficiaries at the Medical Camp and 46 at the Dental Camp. The outreach programme was aimed at providing accessible and quality healthcare services to residents in this remote border region.A dedicated team of Army Medical and Dental officers conducted consultations, health screenings and delivered preventive care services. The camp also emphasised health awareness, early diagnosis and timely intervention, thereby contributing to improved health outcomes among the local community.

The initiative reflects the Indian Army's continued commitment towards community welfare and nation-building, particularly in far-flung and underserved areas. By bringing essential healthcare services closer to the people, the Army reinforces its role not only as a guardian of borders but also as a partner in public health and social development. The successful conduct of the camp exemplifies the spirit of military-civil fusion and Service Before Self.

Basketball Court inaugurated at De Paul School in Manipur

The Indian Army inaugurated a Basketball Court at De Paul School, Punipfosemai in Senapati District, Manipur on April 7 to promote sports culture, encouraging youth participation in constructive activities and strengthening community engagement. The court is equipped with standard infrastructure and essential safety features, and is expected to serve as a hub for local sporting activities, training sessions and competitive events. The facility will provide a valuable platform for aspiring players to hone their skills and pursue excellence. The facility, developed under Operation Sadbhavana, has been established as part of outreach initiatives to support youth development and provide improved sporting infrastructure in the region reflecting the continued commitment of the Army towards fostering physical fitness, teamwork and discipline among the youth, while also contributing to promotion of healthy lifestyle in North East.

Pralhad Joshi calls for collective action against illicit trade

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

At a time when India's rapid economic expansion is reshaping consumption patterns and market dynamics, Union Minister of Consumer Affairs, Food & Public Distribution and Minister of New and Renewable Energy Pralhad Joshi described illicit trade as a "shadow economy" while addressing the seminar virtually.

In a special video address at the seminar "Protecting Consumers: Addressing the Threat of Smuggling and Counterfeiting" organised by FICCI CASCADE, the Minister said, "smuggling and counterfeiting are far from victimless crimes. They expose consumers to unsafe, substandard and even toxic products, undermine honest businesses, and erode government revenues that could otherwise be invested in public welfare and infrastructure."

Emphasising that "the objective is not just consumer protection, but consumer prosperity," he pointed to initiatives such as the Central Consumer Protection Authority, the National Consumer Helpline, and the Jago Grahak Jago campaign as key pillars in empowering citizens. Calling for a broader coalition, he added, "When a product is fake, it is not just a business loss—it is a betrayal of consumer trust. Combating this requires shared responsibility across government, industry and society."

(L-R) Nidhi Khare, Secretary, Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food & Public Distribution, Government of India; Anil Rajput, Chairman, FICCI CASCADE and P C Jha, Advisor, FICCI CASCADE & Former Chairman, CBIC

In her inaugural address, Nidhi Khare, Secretary, Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution, Government of India, said "we are living in a time when India has emerged as the world's fourth-largest economy".

She noted that consumer protection has evolved from awareness-building to a technology-enabled system. "From 'Jago Grahak Jago' to AI-driven grievance redressal, we are building a system that is faster, more efficient, and transparent," she said. Highlighting improvements in grievance redressal, she added, "Resolution timelines have come down from 63 days to around 21 days, and in some online cases even within 72 hours."

On the role of digital platforms, she said, "While e-commerce platforms operate at scale and require continuous regulatory engagement, they are also increasingly stepping up—through measures such as delisting and stronger monitoring—to combat counterfeit products." She added that "the challenge extends beyond digital marketplaces into physical supply chains."

She called for a multi-pronged approach, including stronger quality standards, support for MSMEs, greater platform accountability, and enhanced enforcement across both digital and physical markets.

In his welcome address, Anil Rajput, Chairman, FICCI CASCADE, said advancing consumer protection today requires a decisive shift from a reactive approach to a preventive, structured and forward-looking system.

Dr Ashwani Mahajan, National Co-Convener, Swadeshi Jagran Manch, said effectively tackling illicit trade requires strong and sustained political will, decisive policy interventions—such as demonetisation—have previously demonstrated how determined action can disrupt counterfeit and illicit ecosystems. The need to strengthen enforcement mechanisms, particularly at the borders, stating that gaps in customs oversight continue to enable the entry of illicit goods into the domestic market."

P C Jha, Advisor, FICCI CASCADE and Former Chairman, CBIC, provided a comprehensive enforcement and governance perspective, stressing that consumer protection must be seen as an integral pillar of economic policy.

The seminar brought together senior policymakers, judicial leaders, enforcement officials, industry representatives, and consumer organisations to deliberate on the growing threat of illicit trade and the need for stronger consumer-centric frameworks.

NTPC signs non-binding MoU with EDF for nuclear power

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

NTPC Limited has signed a Non-Binding Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with Électricité de France (EDF) to explore cooperation in developing new nuclear power projects in India. This follows approval from the concerned ministries & departments of the Government of India.

The MoU was signed by Arnada Prasad Samal, CGM (Nuclear Cell), on behalf of NTPC, and Vakisasi Ramany, Senior Vice President, International Nuclear Development, on behalf of EDF.

The MoU establishes a framework for both companies to jointly assess the feasibility and approach for collaboration, including understanding EDF's EPR technology and its suitability for Indian requirements, exploring opportunities to maximize localization for large-scale deployment, examining economic and tariff aspects, developing human resource capabilities through training programmes, evaluating potential project sites, and providing technical support as mutually agreed, according to a Press release by NTPC.

This initiative aligns with NTPC's strategy to expand into clean, reliable energy and contribute to India's long-term energy security.

NTPC Limited, India's largest integrated power utility,currently operates more than 89 GW of installed capacity, with another 32 GW under construction. The company has set a target to reach 149 GW of total capacity by 2032, including 60 GW from renewable energy sources.

This includes a balanced mix of thermal, hydro, solar, and wind power plants, ensuring supply of reliable, affordable, and sustainable electricity to the country. Along with power generation, NTPC has ventured into various new business areas, including e-mobility, battery storage, pumped hydro storage, waste-to-energy, nuclear power, and green hydrogen solutions, added the release.

Fenesta expands Haryana footprint with 8th showroom in Gurugram

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Gurugram

Fenesta, India's No. 1 windows & doors brand, has expanded its presence in Haryana with the launch of its new showroom in Gurgaon. Operated by Wintana Masters LLP, the showroom is located at 3015, Cancon Enclave, Sector 4, Gurugram.

The new facility further strengthens Fenesta's commitment to bringing advanced fenestration solutions closer to customers in fast-growing residential and commercial hubs.

The newly launched showroom provides visitors with a comprehensive view of Fenesta's wide product portfolio, including uPVC and Aluminium Windows and Doors, Solid Panel Doors, and Facades.

Conceptualized to address modern architectural requirements and lifestyle preferences, the showroom offers an engaging experience for homeowners, architects, and builders looking for durable, high-performance, and aesthetically appealing window and door solutions.

Speaking on the launch, Saket Jain, Business Head, Fenesta, said, "Gurugram continues to be a significant market driven by rapid urban development and strong demand for premium building solutions. The opening of our new showroom in the city, in collaboration with Wintana Masters LLP, reflects our ongoing efforts to strengthen our presence in Haryana and enhance accessibility for customers in the region. This showroom will allow customers and industry stakeholders to explore Fenesta's innovative product range firsthand and choose solutions best suited to their residential and commercial requirements."

DAILY SUDOKU

					8		5	
	3		9				6	
5			4				8	7
	5	3						
	7		1	6	5		3	
						2	1	
4	6				2			3
	9				3		7	
	1		8					

No.SS2108 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★☆☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

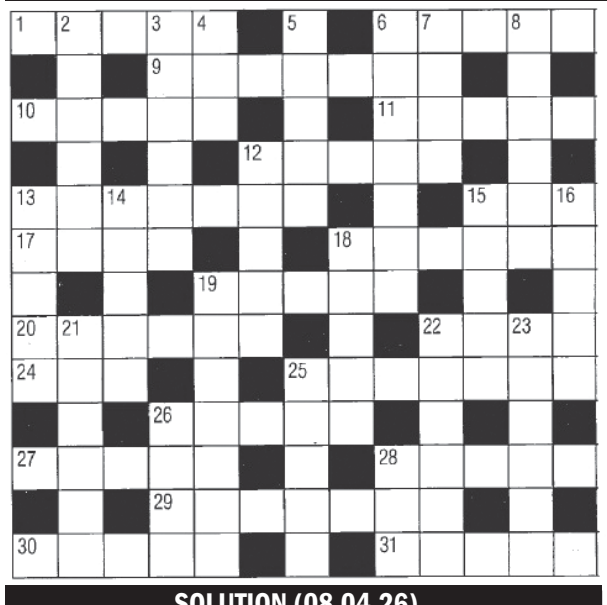
Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction- no maths involved.

SOLUTION (08.04.26)

6	2	8	7	9	3	5	1	4
4	3	7	2	1	5	9	6	8
1	9	5	8	4	6	7	2	3
8	5	3	4	2	9	6	7	1
7	6	9	1	5	8	3	4	2
2	4	1	6	3	7	8	9	5
9	1	6	5	8	2	4	3	7
3	8	4	9	7	1	2	5	6
5	7	2	3	6	4	1	8	9

No.SS2107 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
THURSDAY| APRIL 9, 2026



ACROSS
1 A certain burden is on these vehicles (5)
6 See "9"
9 and 6 Two residences for the Lord Mayor? (7,5)
10 A clever solo for piano shows craft (5)
11 Shots taken in rotation? (5)
12 Displeased with one's mongrel (5)
13 Fun a cleric can maybe rely on (7)
15 Stone in large masses (3)
17 To be candid, there's nothing to write (4)
18 Much fury, some soreness, absolute uproar (6)
19 The novel beauty of Camberwell (5)
20 Compensated cosmetically (4,2)
22 Catherine made history as a survivor (4)
24 An Eskimo has one, but two are normal (3)
25 Has she a fruity voice? (7)
26 One who can train wild trout? (5)
27 It's not right that our Gallic friends are swollen headed (5)
28 Bags of coarse material (5)
29 Piece of silverware in bad condition (7)
30 Little ones can be eaten in numbers (5)
31 Measures for certain areas (5)

DOWN
2 Taking a rest in order to please (6)
3 It's her fault I'm gone! (6)
4 A juicy mug (3)
5 It involves taking too much interest (5)
6 Historic character associated with Tottenham (7)
7 With this burden, you'll never get off to America (4)
8 Criminal said to be poor (6)
12 Muscle trouble put right in camp (5)
13 Presumably spacious accommodation (5)
14 Drive around with Giuseppe (5)
15 Heights in Heligoland, nominally? (5)
16 Short line, about a yard and a bit (5)
18 Saturday night film complaint (5)
19 All the same, they're months (7)
21 The arms position (6)
22 To dad, some yams are fruit! (6)
23 Chanced taking a wild ride round the borders of Suffolk (6)
25 Drive to the outback, in open country (5)
26 Ivan was a terrible one (4)
28 Chuck is bashful (3)

SOLUTION (08.04.26)

ACROSS
3, S-too-p
8, Coven
10, Natal
11, P-in
12, Mater
13, Gra-NT-ed
15, Dig-it
18, Arm
19, Eas-i-L-y
21, Anybody
22, Runt
23, Gene
24, Proffer
26, Pr-E-cis
29, Ian
31, Hal-Al
32, Regency
34, Rabid
35, Rat
36, Bleat
37, Canon
38, Teeth

DOWN
1, Cop-RA
2, Penn-ant
4, Toad
5, One day
6, Par-is
7, Basil
9, Via
12, Members
14, Try
16, Giver
17, Tyres
19, Edified
20, Graph
21, Angel
23, General
24, P-i-late
25, Fag
27, Rally
28, Carat
30, Act-on
32, Rift
33, Nan

Application window for IISER Aptitude Test (IAT) 2026 to close on April 13

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The application window for the IISER Aptitude Test (IAT) 2026 will close on April 13, 2026, marking the final opportunity for students across the country to apply for India's national-level entrance test dedicated to science education and research.

The IISER Aptitude Test (IAT) opens the door to the Indian Institutes of Science Education and Research (IISERs). These institutes have over time become prominent centers for excellence in fundamental science, interdisciplinary learning, and cutting-edge research. Prospective candidates seeking admission to BS-MS (Dual degree) and four-year BS degree programs at IISER Berhampur, IISER Bhopal, IISER Kolkata, IISER Mohali, IISER Pune, IISER Thiruvananthapuram, and IISER Tirupati are encouraged to register for the IISER Aptitude Test (IAT 2026) by visiting the official website https://www.iiseradmission.in/

IMPORTANT DATES

- 13th April: Application Portal Closes
- 16th-18th April: Corrections in Application Forms
- 24th May: Release of Exam Hall Ticket
- 7th June: IISER Aptitude Test (IAT) Examination Date (9:00 am – 12:00 pm IST)

Programmes offered through IAT 2026 include the flagship 5-year BS-MS dual degree programmes across IISERs, along with a growing range of specialized and interdisciplinary courses. These include Computational and Data Sciences at IISER Kolkata, newly introduced majors in Geology and Environmental Sciences at IISER Mohali, and 4-year BS and B.Tech programmes at IISER Bhopal and IISER Tirupati. The programme diversity allows students to pursue pathways across pure sciences, data science, economics, and engineering within a research-focused environment.

NHAI to develop thematic medicinal plantations on land parcels along NHs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

State-owned NHAI said it has taken an initiative to develop 'Arogya Van', thematic medicinal tree plantations on vacant land parcels along National Highways. NHAI, in a statement, said the initiative aims to enrich biodiversity along the National Highways by introducing medicinal tree species that support pollinators, birds and microfauna, thereby strengthening ecosystem resilience. In the first phase of developing 'Arogya Van', an action plan has been formulated covering 17 land parcels, spanning over 62.8 hectares, where around 67,462 medicinal trees will be planted along different National Highway projects in MP, Haryana, Delhi-NCR, Andhra Pradesh, Gujarat, Karnataka, Odisha, Tamil Nadu, Rajasthan, Maharashtra and Chhattisgarh.

Around 36 tree species with medicinal properties, such as Neem, Amla, Imli, Jamun, Lemon, Gular, and Maulsari have been identified and will be planted at land parcels as per suitability to respective agro-climatic zone, statement said.

PARADIP PORT AUTHORITY
PARADIP-754142, ODISHA (INDIA)
(An autonomous body under Ministry of Ports, Shipping & Waterways, Govt. of India)

No:AD/RSC-I-21/16/2013(Pt.-I)/990 Dated, the 2nd April, 2026

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PPA/PR/04/2026-2027
Dt. 07.04.2026

Sd/- Dy. Secretary,
Paradip Port Authority

कार्यालय नगर पालिक निगम, देवास (म.प्र.)
देवास, सिटी ट्रांसपोर्ट सर्विसेज लिमिटेड, देवास (म.प्र.)

क्रमांक/DCTSL/2/2026 देवास, दिनांक 07/04/2021

// निविदा सूचना //

निम्नलिखित कार्य हेतु केन्द्रीयकृत प्रणाली में पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से ऑनलाईन निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती है। निविदा का विस्तृत विवरण https://mptenders.gov.in पर देखा जा सकता है।

क्र.	टेण्डर क्रं. जारी दिनांक	कार्य का नाम	कार्य की समयावधि एवं लागतं	निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य एवं EMD	निविदा की अंतिम तिथि
1	2026 DCTSL 498172_1 07/04/2026	Construction Of E-Bus Depot UNDER P.M. E-BUS SEWA SCHEMEAT	10 Month 113086018/-	30,000/- 565430/-	28/04/2026 06:00 PM

नोट :- निविदा से संबंधित किसी भी प्रकार के संशोधन का प्रकाशन ऑनलाईन ई टेण्डर की https://mptenders.gov.in वेबसाईड पर ही किया जावेगा, पृथक से समाचार पत्र में प्रकाशन नहीं किया जावेगा।

मुख्य कार्यपालन अधिकारी
देवास सिटी. ट्रांसपोर्ट सर्विसेज लिमिटेड,
देवास (म.प्र.)

The Pioneer
NEW DELHI | THURSDAY | APRIL 9, 2026

BRIEFLY

Isak returns to Liverpool for match against PSG

Alexander Isak was included in Liverpool's squad to face Paris Saint-Germain in the first leg of their Champions League quarterfinal on Wednesday. The Sweden striker travelled with the team to Paris after taking part in training on Tuesday. Isak is set to make his return after having surgery in late December on a broken ankle and fibula. Liverpool manager Arne Slot said Isak is fit enough to play but not to start at Parc des Princes. "He finished close to a week of team training sessions, he can play a part otherwise I wouldn't take him," Slot said Tuesday at a pre-game news conference. "We think we can get a performance out of him now, but not to start."
Isak joined Liverpool in the offseason from Newcastle for a British-record fee for 125 million pounds ($170 million). Before the injury, however, he made a slow start, scoring three goals in 16 games overall after netting 62 in 109 matches for Newcastle. His return is also good news for Sweden, which hopes to pair him alongside Arsenal striker Viktor Gyokeres at the World Cup.

Pakistan Hockey Federation to replace head coach

In what has come as a "shock" to the players, the Pakistan Hockey Federation has decided to replace their current head coach, Australia's Colin Batch, with former Olympian Manzoor ul Hasan for the upcoming FIH Pro Nations League and the World Cup. Sources close to the players said they were stunned to learn that instead of Batch, the PHF had gone ahead and named Manzoor as head coach.
Manzoor is a celebrated defender who played in the 70s and 80s. A player, on condition of anonymity. said on Wednesday that the PHF's decision was "recipe for disaster". "We were all happy that Colin Batch who is a qualified coach and aware of the modern day hockey requirements would be guiding us in two major events including the World Cup and now we get this shock," he said. The interim PHF set-up also named a national selection committee headed by another celebrated Olympian Samiullah Khan. The other selectors include Naeem Akhtar, Kashif Jawad, Muhammad Khalid, Nasir Ali and Atif Bashir.One source said the players, some of whom are presently away in foreign leagues, would soon try to speak to the interim President and convince him to hire a foreign coach. Pakistan finally managed to qualify for the World Cup being held in Belgium and the Netherlands in August after eight long years when they played in the final of a qualifying tournament in Egypt.

Romanian soccer great Mircea Lucescu dies

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Bucharest (Romania)

Mircea Lucescu, the Romanian soccer great who was a serial trophy winner as a player and a coach, has died. He was 80.

Lucescu's death was confirmed by Bucharest University Emergency Hospital on Tuesday. He had been hospitalised after reportedly suffering a heart attack on Friday morning.

"Mr Mircea Lucescu was one of the most successful Romanian football coaches and players, the first to qualify the Romanian national team for a European Championship, in 1984," the hospital said in a statement. "Entire generations of Romanians grew up with his image in their hearts, as a national symbol." Lucescu had a lengthy coaching career and was in his second spell with the Romanian national team until stepping down last Thursday after falling ill during training. Three days earlier, Romania had missed out on qualification to the World Cup after losing to Turkey in a playoff.

As a player, Lucescu captained his country at the 1970 World Cup. Lucescu's coaching career spanned almost half a century, from late-1970s Romania to 2026 World Cup qualifying, as Eastern European soccer was transformed by political and economic changes after the fall of communism, and later by the effects of Russia's actions in Ukraine.

Lucescu spent 12 years as coach of Shakhtar Donetsk, where billionaire Rinat Akhmetov's backing assembled a squad filled with up-and-coming Brazilian talents. Lucescu forged a team that became a Champions League regular and won the UEFA Cup in 2009.

By the time Lucescu left in 2016, Shakhtar had left its home city of Donetsk in eastern Ukraine after a takeover by Russia-backed separatists. His later moves to Russia's Zenit St. Petersburg and to Shakhtar's bitter Ukrainian rival Dynamo Kyiv were less well-received by Shakhtar fans. Internationally, Lucescu coached Turkey as well as Romania. His second spell with Romania started in 2024, 38 years after he'd left the national team the first time. His last game was the loss to Turkey.

Lucescu coached Pisa, Brescia, Reggiana and Inter Milan in Italy and is remembered fondly in the north of the country, especially at Brescia — despite his tenure being marked by several ups and downs.

His team there was dubbed Brescia Romeno after Lucescu signed four of his compatriots, including one of Romania's greatest ever players Gheorghe Hagi — between stints at Barcelona and Real Madrid.

Divya Deshmukh storms into joint lead

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Paphos (Cyprus)

Indian chess sensation Divya Deshmukh pulled off a superb turnaround converting what looked like a certain draw into victory to climb into joint lead, while compatriot R Praggnanandhaa saw his title hopes take a major hit after a loss against Dutch Grandmaster Anish Giri in the eighth round, leaving him almost out of contention for a top finish in the Candidates tournament here.

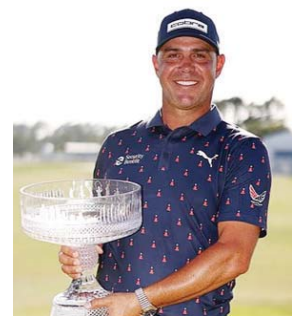
In the women's section World Cup winner Deshmukh turned the tables on overnight leader Anna Muzychuk to jump into joint lead with four others including the Ukrainian on 4.5 points from what had seemed a difficult position to defend. Deshmukh did well to fight on and equalise and then capitalised on an unforced error by her opponent in the queen-and-pawns endgame to score a vital victory. The other Indian, R Vaishali drew with Bibisara Assaubayeva of Kazakhstan to join Deshmukh, Kateryna Lagno of Ukraine, China's Zhu Jiner and Muzychuk in the lead on 4.5 points after eight games.

The event is wide open now with Jiner giving a knockout blow to the hopes of her Chinese compatriot Tan Zhongyi to move to 4.5 points while Kateryna defeated fellow Russian Aleksandra Goryachkina.

I thought people were trying to kill me, says Gary Woodland

DAVE SKRETTAAP
Augusta (USA)

Gary Woodland was playing the back nine at the Houston Open a couple of weeks ago, an event he would ultimately win to secure his return trip to the Masters, when the former US Open champion began to feel what he described as "hypervigilant."



"I battled the last 10 holes," Woodland revealed Tuesday, "thinking people were trying to kill me."

That's not intended to be a joke. The exact opposite, in fact: a powerful admission of Woodland's mental health struggles, and one he hopes will help others dealing with trauma, anxiety and post-traumatic stress disorder in their own lives.

The inner turmoil that Woodland feels even at Augusta National, one of the most bucolic places in the world, has its roots in a scan that uncovered a lesion on his brain that had been causing him unfounded fears of dying. In September 2023, he wrote letters to his wife and kids in the event something went wrong, then had surgery to remove as much of it as possible.

The procedure involved cutting a baseball-sized hole from the side of his head, but it proved to be successful. Woodland was back on the course in January 2024, slowly working his way back into form, making enough cuts to keep him motivated.

The following year, he finished second at the Houston Open — the same tournament he would win last month, when Woodland got through his Friday bout of hypervigilance and closed with a 3-under 67 on Sunday for a five-shot win over Nicolai Hojgaard.

Arsenal beats Sporting Lisbon 1-0 in Champions League quarterfinals

JAMES ROBSONAP
London

A second straight Champions League semifinal is in sight for Arsenal. Kai Havertz scored in stoppage time on Tuesday to seal a 1-0 win over Sporting Lisbon at Estadio Jose Alvalade to put Mikel Arteta's team in control of the quarterfinal tie.

The substitute fired past goalkeeper Rui Silva from close range to give Arsenal the advantage ahead of next week's second leg at the Emirates. In Tuesday's other quarterfinal, Bayern Munich beat Real Madrid 2-1 at the Bernabeu. Havertz settled a tight game in Portugal by combining with fellow substitute Gabriel Martinelli in the first minute of added time. With one touch the German controlled Martinelli's defense-splitting pass in the box and then converted with a side-footed finish.

"To score a late goal is always nice," Havertz told Amazon Prime. "We will take that result. There is still a lot of work to do next week."

Victory saw Arsenal bounce back from successive defeats which cut its quadruple trophy hunt in half in recent weeks. Losses in the League Cup final and FA Cup quarterfinals had shaken the Premier League leader going into Tuesday's match.

And it had to withstand an early charge from Sporting in front of a raucous crowd, with player-of-the-match David Raya producing an outstanding save to tip

Maximiliano Araujo's sixth-minute shot onto the bar.

"It could have changed the tie," Arteta said. Arsenal also hit the bar in the first half direct from Noni Madueke's corner, but both teams struggled to create openings. Martin Zubimendi thought he'd found the breakthrough in the second half with a curling effort from range only for the goal to be ruled out for offside. Late on, Raya produced a string of saves. First he pushed away a goal-bound header from Geny Catamo and then pulled off a double stop to deny Catamo again and Luis Suarez. "For me, the last two seasons, he's the best keeper in the world. He has saved us so many times," Havertz said.

But it was Havertz who delivered the goal that pushed Arsenal a step closer to another semifinal, having lost to eventual champion Paris Saint-Germain at that stage last year. The forward scored the winner for Chelsea in the Champions League final in 2021 and this was another decisive moment for him in this competition.

"He loves the big occasion and the big games," Arteta said. "And that's what we need - the big players to turn up when we need them." Defeat was Sporting's first at home since August. The Portuguese team has never advanced beyond the quarterfinals of the Champions League. "A small lapse in concentration cost us dearly, and it's frustrating because it happened in the 90th minute, but we have to lift our heads and move on," coach Rui Borges told Sport TV.

The scenes of celebration for Arsenal's players were in stark contrast to the dejection that followed the League Cup final loss to Manchester City and the shock of being beaten by second-division Southampton in the FA Cup on Saturday. "We had to reveal ourselves today and I talked about identity and other things that we are as a team and that I definitely saw," Arteta said. "It's halftime. We are a step closer, now we need to finish the tie at home in front of our people, and if we do that, we're going to start to dream."

Bayern stuns Real Madrid in Champions League quarterfinals

TALES AZZONIAP
Madrid

Harry Kane delivered for Bayern Munich on his return from injury, scoring a goal and helping set up another in his team's 2-1 win at Real Madrid in the first leg of the Champions League quarterfinals on Tuesday.

Kylian Mbappe scored Madrid's goal after the visitors had taken a two-goal lead at the Santiago Bernabeu stadium. Kane had been listed as a gameday decision after missing the team's Bundesliga match last weekend because of an ankle injury. The result left Bayern with an edge ahead of the second leg in Germany next week as it tries to reach the

Champions League semifinals for the first time since 2023-24, when it was eliminated by eventual champion Madrid. "We are still alive, clearly," Madrid coach Alvaro Arbeloa said. "We are one goal away. We have shown that we can win anywhere. We showed it with the scoring chances that we had against an opponent that we knew was going to make it difficult for us."

Arsenal won 1-0 at Sporting Lisbon in the other quarterfinal on Tuesday.

On Wednesday, Barcelona will host Spanish rival Atletico Madrid, and Liverpool will visit defending champion Paris Saint-Germain.

Madrid and Bayern are playing their sixth knockout-stage meeting in 14 seasons, with the Spanish powerhouse having won four of their five two-leg matchups since the 2011-12 season.

Kane participated in the build up of Bayern's first goal in the 41st minute, exchanging passes with Serge Gnabry who ultimately fed a through ball for Luis Diaz inside the area. The Colombia forward calmly sent a low shot past Madrid goalkeeper Andriy Lunin. Kane scored himself in the 46th with a nice one-timer from the top of the area, firmly finding the corner with a low strike. It was his 11th Champions League goal, equaling his best scoring season in the European tournament. He finished with 11 goals in 2024-25.

Kane has scored 22 Champions League goals since the start of the 2024-25 season, the most of anybody.

Mbappe scored his 20th Champions League goal since the start of the 2024-25 season in the 74th, finding the net from close range after a pinpoint low cross by Trent Alexander-Arnold.

Mbappe leads the scoring this season with 14 goals, which is double the forward's total last season. He is three goals shy of the most goals in a single Champions League campaign achieved by Cristiano Ronaldo with Madrid in 2013-14.

Liverpool aims to stop slide against PSG

JEROME PUGMIREAP
Paris

Out of the Premier League title race. Routed in the FA Cup. Mounting questions over the manager's future. A star striker set to leave. A disgruntled captain saying his team gave up.

Liverpool heads into the first leg of its Champions League quarterfinal against Paris Saint-Germain on Wednesday in disarray.

"We need 90 minutes full energy and full commitment otherwise we will have no chance," Liverpool attacking midfielder Florian Wirtz said Tuesday at a news conference. Liverpool manager Arne Slot knows what to expect from the outset at

Parc des Princes. "PSG under (coach) Luis Enrique do not give you a second to have the ball comfortable on your feet," Slot said, calling PSG one of the top two sides in the world from open play. "It's press, press, press every second of the game."

But Slot hopes six-time champion Liverpool can draw on its vast European experience to keep the tie alive heading to Anfield for next Tuesday's second leg.

"We've shown a few times we can do special things in difficult circumstances," he said. "The answer is already in the history of Liverpool, but it's easier said than done."

Roles reversed: It was a far different dynamic when the sides met in the last 16 last year. Back then, Liverpool was romping to the Premier League title, new manager Slot was the toast of the city and Mohamed Salah was at his brilliant best. By contrast, PSG struggled to get out of the Champions League group stage and observers were questioning Luis Enrique's methods.

Ayush stuns Lin in Asia Championships opener

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Ningbo (China)

India's Ayush Shetty stunned world number 7 Lin Shi Feng of China in straight games to enter the second round of the men's singles competition at the Badminton Asia Championships on Wednesday. World number 25 Ayush, who had won the US Open Super 300 title last year, registered a 21-13 21-16 victory in 51 minutes.

Lin raced to a 4-1 lead early on, but Ayush clawed back to level at 7-7 before gradually taking control to pocket the opening game. After the change of sides, the Chinese again moved ahead 4-1 and

extended it to 12-9, but Ayush turned the tide with a six-point burst to surge to 18-13.

Lin closed the gap to 16-18, but the Indian held his nerve to shut the door on his fancied opponent. Dinesh Khanna remains the only Indian to win the men's singles gold at the continental meet in 1965, while Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty claimed the doubles crown in 2023.

Collin Morikawa's ailing back is feeling better, body still in a state of flux

DAVE SKRETTAAP
Augusta (USA)

Collin Morikawa has been hitting balls for about a week after dealing with a back injury, and while the two-time major winner admitted he's "not exactly where I want to be," he plans to be standing on the first tee box for his sixth Masters on Thursday.

"It's unfortunate," Morikawa said, "but that's just the body, and I can't push it. It's been a little bit of a mental battle, I think, just trying to trust with where it's at. The back actually feels fine. It's just other parts of the body not cooperating a little bit how I want."

The world's No. 7 player withdrew after one hole at

The Players Championship because of back spasms, and he didn't play at the Texas Open last week, choosing instead to get treatment in the hopes of being ready for Augusta National.

Morikawa has made the cut in each of his appearances, tying for third in 2024 and finishing in the top 10 three times.

"This isn't a place where you want to be uncomfortable, but sometimes you've got to find other ways to get around a golf course," he said. "It's a work in progress. But each day just staying positive, trying to get through it."

Negotiating tactics: Scottie Scheffler and his wife, Meredith, recently welcomed their second child, Remy, news that did not come out for about nine days. In the case of Bennett, their 2-year-old, the couple waited five days before announcing his birth in an Instagram post.

There is a very simple reason for the delay.

"There's no reason that my kids need to be on TV or on my Instagram or whatever it is," the two-time Masters champion said Tuesday. "I feel like my kids need to have a normal upbringing, or as normal as I can, and we'll go from there."

That "normal upbringing" could prove to be a challenge. Their dad happens to be one of the biggest stars in golf, if not all of sports, and he's recognized just about everywhere he goes. He has more than $100 million in career earnings.

"Bennett is still 2," Scheffler said, "so the hard parenting hasn't really started yet. It's more bargaining at this point." What kind of bargaining? "Last night we were leaving a Nike party and he somehow ended up with two sugar cookies, and he hadn't eaten his dinner yet," Scheffler said. "It was like, Alright, buddy, if you eat these sausages, I will give you this cookie.' He's like, Cookie!' I'm like, If you eat this.' My buddies are sitting there watching — Yep, I've seen this movie before.' It's bargaining."

Tee times: Masters rookie John Keefer and Haotong Li will be the first pair off on Thursday once Jack Nicklaus, Gary Player and Tom Watson hit the ceremonial first tee shots, while most of the featured groups begin their rounds a couple of hours later. The tee times were released on Tuesday.

Defending champion Rory McIlroy, red-hot Cameron Young and US Amateur champ Mason Howell are in a group at 10:31 am. local time. Bryson DeChambeau, Matt Fitzpatrick and Xander Schauffele are two groups ahead of them, while Morikawa, former champion Hideki Matsuyama and Russell Henley are sandwiched in between.

The Pioneer
NEW DELHI | THURSDAY | APRIL 9, 2026

Gujarat Titans beat Delhi Capitals by a run in a thriller game

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

Gujarat Titans beat Delhi Capitals by one run despite KL Rahul's heroic 92 off 52 balls in an Indian Premier League match here on Wednesday. Needing two off two balls to reach the victory target of 211, David Miller had a brain-fade moment when he refused a single of the penultimate delivery from Prasidh Krishna and then missed the last delivery with Kuldeep Yadav failing to beat Jos Buttler's direct throw.

Shubman Gill led from the front with a belligerent half-century to help GT post 210 for four..

Besides Gill (70 off 45 balls; 4x4s, 5x6s), Jos Buttler also chipped in with an aggressive 52 off 27 deliveries while Washington Sundar made a fiery 55 off 32 balls after the Capitals opted to bowl.

For DC, Mukesh Kumar (2/55) and Lungi Ngidi (1/24) were the pick of the bowlers.

Chasing, Rahul's knock went in vain but his 76-run opening partnership in 8.1 overs with Pathum Nissanka (41 off 24) gave momentum to DC's chase.

But thereafter, none of the DC batters could produce substantial scores before David Miller's unbeaten 20-ball 41 kept them in the hunt till the last ball.

Earlier in the game, Jos Buttler returned to his ballistic ways with a six laden half century before captain Shubman Gill changed gears for a well made fifty, powering Gujarat Titans to 210 for four against hosts Delhi Capitals in the IPL here on Wednesday.

Buttler (52 off 27), who had a forgettable T20 World Cup in India, finally found the form he is known for. Besides Buttler and Gill (70 off 45), Washington Sundar (55 off 32) contributed with third fifty of the innings..

When Buttler is at his best, the former England captain hits sixes for fun and he smashed five of them at the Kotla. Four of those maximums came off medium pacer Mukesh Kumar (2/55 in 4 overs), who had an off day after starring in the previous game against Mumbai Indians.. Buttler went hard at Mukesh in the fifth over of the innings, collecting 23 runs via three hits that went all the way. One was over fine leg after he shuffled across the stumps, the second was a massive strike that reached the top tier of the 'Gautam Gambhir Stand' and three balls later, he targetted the extra cover region.

Buttler's onslaught helped Delhi Capitals reached 68 for one in the powerplay. He was dismissed against the run of play, off a long hop from Kuldeep Yadav.

Gill, a mere spectator when Buttler was batting, took the onus on himself to clear the ropes after Buttler's departure. Four of his five sixes came off India teammate Kuldeep with the Titans captain using the slog sweep effectively against the wrist spinner.

Titans have been labelled as a top heavy team with middle order not being tested enough. Washington Sundar on Wednesday played his part well at number four.

The southpaw picked the mid-wicket boundary against the spinners especially Vipraj Nigam who leaked 23 runs in the 12th over.

Washington reached his half century with a six over deep square leg off T Natarajan. At 161 for two in 15 overs, Titans were on course for 220 but fell short.

Lungi Ngidi was the pick of the bowlers for Delhi Capitals, ending with frugal figures of 24 for one in four overs.

Mahela concedes MI blown away by Sooryavanshi, Jaiswal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Guwahati

Mumbai Indians (MI) head coach Mahela Jayawardene admitted his side was blown off course by a blistering onslaught from Rajasthan Royals openers Yashasvi Jaiswal and Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, saying the bowlers missed their lines and lengths on a night when even Jasprit Bumrah "probably missed the length by a little bit".

Mumbai Indians suffered a 27-run defeat in a rain-curtailed IPL clash as Jaiswal and Sooryavanshi lit up the night with a blistering display that powered Rajasthan Royals to 150 for 3 in 11 overs before their bowlers tightened the screws to restrict Mumbai Indians to 123 for 9 on Tuesday night.

This was MI's second loss after starting the season with a win over Kolkata Knight Riders.

"We were not good enough, and that's what we have to work on. I think we had some plans, but...we never executed those plans the way we wanted. These guys are batting really well. We knew the danger, especially when rain curtailed (the match), and you have the license to go up front.

"We needed to make sure that first four, five overs were crucial for us. And, yeah, I think we missed our lengths, we missed our lines, and they played really, really well," said the former Sri Lankan batter.

He added that even a bowler of Bumrah's calibre had to struggle against the onslaught of the two RR openers, who together scored a blazing 80 runs in the first five overs, with Jaiswal making an unbeaten 77 off 32 balls and Sooryavanshi 39 off 14.

"I think we all knew his (Sooryavanshi's) great talent from the way he went about last year. We managed to control him last season. And every match, it's a challenge.

"Bumrah probably missed the length by a little bit, and he was ready for this. So, yeah, it'll be fascinating to see how he evolves. But definitely, you know, he really took our bowlers down," added Jayawardene.

However, much of RR's total came from Jaiswal's batting, and Jayawardene said that it was the batter who truly took the game away.

Mumbai Indians lacked purpose and intent with ball: Anil Kumble

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

Mumbai Indians (MI) appeared to lack intent and purpose in their 27-run defeat to Rajasthan Royals (RR), said former India captain Anil Kumble as he lauded young swashbuckler Vaibhav Sooryavanshi for his "brilliant" offensive against pace ace Jasprit Bumrah in an IPL clash in Guwahati.

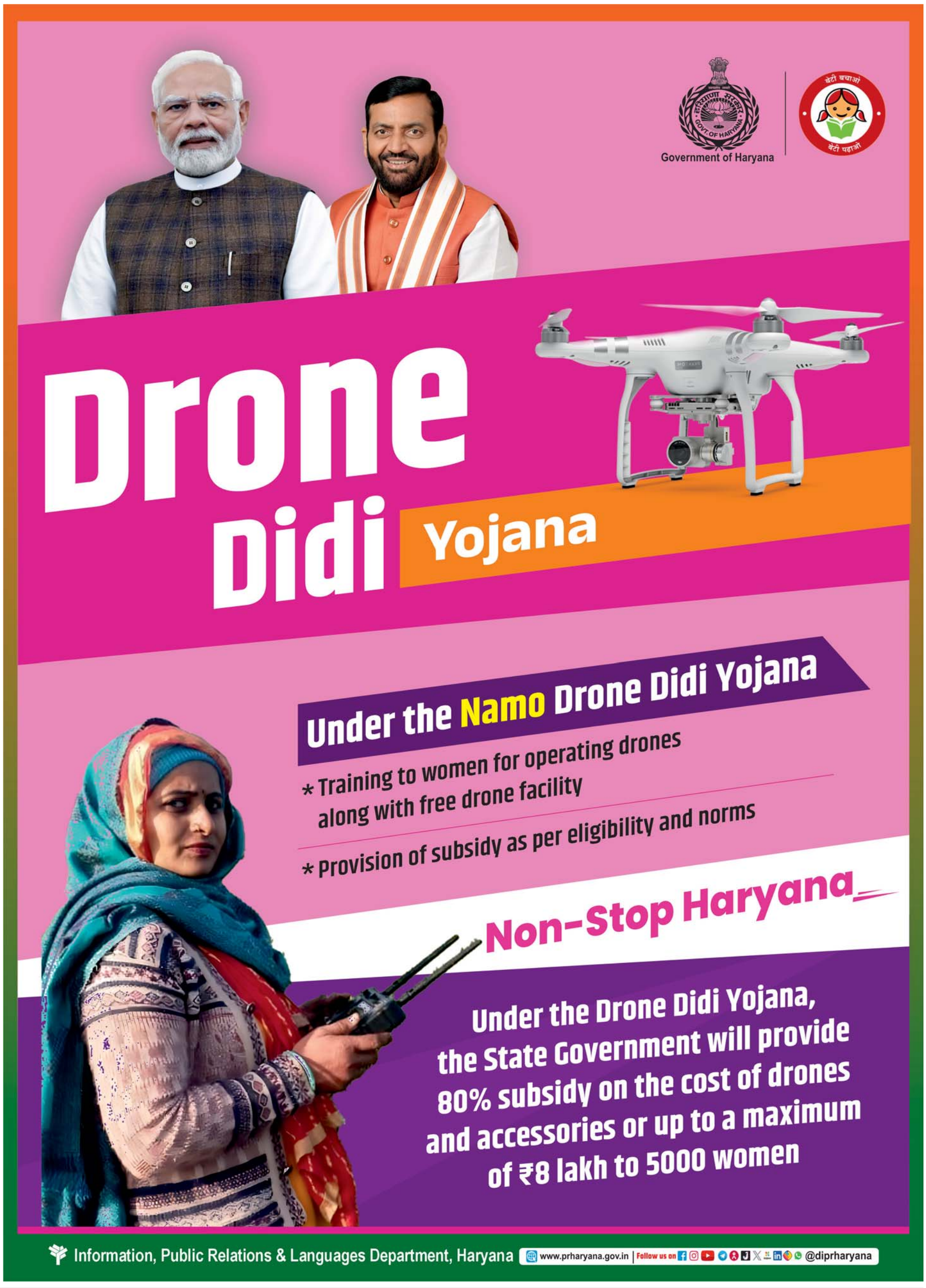
RR cruised to the comfortable win over Hardik Pandya's Mumbai Indians, powered by Yashasvi Jaiswal's scintillating unbeaten 77 and Sooryavanshi's 14-ball blitzkrieg of 39. Their performance set the tone for a 150-run total in the rain-shortened, 11-overs-a-side contest.

Mumbai Indians fell well short, restricted to 123 for 9, with their entire top order failing to make an impact. This was Rajasthan Royals' third consecutive win, while MI endured their second loss in three matches.

"It felt like the Mumbai Indians lacked a bit of purpose and intent with the ball, and that certainly spilled over into the batting. It was always going to be a big task to score 151 in 11 overs," said Kumble on 'JioStar'.

Kumble was amazed by how Sooryavanshi confidently took on a bowler of Bumrah's calibre, smashing a six off the very first delivery he faced.

"Sooryavanshi makes it look easy against one of the world's best bowlers. First ball, he hits him (Bumrah) for a six and then sets him up. He set the bowler up, not the other way around.



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